Gone with the Wind — English reception corpus

T01 In defense of Ashley Wilkes

In defense of Ashley Wilkes I've just finished the book, and reading opinions from fans online, I can't believe how different my impression of it was compared to theirs. It's like we read an entirely different story.

My largest divergence from other fans of the book seems to be my interpretation of the character of Ashley Wilkes. What do people on this sub think of him? You can see here: Thread - "Spineless wimp" and "weak" are the near-universal appraisals of him.

This seems to me to be supremely unfair. I'm going to go through a few reasons why,

1. He is genuinely brave and thoughtful

Everyone in the county, and later in Atlanta, likes and greatly respects Ashley. This is not for no reason. His gallantry during the war was renowned, he had the fortitude (and yes, the "gumption" as Scarlett would put it) to walk all the way back from the North after being starved in a prison camp for years, he rides out with the other men to avenge Scarlett and gets shot for it. But he's not addicted to violence and the thrill that goes with it. He is consistently a voice of reason, a moderating influence who restrains the worst impulses of the honour-bound men of his circle.

So what if he prefers books to real people? This made me like him even more. He has some of the most beautiful, poetic, and moving passages in the novel. I'm especially thinking of his conversation with Scarlett while splitting fences:

Scarlett, before the war, life was beautiful. There was a glamour to it, a perfection and a completeness and a symmetry to it like Grecian art. Maybe it wasn't so to everyone. I know that now. But to me, living at Twelve Oaks, there was a real beauty to living. I belonged in that life. I was a part of it. And now it is gone and I am out of place in this new life, and I am afraid. Now, I know that in the old days it was a shadow show I watched. I avoided everything which was not shadowy, people and situations which were too real, too vital. I resented their intrusion. I tried to avoid you too, Scarlett. You were too full of living and too real and I was cowardly enough to prefer shadows and dreams.

How can you be unmoved by this?

By the way - I find it the height of hypocrisy that anyone who sat through a thousand-page novel about the civil war would excoriate a character for living in a dream world. If you fell deeply in love with the world of GWTW, you are far more like Ashley than Scarlett or Rhett, I guarantee it!

2. He's a good influence on Scarlett

Scarlett is one of the most selfish and conceited characters in all of fiction. Though she becomes a "survivor", she burns bridges with almost everyone who ever cared for her. Her single-minded pursuit of money alienates virtually every friend, and ruins the lives of her children and husbands.

We see that Rhett nurses her worst traits in this respect. He pushes her to become worse, more selfish; he attempts to remake her in his own image, that of an amoral scoundrel who profits from the misery of others.

But if Rhett is the "devil" on her shoulder, Ashley is the "angel". It is he who makes Scarlett promise to protect Melanie during her pregnancy. Without this, you can bet that Scarlett would not have dragged her all

the way to Tara after the siege. Ashley cultivates that sense of duty and honour in Scarlett; yes, she idealises him, but her idealisation makes her attempt to be better to be worthy of him.

I also believe that he gets way too much flak for the way he behaves towards Scarlett's affections. Yes, he makes a mistake. Of course he does, and he knows it; every character in the book is flawed and this is his flaw. But he hardly acts as a "cad". As soon as he makes the fatal mistake of kissing Scarlett, he withdraws from her completely to protect Melly. In fact, he does the right thing and tries to leave for New York to remove the temptation forever. It is Scarlett who forces, yes forces, him to stay, by using Melly against him. He doesn't play with Scarlett's heart, Scarlett plays with his.

3. Scarlett's inner monologue is not a reliable narrator

Most of the time, the narrative voice of the novel, when following the point-of-view of a certain character, presents the thoughts, feelings and prejudices of that character. Not only that, it picks up the verbal tics of the character; for example, when it (briefly) follows Mammy, the narrator talks in her distinctive dialect.

So when we come to the final twenty pages of the novel, when Scarlett finally falls out of love with Ashley and runs after Rhett, we are seeing her perspective on his character. It's not objective and it's not supposed to be. Even Rhett feels compelled to step in and defend Ashley from Scarlett's unfair appraisal of him:

"Ashley!" she said, and made an impatient gesture. "I—I don't believe I've cared anything about him for ages. It was—well, a sort of habit I hung onto from when I was a little girl. Rhett, I'd never even thought I cared about him if I'd ever known what he was really like. He's such a helpless, poor-spirited creature, for all his prattle about truth and honor and—"

"No," said Rhett. "If you must see him as he really is, see him straight. He's only a gentleman caught in a world he doesn't belong in, trying to make a poor best of it by the rules of the world that's gone."

In fact, as pointed out at various times by both men, Ashley and Rhett aren't really all that different. They are shadows of each other, but not in the simplistic way that so many seem to think. It's not that Rhett is "strong" and Ashley is "weak", or that Rhett has "gumption" and Ashley doesn't. It's simply that Ashley clings to something higher than himself, while Rhett clings to himself alone. And neither of these paths is better than the other. If Ashley lacks an impulse to act for himself and his own, Rhett lacks the ability to make a true connection; Ashley's path leads to him desolate and purposeless, but Rhett's path leads to sobbing dunkenly into Melly's skirts after wishing his wife a miscarriage.

Ashley and Rhett are both mature, fully-realised men. They're the only men she knows that can resist her and both have great internal strength. That's why she finds them intoxicating:

Only Ashley and Rhett eluded her understanding and her control for they were both adults, and the elements of boyishness were lacking in them.

Scarlett doesn't fall in love with Rhett until she feels like she can't understand him anymore; the night on the staircase, when he becomes like a "stranger", and then in the final scene, where his eyes gain the "remoteness" of Ashley's and he speaks in the same poetic and resigned way as Ashley.

All we are seeing in the final chapters of the book is Scarlett transferring her idealising obsession from Ashley to Rhett. This is another thing which Rhett himself recognises:

"I see you are contemplating the transfer of your tempestuous affections from Ashley to me and I fear for my liberty and my peace of mind. No, Scarlett, I will not be pursued as the luckless Ashley was pursued."

And what is the thing that finally puts Scarlett off Ashley? She rationalises it to herself that it's because of his weakness and childishness, but is it really? She never stopped loving him through all those years of him mismanaging her sawmill. No, the one and only reason she turns against him is that in the wake of Melly's death, she gets final confirmation that he doesn't love her. It's purely selfish on her part. She can't stand the thought of not being adored. If Scarlett deluded herself for years that Ashley would leave Melly for her, that's her issue and hers alone. Realising that it was a fantasy doesn't make Ashley a bad guy.

P.S. I think I noticed a historical error while writing this. Both Ashley and Rhett refer to the fall of the South as a "Gotterdammerung" (twilight of the gods) - as far as I'm aware, this is a translation by Wagner of the term "Ragnarok". But Wagner's Gotterdammerung wasn't released until 1876, ten years after the civil war. So how do the characters in the book know about it?

I absolutely agree with you but there are some definite negative traits about Ashley. As Melanie said with her last breath "He isn't.... practical."

His worst failing was when Scarlett turned to him for help about the taxes and he went into his dreamy monologue as if none of this really mattered. He was relying on Scarlett to provide a home for his family and she was driven to absolute desperation and he completely shrugged off the problem. Twelve Oaks was a burnt out shell, and he wasn't planning to rebuild, but he still had a valuable asset in the land, so he did have a way of helping her. Instead, she had to turn to virtual prostitution in order to keep her home available to him.

Then there were the little things, like when Melanie was struggling for money while they were in Atlanta, but Ashley kept buying crates of expensive books that had to be shipped from the North.

Re Gotterdammerung - good catch! I would assume seeing the opera was based on a legend, and the word is a translation of an old Norse word, the Germans were already using this term before Wagner immortalised it.

I completely agree with you that he has negative traits to his character (they all do, even Melanie). It's just that I think fans are way harsher on him that Rhett or Scarlett, who objectively act much worse at various points of the book! (neglect children, commit murder, cheat in business, work convicts to death etc)

Ashley absolutely does commit murder, he’s an active Klan member. He also wanted to kill the overseer and argued with the Fontaines about it, but in the end he settled for being the wingman. It’s one of the ways in which he isn’t that different from Rhett, they’ll all kill over their sense of honour.

The philosophy concept of the Gotterdammerung" long predates the opera. I always thought Ashley was a good guy, but weak. Like Rhett put it, he couldn't be emotionally faithful to Melanie but couldn't be physically unfaithful. He couldn't fight both Melanie and Scarlett about taking Scarlett's job offer.

I guess this is another way in which he shadows Rhett. Rhett is flagrantly physically unfaithful to Scarlett even as his heart remains hers

But he was physically unfaithful to her- he kissed Scarlett

That's true, but i think Rhett was referring to sexually. Ashley found Scarlett physically attractive and couldn't seem to shake that off

One of my all-time favourite quotes is from Gone with the Wind and is from Ashley's POV: "He had never known such gallantry as the gallantry of Scarlett O'Hara going forth to conquer the world in her mother's velvet curtains and the tail feathers of a rooster".

That’s one of the few times we get Ashley’s POV. I remember noticing that immediately.

I love this also.

Well-written! I’ve always felt Ashley was an interesting character, and I seem to like him more than a lot of this fandom does. One of my favorite parts of the whole book is when he has the doomed conversation with Scarlett just before his birthday party, and they talk about where they are each trying to get in life. It’s one of the few times Scarlett truly self-reflects.

I think I do disagree on your analysis of Scarlett. I don’t think the “one and only” reason she turns on Ashley is because he doesn’t love her. I think that was just the final nail in the coffin that helped her to wake up; she’d been falling out of love with Ashley all throughout part 5. I also don’t think she would’ve actually ever left Melanie behind. Her thoughts and actions towards Melanie often contradict each other.

I think Melanie's death really makes Scarlett appreciate how much she actually loved her

Scarlett has mean thoughts about Melanie during the siege, and yet when the shells are exploding around the house the two hold each other in bed and cry for comfort. She internally complains that she “can’t” go in the cellar with Wade and Prissy and leave Melanie, but can’t she?

At Tara, she savagely wishes that Melanie would’ve died in childbirth, and then on the very next page she’s scolding Melanie for giving away her food to soldiers when she’s already weak. According to Melanie, Scarlett made sure Melanie had the best mattress at Tara and the only whole pair of shoes. Can we really say this is only because of her promise to Ashley? Scarlett also sleeps in Melanie’s bed when she starts having nightmares.

In Atlanta, when Frank steals her money and bans her from going to the mills, it’s to Melanie’s house that she storms over to unburden herself. After Frank dies, she wishes Melanie were around to comfort her. She is terrified of seeing Melanie’s face (“only Melanie”) after the scandal with Ashley, and then on the very next page is resentful that she had to “shelter behind Melanie’s skirts.” During her delirium following the miscarriage, she repeatedly calls out Melanie’s name, but then in the very next chapter is insisting that Melanie spends Ashley’s money “as soon as he makes it.”

Sorry for the ramble. I loooove the Scarlett/Melanie relationship. It’s so fascinating. Scarlett wants to hate her so much, but she simply doesn’t.

I always love when the Yankees come to the house Scarlett wishes Melanie was with her- Melanie was worth ten of the others. It’s the first time she acknowledges that she loves and needs Melanie. And then Melanie comes to save her and Tara from the fire- it’s such a beautiful turning point in their relationship. I think she actually treated Melanie really well before that, even if she thought critically about her, but it’s when she starts relying on Melanie as an equal. To me the real love story of the novel is between Scarlett and Melanie.

I love how you summarise their relationship in your last sentence. Very well put!

My issue with Ashley is how he has manipulated Scarlett, used her "love" for him to his advantage. He was 24-ish when he returned from his Grand Tour, Scarlett 14. He called on her every week for two years, riding with her, reading her poetry, and so on. Never once stating his intentions to her or anyone else. He toyed with her. During his furlough, he used her "love" again to take care of Melanie. Which she did. Yet when she needed him after the war, he was useless. He couldn't help her with the work on the plantation, which he should have been raised knowing how to run it, and then he did nothing but speak in riddles to Scarlett. He didn't even try asking his Macon relatives for help, or find a way to get the tax money. It may not have been

his house, but he resided there and was a male relative. He had to of known Scarletts intentions to sell herself for the money. Then when he is working for Scarlett at the mill, he does horribly and does nothing to learn the business or even look for a job that would fit him better. Then there's meddling in Scarletts marriage to Rhett. He was fine with her married to Frank and having marital relations, but Rhett was a hard limit. He put ideas into Scarletts head which lead to the separate bedrooms. When the hugging at the mill happen he hid under his wife's skirts rather than standing up for himself.

I wonder what Gerald and Ellen thought of all the attention Ashley paid to Scarlett? Just a family friend? (Although it seems quite beau-like.) Gerald tells her he knew Ashley would never propose, and he would have had misgivings if Ashley had, so it must have crossed their minds.

I definitely missed how much older he was (wtf?!) and the fact 12 oaks land still existed. I'm back to finding him highly annoying

I think you are making the mistake of taking Scarlett's POV narration as fact.

There is no way that Ashley "puts the idea" of separate bedrooms into Scarlett's head. He isn't having sex with Melanie because the doctor told him not to. Scarlett's idea that this is some romantic gesture towards her is total delusion.

He does look for a job that would suit him better than the mill (the bank in New York), again it's Scarlett that forces him to give that up, using Melly as leverage.

And he doesn't speak in riddles to Scarlett, his meaning is perfectly plain, it's just that she's not intelligent enough to understand him. In fact, half of the time she isn't even listening, she switches off halfway through and then ascribes whatever baloney to what he said afterwards. He didn't toy with or manipulate her, even she herself admits this (emphasis mine):

"You coward, you cad, you—You made me believe you were going to marry me—"

"Be fair," his voice pleaded. "Did I ever—"

She did not want to be fair, although she knew what he said was true. He had never once crossed the borders of friendliness with her and, when she thought of this fresh anger rose, the anger of hurt pride and feminine vanity. She had run after him and he would have none of her. He preferred a whey-faced little fool like Melanie to her. Oh, far better that she had followed Ellen and Mammy's precepts and never, never revealed that she even liked him—better anything than to be faced with this scorching shame!

Everything you say here about Scarlett not listening & choosing to ascribe whatever motives she wants is spot-on and something I think a lot of people ignore with this book.

She does it to lots of characters, not just Ashley. It's actually infuriating at times, especially when she's talking to Grandma Fontaine, haha.

The bit about us being more like Ashley since we read the book is hilariously true

Excellently written analysis! I disagree about Scarlett though. I believe she does love people though in a twisted way. By caring for Tara she shows love and respect to her father, by providing for her family and friends she shows love to her mother.

And though she is not a good mother emotionally she works hard to fulfill the childrens' physical needs. The way she is with them, in contrast with how she loves Bonnie, makes me think she suffered from a post natal

depression and the children reminded her of her trauma. She was still a child when she had them. But despite that, she does what she can to make them survive.

I think providing is a form of love, too, and I recognize it from my grandmother, a WW2 survivor who lived in East Germany. She lost her husband shortly after the war and starved under the Soviet reign as a widow with 5 children. For years she worked relentlessly to get them out of Germany and finally managed to escape to Sweden, having to split the family in the process (though they were later reunited).

In Sweden she again worked hard to provide. She had to put my mother and her sister at an orphanage (mom hated it there!) and moved in with an older, single man as his housekeeper. Not long afterwards they were married and the children could leave the orphanage and they had a home again. That whole situation reminds me a lot of Scarlett's second marriage.

I remember my grandmother as an old lady who paid little attention to me or her other grandchildren. She never showed affection. Emotionally distant. Doubtless carrying a lot of trauma. But mom and her siblings loved their "Mutti" as they called her and they knew she loved them back. They appreciated how hard she worked for them.

It all boils down to that pyramid they teach about in psychology. Your basic needs must be fulfilled before you can love emotionally.

Really interesting, thank you for sharing your family's story.

I have been reflecting on the hierarchy of needs so much lately - it really is true, you can't skip the basics! That's a beautiful story. I have had a lot of trauma in my life and sometimes I wonder if I'm not being outwardly loving to my kids. But I make all their food from scratch and work to make sure they have a good home, and I know even those are acts of love. They need more than the basics, but in survival mode, like the majority of the book, you have to focus on the basics and go from there.

Yeah I think so too. And also, it comes down to personality. Not everyone is outwardly affectionate.

In the GWTW book I think both Scarlett and Rhett carried too much unresolved trauma to be able to love each other properly.

Starvation and hardships aside, Scarlett's trauma started earlier, from marrying as a child/teen, becoming a teenage mother - and not until too late understand what it meant to be a mother and widow at that time. She was robbed of her youth. And since being a pretty flirt was what she was, what she built her whole identity on, losing that was hard. And she blamed the children for it.

Rhett similarly lost his youth. He became an outcast even with his own family at a young age. With his father acting so harshly then, it's not too much a stretch to imagine he was always a strict father caring only for his son's behavior and status. How else could he refuse ever to see his son again?

Rhett going "bad" was pretty natural. He could never live up to his father's (or society's) expectations so he figured he might as well be the bad man he was told he already was. A self-fulfilling profecy. And I think despite his seeming carelessness he carried a heavy load of guilt and shame that he tried not to listen to but couldn't ever silence completely.

In Scarlett Rhett saw himself before he was "ruined" and I think part of his obsession with her was wanting a partner in crime to make himself feel better about the life he lived. With Bonnie, his reasons were less

selfish, her he loved for her sake, but it was also a way for him to set his own lost childhood right. To be the loving father he himself never had.

Excellent and insightful analysis!

I will always upvote a defense of Ashley Wilkes. That man doesn't deserve half of the hate the fandom gives him.

Two things I personally would've gone deeper into (I am perpetually working on various GWTW essays):

Ashley's quote about life before the war being beautiful has a 2-sentence line that no one ever talks about. "Maybe it wasn't so to everyone. I know that now." I feel like this line could be summarizing so much and we the reader just don't get to explore that because the narrative doesn't take us there.

A lot of people (including Rhett, sort of) think Ashley just wants Scarlett for her body but he makes it known over and over again that it's her passion for life, her fire, the way she's so different from everyone else, that makes her so incredible.

I think if those were the only things Ashley liked about Scarlett, and not also her body, he wouldn't have such a hard time resisting her. He definitely lusts after her and those personality traits are the icing on top, like how an attractive person is even more attractive if they have a foreign accent.

I did say "just". Ashley wants Scarlett for more than just her body.

I don't think anyone believes Ashley is a coward in the sense of avoiding physical conflict, or even his responsibilities. His cowardice is emotional- he won't admit to himself that he's leading Scarlett on for years (though yes she's very capable of leading herself on) and that he lusts after her. And it's that emotional cowardice that turns Scarlett off him in the end.

I don't think he gets credit for making Scarlett better, because he wasn't trying to do that. She did it herself just with him as a figurehead, instead of her mother. Scarlett would never have abandoned Melanie whether she promised Ashley or not, her key character trait is that she looks after people. It's the one thing she actually learned from her mother that stayed deeply embedded in her once all her manners left. And she loves Melanie even if she doesn't acknowledge it.

I don't think it's true to say Scarlett's key character trait is looking after people. She provides food and money, yes, but doesn't fulfill any other needs, least of all to her children. And sometimes she doesn't even do the basics for them. When the Yankees come to Tara she literally forgets about Wade and almost leaves him in the house alone. It's Melanie's love which allows them to flourish, not Scarlett's.

Sure, she doesn't always provide emotionally, but I think you're agreeing that she wouldn't physically abandon anyone.

Not consciously, but I think the fact she doesn't think once about her own son's safety until she sees him cowering by the stairs speaks volumes.

This is at a time when she's ultra-concerned about Beau and the soldier's wallet, by the way.

I suppose it's a bit like the convicts. It's not till she actually sees how badly Johnny Gallagher is treating them that she's moved by their plight even though she must have known he was mistreating them before that.

Let's not forget that she allows him to keep mistreating them even after that incident! And he even kills one, subsequent to that conversation

Yeah, very true! She ultimately chose keeping Gallagher and the profits he was bringing her over their wellbeing even if she was initially moved by their plight.

I always thought this type of behavior was a metaphor for the South. Ashley did it too! They turned a blind eye to how wrong things were until they are forcefully confronted with it.

I'm sorry, he's not thoughtful- he kisses Scarlett while married to Melanie! And he does that as a "mature" man!

Excellent analysis, I agree with much of it. I also made a sort of defence of Ashley here some months ago: [link]

The honorable Ashley had many fine qualities. But the ability to succeed in the world wasn't one of them.

I think the key to understanding the text and the characters is not whether they do good or bad things but as Margaret Mitchell herself said, “If Gone With the Wind has a theme it is that of survival. What makes some people come through catastrophes and others, apparently just as able, strong, and brave, go under? It happens in every upheaval. Some people survive; others don’t. What qualities are in those who fight their way through triumphantly that are lacking in those that go under? I only know that survivors used to call that quality ‘gumption.’ So I wrote about people who had gumption and people who didn’t.”

I never saw Ashley as “bad” vs Rhett’s “good”, he felt for me like the person who simply didn’t have a capacity to survive. Someone lost in their own world and who pines for the “good old days”. Without Melanie as emotional support and Scarlett’s need to protect him and prop him up with a job (obviously for her own selfish reasons), left to his own devices I can’t imagine where he would have ended up.

I think without Melanie and Scarlett he probably would have just left the South and gone to a northern university or something, and someone would have taken pity and given him a job. Theres a sort of ‘failing upward’ that’s only available to rich white men, where the world can’t stand to let their ‘potential’ go to waste and things are just handed to them. It’s basically what almost happened but Scarlett insisted he come to Atlanta instead.

That is such a great take.

And with Andrew Johnson installed after Lincoln’s assassination, his restoration of the ceded Southern States and pardoning ex-Confederates you can imagine someone with Ashley’s pedigree being welcomed with open arms into some of those hallowed halls.

Perhaps, or perhaps not. Many post-war Northerners had contempt and disgust for Southerners they considered to be traitors.

I don't understand your second sentence. I've seen this "failing upward" situation happen with many people, not just "rich white men."

I see Rhett and Ashley both as people who see that their world as they know it is crumbling around them. They know that the Old South is dying. The difference is that Rhett takes advantage of it and Ashley gets depressed about it. I don't think it makes him weak. He has empathy and a lot of trauma from the war.

Ashley is a coward because he could see the reality of a situation but his actions never reflected reality. It’s one thing if you believe in a dream and another if you think it’s a dream. I see Ashley as weak because he never told Melanie about Scarlett and he took minimal firm steps to stop Scarlett’s pursuit of him. Had he

told Melanie why he couldn't work for Scarlett, she would have had to have said something. I think she too was happier ignoring what she knew to be true.

Are we totally certain that Ashley never told Melanie about Scarlett?

Even if he had, I'm not sure Melanie would have believed him.

She would have thought it was a terrible misunderstanding, like the incident at the mill (even though that was a misunderstanding). Her brain simply wouldn't process something so negative about Scarlett and Ashley because it would destroy her entire world.

The other part of this is that all there really is to tell are feelings. Scarlett & Ashley never actually fool around. So Melanie would be correct in her belief.

Ashley in the movie is an insipid, mopey weakling. I had no empathy or respect for him until I read the book, and discovered a much less passive character.

It's unfortunate that the actor is about 20 years too old in the movie. He should be 10 years younger than Rhett, but Leslie Howard was 8 years older than Gable.

I always thought he was terribly miscast for the part. He didn't want to do it and it showed. I've wondered who would have been better and I honestly feel a young Jimmy Stewart would have been a far more likable / empathetic Ashley, with his soulful ability to connect to an audience with his eyes.

Great analysis. I'd add 1 thing to it: I suspect that Ashley has depressive disorder. The fatigue, inability to take pleasure in activities, feelings of isolation from others…it all fits. And Gerald said all the Wilkes are like that.

Sure, but also PTSD wrecked a lot of them specifically after the war.

Before the war he is physically 'the best in the county' and enjoys lots of things, he's just 'queer' I.e he's intellectual. He likes learning and reading and that makes him (and the other Wilkses) different to the people around him, but he's not depressed.

Then after the war his health is destroyed by years in essentially a concentration camp where something like 50% of prisoners died. But he seems happy enough and says he doesn't mind being poor if he has books and Melanie. I don't think he's clinically depressed I think he just doesn't like the world he ended up in- pretty normal for anyone who lived through a war and lost their fortune and entire family.

He's the best in the county but Gerald says he's queer not only because he's an intellectual but "his heart isn't in it." He does all the usual activities but he's just going through the motions. And in the conversation with Scarlet before he kisses her, he says he feels like people were shadow people even before the war and he wasn't connected to anything.

Sorry but you make me recall lines I haven't read in years…."Didn't he take 50 dollars from you at poker last week? Aye,the Tarleton boys have been talking, else you'd not be knowing the amount. Yes he can do all those things Puss, but his heart's not in it. That's why I say he's queer." I don't have it exactly right but that's the gist of Gerald and Scarlett's conversation near the start of the book.

Yes, that's it. Although I think it's kind of rich that Gerald counseled Scarlett against marrying Ashley because as Scarlett knew, Ellen and Gerald were nothing alike and Gerald effectively dumped both the mental load and the management load on Ellen, a teenager half his age.

He led her on throughout the book and is spineless. Rhett had him properly pegged through out the book.

Rhett defends him at the end, and admits he was jealous. They also work together to shut down the Klan

Sort of. To both of those points.

Who names a man Ashley?

T02 Scarlett — a complicated character

Scarlett O'Hara from Gone With The Wind is a complicated character. From the start of the book, she is selfish and spoiled. She retains this attitude, wanting to be rich and having all the best things in life. She always gets what she wants. Yet, she works hard, she is ruthless and follows her dreams. She protects her family and kills people if she needs to. But by the end, all that strength and ambition has missed one thing: love. Her heart was so full of greed and power, she didn't let herself be loved or know what love meant. It wasn't until someone had to leave her, that she realized what she was missing out on all along.

She is very realistic character, cause she's not completely good and not completely bad, just like in the real life, and I think that's what makes her so great

I think the biggest takeaway I got from Gone with the Wind (and this includes the film) is that life is difficult and sometimes, as in the case of the Civil War and Reconstruction, it is almost unbearably so. Different people will do whatever they can to survive. Scarlett did everything from lying to sweet talking. Melanie survived with extreme kindness.

Melanie never would have survived without Scarlett.

Probably not. You can tell she wanted to be stronger but she had to find what worked for her.

I do think she also genuinely cared for Scarlett, at least.

I think so too. Scarlett said she believed Melanie was the only woman besides her mother who genuinely loved her.

And Melanie knew that, it's the reason she was always loyal to Scarlett.

I love your username. I suppose you know the history.

Yes, I do. Thanks!

That sounds a bit more opportunistic than I believe Melanie knew how to be.

I don't mean she stuck with Scarlett because she knew Scarlett would take care of her. She appreciated what Scarlett had done and was very grateful to her. I am not sure whether she realizes how grudgingly Scarlett gave her help, and that S only did it because Ashley had asked her to. Melanie always saw the good in people, and she loved Scarlett because Scarlett was her brother's widow.

Yeah, she was oblivious.

I am not sure she was oblivious. But I think she viewed Scarlett and all of her actions through a kinder lens than anyone else who knew Scarlett. TBH her kindhearted, idealistic and grateful view is next to impossible to accept!

I think it's also within the realm of possibility that she indeed understood that Scarlett had always had this huge crush on Ashley, and that Ashley felt a yearning for Scarlett that caused him to feel very guilty. But

Melanie also knew Ashley would never abandon her because that would violate his code of honor. He had lost everything material when Twelve Oaks burned and he still had to support his sisters. So his honor was the only thing he had left, and if he abandoned his wife and child, he would lose his honor and that would destroy him. In that sense, Melanie did have security. And apparently she truly did love Ashley. She, like Rhett, could see his good qualities as well as the things that made him weak (not being able to face the fact that the world had changed). Melanie did not care about wealth and status, just that there was a roof over their heads and she could be with her family and loved ones.

Can you tell that Melanie is my favorite 😉? But I do agree that she's unrealistically innocent and seemingly naive!

Lol. Yeah. I hear you on that. I like Belle to be honest. She seemed to be the only one who for better or worse was just transparent and laid it all out there. She didn't sugar coat or b.s. you. She seemed like a genuinely good person. And yes, Melanie was just too naive. But she was sweet. She's my second fave. Scarlett...well she's not the most likeable, huh?

Melanie recognized that and it's why she convinced Ashley not to go to New York. Would have kept Scarlet from pining after him so much if he was gone.

I don't think so. Melanie didn't want to leave her home and her friends and family. She saw Scarlett's offer of a job as a lifeline.

And Melanie is well aware of this. Which is why I love her and Scarlet both (though I prefer Scarlet overall). They are the original Ride Or Die.

Oh yes. Probably what Scarlett did to survive wasn't an example of good behavior in general, but again, in her circumstances it was quite excusable, because she had to look after a whole family all by herself (though at the beginning she didn't seem to be able to even look after herself), and I really admire her and how strong she was.

The movie leaves out her other children but yes, for much of her adult life she alone was taking care of everyone.

Well, leaving out some characters was probably the worst thing about the movie, and they dropped many great moments. The movie was beautiful, but the book is SO much better.

I do think the movie handled part 5 of the book better, the details of the marriage with Rhett felt rushed.

The book does too

And this is why she is one of my favorite characters. She is so very deeply flawed, and yet I admire her ability to make it through to the next day.

"Slaves were neither miserable nor unfortunate. The n****es were far better off under slavery than they were now under freedom, and if she didn't believe it, just look about her! Definitely flawed

I've read the book several times, and get something different each time, depending on the phase of life I was in. In High School, all I could see was the slavery, and spoiled brattiness. In College I could appreciate her drive and trying to get what she wants. Post college struggle let me empathize with her desperate desire to survive at all costs. As a married woman, I see her keeping her family fed and doing whatever it takes.

Scarlett experiences growth, trials, tribulations, murder, childbirth, love, loss, war, post war boom, success as a female in a deeply patriarchal society, and so much more. Sure, she was part of a society that thrived due to slavery, but when that part was done, she thrived off her own brains and charm. She has a unique ability to clear her head and "worry about that tomorrow." She went from a spoiled teenager, the belle of the ball, to eating raw potatoes in the dirt and forcing her bratty sisters to pick cotton and vegetables so they could survive.

Scarlett is a survivor. In my darkest times, I try to pull a little bit of firey Scarlett out of my soul to carry on.

You guys keep mentioning the slavery aspect as if it's a background, one note thing. I don't know why but I find it funny

Because in the context of the book, it was. Imagine 50 years from now new insights into animal cognition make eating meat utterly repulsive in hindsight - someone like you would comment "it's so weird people talk about eating meat like it's just background" about contemporary books.

She is the ultimate anti-hero for me and I couldn't love her more for it.

But the reason she missed love is her very own misguided idea of love. She was always the favorite not only among her sisters but among all the young ladies in Tara, she was adored by the male population of her neighborhood. The reason she thought she loved Ashley was because he kind of rejected her and she was NOT used to rejection. And he did it in such a "nice" way that he unintentionally strung her along and didn't nip her affection for him in the bud. She missed love because she thought she was in love.

Can't really blame her considering how messed up her life became. She did what she had to do to survive and to protect her family. Can't blame her, only admire her. How she went to a spoiled little brat to someone everyone could rely on.

Sure, she didn't get the guy to stay with her, but so what.

I agree, except that she did crave love and ask for love but from a wrong man. She was obsessed with him because he was out of reach, meanwhile here was Rhett, as manly a man can be, but she didn't appreciate him enough since he seemed like an easy option and therefore less valuable, by foolish dating logic we always tend to apply.

Dude Rhett was 16 years older than Scarlett. They first met when she was 16 and he was 32. Ashley was around 20/22.

Are we really giving shade to a teenager for having a crush on a guy a few years older than her and not wanting the old man just because he liked her?

If they used an actor like John Wayne vs Clark Gable I don’t think we would be idolizing Rhett as much.

I never realized what the age difference was.

I never liked Ashley though.

I didn’t like Ashley either, I watched the movie as a teen but read the book as an adult. As an adult I kinda see why she wasn’t into Rhett.

Ashley was complicated to me. He definitely was wishy washy.

One of the early chapters, when she realizes Melanie and Ashley are going to be married, Scarlett remembers Ashley saying something to her about not having enough courage to do it himself.

I don't remember exactly, but I remember thinking he was saying that he wasn't brave enough to be truthful to Scarlett - that he let her find out about his engagement from gossip instead of telling her himself.

I also think he wasn't brave enough to anger or disappoint his parents. He wouldn't tell them that he wanted to marry Scarlett. He just went along with their plans for him to marry Melanie.

He would go on rides with Scarlett, and make every indicator that he was courting her. But he wouldn't go against his family's plan for his marriage to Melanie.

Yeah, he was so spineless. He didn't deserve Melanie or Scarlett.

No man ever could deserve Melanie.

No man could deserve Scarlet, except Rhett.

And Leslie Howard, who played Ashley in the movie, was about 40 at the time. He thought he was wrong for the part of Ashley and didn't want to do it, but he was under contract to the studio and had to take the part. He was a very popular actor at the time; after GWTW he went back to England and joined the war effort against Nazi Germany and was killed during the war.

I think this casting really detracted from the image of Ashley as described in the book. Nothing against Howard, but he was too old, although his acting, IMO, was great.

He played the milquetoast Ashley very well

Yeah he did but he was too old.

Rhett also raped her so……. Let's not romanticize this character overly much.

Yes, on the one occasion, he did. I certainly won't try to defend that—but it was one occasion. Scarlett had made herself a target of gossip by a public kiss with Ashley that was witnessed by Ashley's sister—although ironically it was one time in her whole infatuation with Ashley that it wasn't a flirtatious attempt on her part.

Rhett would have given anything for Scarlett to be so tender and affectionate with him at that point, and he sat at home and got drunk while she went alone to Ashley's birthday party that Rhett forced her to attend so that a) Scarlett would be embarrassed but also b) Rhett and their daughter wouldn't be targets of gossip, too.

Don't forget all the bodice-ripper romances of the 1970s and 80s where the "hero" made his conquest through raping the female MC.

They did not kiss in that scene. Scarlett got emotional and Ashley put his arm around her trying to comfort her.

Even if they had, that is not excuse for rape. Not even "just once".

What the ever living fuck. Your post states several times "on the one occasion he raped her" and that you "won't try to defend it" but then double down on how it was only one time.

Not defending. But I was trying to make the point that not only was the "rape-seduction" a common technique in books that featured a romantic relationship in earlier times, but that the circumstances around the episode were factors. Those circumstances don't excuse the act.

Then learn how to phrase things better. Your comment is completely in defense of this. Lol.

And this book was written in its own era that wasn't a part of the 70s and 80s rape fantasy books you reference.

No, it isn't a defense. And I'm very well aware of when GWTW was written.

Lmao. Reread your post and ask yourself: Isnt what I'm saying kind of defensive regarding this rape? Isn't what I'm saying kind of fucked up because I'm so focused on how he only raped her one time and how he would do anything else for this woman?

I liked her. She was selfish, but she refused to conform to the expectations. She knew people talked behind her back, ostracized her for stupid reasons like dancing at a charity ball and she just carried on. She was an outcast.

It's been a long time, but I think that's why I liked the sequel that came out in the 90's. She finally finds love and is still a whipcrack of a woman.

I absolutely loved the character development in the sequel!!!

Yes.. I loved that book.. it's called Scarlett. I read it multiple times during my school holidays. I was about 16 or so .

That's about the age I read it. I recall the halcyon teenage years when I could literally read GWTW over the course of 3 days on little sleep. Can't do that anymore! LoL

For about 4 or 5 years during my teens I started each summer vacation by reading GWTW. Maybe took me about a week. I love that book.

I'm reading this book now. If her and Rhett don't make this work I'm going to completely lose my mind 😂

Well, she's a 16 year old at the beginning of the book so it's no surprise that she's selfish. Then, she's put in an incredibly scary and stressful situation with the Civil War and again, she learns that being selfish is the only way to protect herself. She doesn't even give herself time to grieve her father because she's too busy trying to survive.

I thought Rhett Butler was equally as flawed, but a tad less selfish. His confronting her about how she treated her two previous husbands and her ongoing infatuation with Ashley Wilkes, especially after he married, exemplifies that he does have some consideration for others. His willingness not to use their children as accessories for prestige also endeared me to him.

Well he was also a night rider aka a Klansman

No Rhett was not a klansman--hen had no respect for them read the book again.

I need to reread the book, as I forgot about that!

I actually like gone with thr wind as a snapshot of southern life in the pre war, war, and post war period but thr uncritical love it gets really burns my soul as a southerner who still has had to deal with lost causers and burning crosses in life

Gotcha. I always try to keep an open mind when I'm reading for that reason: I recognise that there are going to be a lot of different perspectives on any given literature.

Yeah. I'm sorry my liquored self made it so awkward. I really do apologize for butting into the book discussion

Can i ask because maybe you might know; are the depictions of the north accurate at all? I seem to remember the union soldiers pillaging and raping, and really being no better to the freed slaves. I’m Canadian and unfortunately haven’t learned about US history.

That's actually a really good question. And the answer is "kinda but not really". This may be a bit long.

Firstly the union never saw the south as anything hut a "region in rebellion". It never saw them as a legitimate government. In fact there was a popular belief that southern elites were pushing the war and the common folks of the South would rally behind the liberating northern troops. There was also a common feeling that the south was still their brothers so there was an attempt to win hearts and minds. So for the first year or two of the war the Union stepped slowly and lightly trying not to destroy to much infrastructure, returned escaped slaves and generals tried to restrain their men from rapine pillage and plunder.

The south had no such qualms not only did the south elite advocate open warfare on the countryside and cities of the north they also treat black soldier with contempt. Ft pillow is an infamous massacre where colored troops were put to the sword and no surrenders were accepted. It wasn't until the "step lightly" approach proved to be a failure that the Union Changed tactics and began to commit to total war.

Secondly the majority of the troops who DID commit pillaging were mercenary groups most of them foreign troops recruited to bolster the ranks of the army.

Thirdly, yes the Union was actually better to the freedmen. You know that 40 acres and a mule legend that alot of black scholars bring up? That was what a free black preacher told General Sherman his people needed to become prosperous. Or to be more specific, Sherman asked what the colored people of the land needed (as many slaves fled their plantations and began following the Union army in a baggage train)and the preacher responded with "land and animals". Note that I'm paraphrasing.

Lastly when confederate towns and cities were conquered many southern troops burned their own towns and it was often Union troops who tried to put these fires out. This ain't to say that Union troops didn't burn places down (they even had jingle for the capital of South carolina: "Dear Columbia happy land, if we don't burn ya I'll be damned") and they burnt atlanta down because they got drunk as all hell. Of course ex slaves go involved as many would drag out slave owners and whip them in the street while union troops cheered. But again, this was war and the Confederacy wasn't doing much worse.

Gone with the wind is perfect for daughters of the confederacy meetings and great for a peek into what southerners thought of the war at that time. But it's wildly inaccurate and extremely biased. That being said it has one redeeming feature insofar as to accuracy. But it's a chicken or the egg type situation and off topic.

Scarlett being a riches to rags type woman who rebuilt her life and tried to do her best to survive is actually what happened to many MANY southern Planter wives and the Union was not generous to them. But did this image of the noble struggling southern belle come before or after this book? Many neo confederate organizations were founded by confederate wives who pooled money in order to naive their husband's and sons proper burials and often sought to protect each other financially. Gone with the wind helped popularize the struggles of these women and pushed many in society to reconcile with the south and give support to these women.

I love her so much. She was a beautifully flawed person and sure she was an outrageously selfish brat but also was the only one able to keep it together enough and pick her family up. Scarlet saved them all from

starvation. She was a women who defied all gender conventions and norms never truly hesitated to do whatever she wanted. Scarlet was wonder woman in a war time world. She is awesome!

Scarlett is my absolutely favorite literary character. She is amazing but flawed and I love her.

She was so amazing I genuinely didn't even want her to end up with him. Rhett really wasn't that great to me. I'm glad they didn't end up together. Plus he was damn old compared to her… Jesus she was 16 when they met and he was 32.

She is a character descried in ways that lead you to believe that she had a narcissistic personality disorder, but the time period did not have a name for these personality types. I often wonder if she was maybe borderline. Perhaps the author had experience with BPD. Scarlet cannot accept rejection and feels intense love for someone she barely knows at the beginning and that love only grows the more she is rejected by him. Her extreme vanity, selfishness, and manipulation leads me to believe she did have BPD and the way she treated her daughter like an object even more so.

The saddest part is she is only a teenager in the very beginnings. Sure everyone on reddit was perfect and owned 80 private jets as a teen, but all teens are selfish. She was too young to understand what was happening, and by the time she was old enough to maybe understand she became a ruthless adult. Not only that but she maintained the plantation with those qualities so she is gonna retain those bevause she survived with those qualities. So in essence the civil war stunted her as a human. Those years of retaining and growing up could've prevented her from living a life devoted to pursuing a love that was never going to happen but she never had a chance to grow out of that puppy teenage love cursing her to be stuck in it. It's sad, tragic, but my God does it make for really good storytelling.

I've shared numerous thoughts about Scarlett O'Hara before, yet I still have some reflections to share on why her character marked a pivotal point for feminism in classic literature, based on my understanding of feminism and the portrayal of female characters.

I believe she is the blueprint for the anti-heroines we all know now. And yes, that includes your favorite mean girl, Regina George.

As an anti-heroine, she naturally challenges expectations, and, of course, the general assumption is that the audience wouldn't like her. Boy, does she give you a lot to hate about her, especially when she's foiled by an almost a literal angel in the form of Melanie. But when she reveals her likable side, you gravitate towards her. For those who understand her (and I'll be bold and include myself), you become both Ashley and Rhett, grappling with loathing and admiration for such a complex person.

Compelling as she is, and considering 'Gone With the Wind's' enduring success (it still holds the record for the highest-grossing film in history when adjusted for inflation), albeit infamous for its racial issues, I find her somewhat underrated and overlooked in discussions about empowering female characters. Many feminists consider her problematic (no shit, Sherlock) and not deserving of a spot, but her complexity and controversial nature add richness to her character. She provides a nuanced understanding of women in literature. While Austen's Elizabeth Bennet and Alcott's Jo March navigated societal constraints admirably, what Scarlett went through across a thousand-page book was nothing short of tumultuous. Her showcase of strength, flaws, and vulnerabilities creates a wonderful experience—both in reading and viewing. And having Vivien Leigh portray Scarlett O'Hara on screen??? An epitome of casting!

Now, go watch David O'Selznick's three-hour beauty that is Gone With the Wind. 😁.

Gone With the Wind is my absolute favorite book!!!!!! I love Scarlett so so much!!!

I wonder why

I wasn't much impressed by the "Gone with the wind" in general. The storyline is too much dramatized.

Scarlett is a lovely character but her behaviour towards Rhett was annoying sometimes.

Old fashioned stereotypes .... I felt so bad for the poor baby girl who broke her neck, have she ridden that pony astride, her life could probably be saved. "Lady shouldn't do this, shouldn't do that!"

Thanks God, I am not living in such times!

RemindMe! 1 month

There's a Billy Joel song, Always a Woman, which I think of as "Scarlett's Song."

"Nwords were provoking sometimes and stupid and lazy, but there was loyalty in them that money couldn't buy, a feeling of oneness with their white folks which made them risk their lives to keep food on the table."

Very complicated character

He didn’t love her. 😳

I worked at a law firm across the street from Mitchell’s home, my office had a window and I saw her former home every day. I wondered what her view was while she hammered out GWTW on her vintage typewriter while I typed on a IBM keyboard in the future.

Scarlett was a survivor. And somewhat ruthless. It was the horrific scene at the hospital in Atlanta that sent her off that I find interesting in her character. She was never prepared for the hard stuff.

I think she finally does. She's a spoiled moron but she does have her moments of lucidity.

T03 Scarlett — messy and flawed

Scarlett O’Hara in Gone With The Wind is very messy and flawed, but still manages to be a compelling protagonist

Asides from a select few classics, Gone With The Wind is one that I find myself really attached to. It was my pandemic book, and although I was too young to comprehend the messages, sixteen year old me was drawn into the story of Scarlett and the Civil War raging on her around her.

It wasn’t until I talked to my aunt about it, that I realised Scarlett wasn’t who I thought she was. I found her to be this spoiled brat who was dense and conceited, who couldn’t look past her own self to care about others. Obviously, it wasn’t true. Because like Scarlett, I realized she lived in a fantasy world. The South was her ideal heaven, her home. But disregarding that, I mean the world of a young woman who knows nothing but love and luxury. Like Scarlett, I too was living in my own world of youth and innocence.

It wasn’t until she was hit with the reality of war and barely managing to care for her family, that she has to change and grow. Away is the silly little girl, and now it’s a young woman learning to survive in the real world. It wasn’t until I was hit with the realities of college and jobs, that like Scarlett, I had to discard my old ways and young self, and learn to be stronger like she did.

Scarlett is selfish, she is greedy, she also cares, but it’s hard for her to show it. She isn’t some perfect saint, that’s Melanie. So at the end of GWTW, she realises too late, that she had one good thing but she lost it.

Love. Real love. Everyone around her pretty much hated her at that point, her parents were dead. Her sisters scorned her. The friends she used to know don't like her. Melanie died. And even in the end, Rhett left her as well.

And so at her lowest point, Scarlett was still hurting. She tried to find all the perfect things for herself, or at least what she thought she needed. But she ended up making more mistakes and hurting herself. "After all, tommorow is another day." It signifies that not all hope is lost for her, and she will continue to find the strength to live for herself.

I just like Scarlett, she's one of my favorite fictional protagonists. It took me some time to really understand how multifaceted her character was.

World Without End Scarlett's kind of dreadful, but she's fascinating

Exactly, scheming to climb to the top of a social ladder as it was burning itself to the ground. A way to read Scarlett is that she was openly behaving in ways that the rest of the antebellum set were too hypocritical to admit.

I think she was at the top of the ladder when young, but when the world began to change, she was one of the few who realized she would have to change if she wanted to survive. Scarlett had balls. She was flawed, but she was smart and strong.

Things make way more sense knowing she was 15-16 at the start of the movie.

I've always read her and Rhett's characters as direct critiques of the Old South represented by Melanie and Ashley.

Margaret Mitchell started out intending Melanie to be the protagonist but as she wrote the the book, Scarlett just took over.

I never knew that!

I read a biography of her ages ago & it went deep into her writing the book.

This novel has a special place in my heart because it was my first time reading a book that had one of those "unlikable" protagonists. I also read it when I was 16, and I found her fascinating as a character.

I don't get how she was unlikable. She was exactly what she had been raised to be, and the story explains why she did the things she did. Although, marrying Charles was crazy, I'll admit.

Oh, I think she made sense as a character, which is part of why I liked reading about her so much. But I also think she fits the criteria for what's usually described as an "unlikable" character.

Personally, I often really like those sorts of characters, though, and GWTW was the first book that I remember reading with a truly flawed character instead of a protagonist who was at least generally good/nice/heroic.

The book gave solid reasons why she was forced to do what she did. I guess I was always on her side so I never saw her as unlikable.

But the other characters who were raised in that same environment and family wouldn't do all the things that she did. Scarlett was just different outside of her environment (which also molded her, don't get me wrong).

Look at Suellen and Careen and how they responded to the war and tragedy. Both did so in very different ways from Scarlett, neither of them in a scandalous way (according to post-war standards; Suellen's marriage would have been fully scandalous pre-war).

I do think it's super interesting to the modern reader, though. We all love Melanie and Careen and Will. We admire Scarlett even if we don't like her (and you have to admit that stealing Frank from Suellen was a shitty, unlikeable thing to do; the way she treated Charles and her children was also horrific, etc.). Contrast that with Suellen who is definitely a victim of her sister's scheming, but still manages to be less likable than Scarlett.

I love this book so much.

Scarlet sacrificed to make sure that her sisters and Melanie and her children lived.

Her actions make her unlikable. The way she treats people. She's complex though. Not every aspect of her is unlikable, and unlikable is in the eye of the beholder anyway.

I guess I just had Scarlett fever and loved everything she did. Except leasing convicts.

She full on neglects her son! 90% of the book, sure, she's just a product of her environment. But the way she treats her son, who is a toddler during the burning of Atlanta and likely has PTSD and gets absolutely no affection from his mother, is abhorrent

Because she never wanted to be a mother, but was forced to because of the time that she was born and raised.

And yet Melly was perfectly able to take care of her son AND Scarlett's son

Melanie and Beau lived because Scarlett helped deliver him then got them out of Atlanta and then did whatever she needed to do to put a roof over their heads and food in their stomachs.

I think the relationship between Scarlett and Melanie is the most compelling part of the story for me. They are so loyal to each other. Scarlett consciously sees Melanie as a rival but refused to abandon her.

I agree-Scarlett was not close to her sisters, she had 1 friend and she greatly admired her mother-I think Melanie reminded her of her mother, she becomes the great woman that Scarlett saw her mother as.

She owned slaves

That was accepted at that time. The story doesn't deal with it at all-true.

Why would that matter? There were abolitionist at the time. Hell there were many a hundred years before. It was banned in most of Europe, clearly people knew being a slave was an awful and inhumane fate. Just because a lot of people were okay letting an evil slide doesn't make it okay. It just means a whole lot of people were awful.

It was written in the 1930s.

Every time there's a Scarlett and Ashley scene in the book I want to just shake her. He's so awful and she was so blinded by him.

I think her desperation to cling to at LEAST one thing from when life was easy and she had no worries or real struggles made her willingly close her eyes to how... not very good Ashley was for her. He didn't really change to suit the times (the man was too weak to step up for his family and preferred to be lost in nostalgia, ugh, I hate him so much) and instead of seeing it as stagnation, she saw him as comfortingly familiar.

If she had stopped to really think about it all, she would have realised that she didn't even like him as a person, never mind love. Like, there are very telling moments where she may have understood it, but she buries her head in the sand like the most obtuse and stubborn ostrich.

Besides, it's not like Rhett gave her a lot of alternatives. He turned downright nasty to her shortly after their wedding instead of being someone she could be vulnerable with. Showering someone with gifts and spoiling them with money is NOT how you get someone to see you as a love interest, Rhett! Not even a materialistic, spoiled, and dense fool like Scarlett 🙄 🙄 😒 😒

I mean he only really turned nasty forward her because she gave that same thing back to him. They each treated each other like the other treated them even when they wanted to be vulnerable

Not saying she didn't, because goodness gracious, the way that woman self-sabotaged herself in their relationship is astounding. But at the same time, Rhett was more experienced (although perhaps not when it comes to healthy love) and older. HE was the one with the feelings, and he chose to hide those feelings because he was scared Scarlett would use him

He didn't have to bare his soul, but he could have been gentler and been her friend instead of turning caustic, bitter and angry at Scarlett for not returning feelings she didn't even know she had inspired. For as much as he knew her, he didn't really see that she was changing and evolving (albeit at a glacial pace) and chose to run away or to hide behind sarcasm at pivotal moments

Like you can trace the exact moment he stopped being her friend, almost. Before their marriage and even at the beginning of their honeymoon, they were very clearly friends. It was a shame they lost that friendship and distanced themselves because if that friendship had been alive, it would have been a door kept open for them to improve their relationship for the better

Take that ridiculous time when Scarlett listened to Ashley and decided not to share a room with Rhett after Bonny was born. It's been a good few years since I read the book, but I always got the impression she regretted it. But by that point, their relationship was too damaged for her to be vulnerable with Rhett and admit that. Earlier, Rhett would have just teased her gently, but by that point, I think Rhett would have been far more vindicative if she did. There were far too many people in their marriage, from Ashley to Belle to even Bonnie (although in a MUCH different capacity to the two nuisances)

he was scared Scarlett would use him

Kind of a ridiculous nitpick, but IIRC he knew that Scarlett would definitely use him. He knew that she didn’t actually love him (or wouldn’t admit to herself that she did, which amounted to the same thing). He loved/wanted her so much that he was willing to cross his own lines to get her. That included marrying even though he swore he wasn’t the marrying type. It also included being with a woman who didn’t love him but definitely loved his money.

He willingly let her use him, but eventually it just became too much.

Well I would say it makes sense he didn’t see her changing because Scarlett is very good at hiding her feelings and given the fact that she was very obvious about her obsession with Ashely, it’s hard to see her changing at all he would have to be able to read her mind. They’re both at fault at the end of the day, they’re the same and so if he couldn’t see her, you could say the same about her towards him

I agree with Rhett when he says her grandchildren will love and admire her, even though she was not ladylike-she is ahead of her time, she is a woman who depends on herself because every man she meets is a disappointment in one way or another.

I love Scarlett. All the parts of her. I think people forget she was only 16 when the book started and probably had massive PTSD from surviving a civil war.

👆 yep. At the outset, she's vain and spoiled but she's exactly what she's been moulded to be in that environment. She's reinforced - pretty much feted - for acting that way. But even then, she admires her mother and wants to be a "great lady" like her one day. The war has other plans for her. By the time she gets back to the devastated remains of Tara - and her dead mother - she's just committed to survival at any cost, and everything she does afterwards reflects that.

I think a big “growth” for scarlet, if you will allow me to speculate, is when she returns home and finds her mom passed and her dad senile. At once she turns from the fiddle-Dee-Dee mindset into the must take care of my people(mother) and the must take care of my soil(father).

However, it didn’t fundamentally change her. She was still spoiled, conniving, and a bit heartless to the ones she was trying to save, but things that didn’t matter as a debutante to her mattered so much she was willing to trade herself for it as a survivor.

Caveat to this, I read the book in my teens and am now reading it again in my fifties and have just got to the part where Scarlett goes back to Atalanta after the war is over to find Rhett in jail. So I could change my opinion again

Her father’s Irish arrogance helped her after the war, while her mother’s genteel background fell away. It was the only way to survive, to let the mincing ways of the southern upper class fall to the wayside.

Interesante esta versión!

I always found the mother to be a cold bitch, but the scene in the movie when Scarlett realized her mother's dead always brings me to tears. She loved her mother in that distant, awed way and it was such a blow to her.

Her mother suffered a terrible tragedy when she was 15, and it left only a shell of a woman, according to the book. The movie, btw, is much summarized. The book has the full story.

You need to read the book! There's some important backstory to Ellen.

I love, love the way that Mitchell went out of her way to critique the way that women were regarded and treated in that society. Her tongue is right in her cheek when she points out that Ellen at 32, is deemed to be "a middle aged woman".

I have loved this book and the film since I was a kid. Yes, it is problematic with certain views, but it's a sweeping story and Scarlett is one of the most fascinating characters. She's flawed, she's smart, she Wass clearly born in the wrong era. Ashley was a wet blanket and so dull, but she was clinging to the love of her youth who represented a different and to her mind a better time whilst facing crazy circumstances, so I kind of get it. Rhett gave her her first orgasm, though, so she really should have smartened up. And poor Frank - she really did a number on him. 🤣

I actually find Ashley rather fascinating; he’s clearly a foil to Rhett and although he gets derided as a”wimp,” he and Rhett both have the courage to look at things and say what they feel instead of following society. Both Melanie and Scarlett comment several times that Rhett and Ashley see the war as useless, society as deluded

and yet they have an attachment to the “old days.” Ashley is also a foil to Scarlett in that they both adhere to traditional gender norms but neither of them likes it.

Actually, I always thought she was sort of an asshole. But the book was pretty compelling.

She is a royal asshole. But I did admire her ability to survive.

She absolutely is an asshole. And a terrible, abusive mother.

But she's formidable as hell

I never did care for Scarlett. I will say she is a strong woman by doing what she did but she is self centered till the end.

The book is hard to read because of its horrible racism but is one of the best written books I’ve read.

Yes, parts are very racist but it was written in a racist time and set in an even more racist time. I'm not taking my views on race or slavery from Gone with the Wind.

I read it as a teen and loved it! She often annoyed me and many of her decisions were not the best, but she felt so human with all of her issues and complexity

I love Scarlett! That doesn't mean I agree with everything she does (or even most things she does) but I love how real she seems. She strikes me as just what a spoiled, rich teenage daughter of a plantation owner would have been like in that era. She's such a brat but really comes into her own (maybe too late, though). The movie is SO good and I'm like 1/3 of the way through the book now.

She is a terrible person, but she knew what had to be done to keep her lifestyle and people safe-ish.

The sequels didn't do her story justice.

Edit: sequels- Scarlett by Alexandra Ripley, Rhett Butler's People by Donald McCaig.

Prequel- Ruth's Journey by Donald McCaig.

People are forced to do terrible things when their survival is at stake. The theme of the book is survival and determination, and that entails desperate measures.

idk I genuinely enjoyed Scarlett! But there are very few stories in happy to let go with an ending that's sad, or left to the reader's interpretation

I very much liked it overall, but you can definitely see the sections where Ripley strayed from any attempts to pattern after Mitchell’s writing. I think(?) she generally wrote romance, which is absolutely fine. But for this sequel she got a little too smutty, which Margaret Mitchell would never. I read it as a late teen and remember ripping about 30 or so pages straight out. First and last time I’ve willingly defaced a book.

I just didn't think she would have left Tara that easily, but that's just my take lol.

I can totally see that! I may be too willing to accept that she'd feel her dad's homeland calling to her haha. But considering how young she was in the og story, I can see her needing to feel free and not tied down for once.

I honestly might have read Scarlett before gone with the wind so my opinions should be taken with a grain of salt haha

There’s a different sequel published in 2008, The Winds of Tara, which has Scarlett staying at Tara. I haven’t read it so can’t say if it’s any good.

I love GWTW. I read the book years after I’d seen the movie several times. Talk about the book being WAY better and deeper than the movie!! One of my favorite books. Thanks! Now I’m motivated to read it again!

I know it by heart. This book was the most important story and character that I have ever read, and helped me through difficult times. I first read it at 16, and I had dark hair, green eyes, and a tiny waist. I could not believe I had so much in common with Scarlett.

A big part of why Scarlett is so compelling i think is that Mitchell knows just how flawed she is and misses no chance to point it out.

Definitely this. Every time Scarlett gets a win, the narrator or someone else is right there to tell us she won using dirty tactics and her victory will be temporary, hollow or both.

Good characters with no flaws do not make interesting reading.

Scarlett is honestly one of the most authentic female characters in classic literature. She's messy as hell but that's why we relate to her. The way she adapted from spoiled girl to survivor is what makes her fascinating she gets things done when everything falls apart, even while making terrible personal choices. I love that Mitchell didn't take the easy route and give her some perfect redemption arc. Your connection to your own life transitions really hit home we all have those moments when we realize our comfortable bubbles aren't reality

Honestly very surprised by the sentiment that a character is a good protagonist despite being messy and flawed. I always want nuanced characters with depth that can be arseholes.

Oh definitely; I mean, there’s a reason Gone With the Wind has such staying power. Flawed but fascinating, interesting leads and compelling stories make an impression. Scarlett was spoiled, entitled, manipulative, and selfish. But she was also feisty, determined, very young, and a survivor.

As with any female protagonist, there's an element of sexism/misogyny in the response to her. The fact that she's not a very nice person (though how much of that is down to trauma is debatable) is beside the point that she is, as you say, a very interesting character.

There are a lot of problems with GWTW obviously, but its main appeal IMO is in the characterisation. In a lot of ways, it's a soap opera with the war as a backdrop. But the relationship between Scarlett and Melanie is among the best in any novel I can think of - finely drawn, nuanced, and weirdly realistic.

Scarlett was such a bad person but god damn, she was capable. She was fascinating. I read GWTW in high school too and it hit.

My fave character of all time

One of my favorite movies. She has a lot of character growth.

I expected to hate this book, but it totally floored me. I remember wondering "Can you think of any other book where the MC grows into a new person every 100 pages?" I think this is highlighted by the historical setting, showing how the drama of the civil war turned people's lives so abruptly and severely. I found it to be a masterpiece, and I sometimes have a hard time enjoying classics.

I've only seen the movie but I have to say that Scarlett is really the standout even there. She's one of my favorite characters of all time. Her flaws and her strengths are one and the same. The same tenacity that lets her help her family survive makes her lie, cheat, and steal.

If I had to sum her up it would be that one Smith's song title "I want the one I can't have." The millisecond Ashley becomes reasonably available to her she doesn't care anymore and only wants Rhett as soon as he's out the door. She doesn't care about Tara, she hates Tara until she's away from it. She has everything but she's never satisfied with it. She's not a perfect character but honestly she's one of the most compelling to me.

Oddly enough to me this might be a weird comparison but I feel that she is the opposite side of the coin of Patrick Bateman. I feel that Patrick Bateman is an incredible exploration of some of the worst parts of masculinity and I feel that Scarlett O'Hara is an exploration of some of the worst aspects of femininity.

The book and movie are very close. I would say main differences with Scarlett in the book and in the movie are her having two other children (one from each marriage) that she kind of ignores and don't feel maternal towards (but takes care of them materially). And the period where she is struggling in Tara is longer and even more impressive for her trying to deal with. She actually manages to be nice to her future brother in law Will (who liked her youngest sister Carreen but married Suellen) who is a cripple soldier from a poor family. And her trying to be more like her mother but always failing is more in the book perhaps.

Read the book. The movie is a mere shell compared to the book.

You can't possibly understand gone with the wind until you read the book. Yes, I love the movie more than any other movie I've ever seen. However, the book has so much more in it than the movie because they just couldn't put it all in.

The book is so much more in depth than the movie. You'd never know how much more there is to the story if you haven't read the book. It's such a good read!

Yeah, the thing about Scarlett is her awfulness. IIRC there was a point in the book where she'd admitted she'd enslave white people too, just so long as she stayed on top and was able to keep living in luxury - she didn't care how many people she had to trample over. She only cared when it cost her (Rhett, like how she made sure her mother didn't know her flaws - but she couldn't hide them from Mammy - and how she HAD to keep all those men centered on her...)

I just kinda wish she'd been able to see (if only for a minute), slaves like Dilcey or her Mammy were doing what she'd done - dissembling and masking.

This is a very surface level take of her character. I don't recall that she said she'd enslave people*, I do think that when she was back at home trying to run the household she talked about working everyone hard and she didn't care if people complained, she just tried to work them harder. But it was pretty clear that the main motivation wasn't to live in luxury for the sake of luxury, it was to get as far away from starvation and death as she could. The more money she had, the better she was able to protect everyone she considered family, including poorer relatives who thought+ talked badly of her.

Her view on men changed over time, she weaponized her beauty and charm in order to get what she needed, oftentimes marriage, again for the safety and security she needed for herself and her family. But she hated it too, ultimately I think she wanted to get to a place where she could be her own person and just stop struggling.

The drama around Ashley was selfish, but just another facet to the fight within herself to be the perfect Southern belle/lady of the house vs the practical/pragmatic survivor who will do anything not to be trampled in the dust. Ashley was the key to the past and to the woman she was raised to be. She was literally 16 years old at the time lmao obviously she romanticized the heck out of the situation and it was hard to let that go.

*Edit: it would be fitting of her character to say something like that though when she was mad, telling those around her that her will was stronger than the law. Literally her vibe was that she'd get herself and everyone she was responsible through every trial regardless of the cost, and unfortunately she was willing to force others to make that happen, like forcing her sisters to work right after they'd been ill

Well, it's been the better part of a decade since I've read it and I don't have the book anymore, so it's entirely possible it was a misprint or something. (Like that copy of Haunting of Hill House I had, wherein instead of the second half of the book.... it just reprinted the first half. Only less obvious. Er.)

The impression I had of her, is that she didn't care *who* she used in order to make sure she never went hungry again. Or had to endure shelling. Or to keep herself and her family in nice clothes and food. She didn't think much of women (even after the war); how much of that was her upbringing and how much was her I don't know. I do think she'd have done better now, when she'd have more choice in her reproductive health (she... didn't enjoy motherhood much, from what I remember, and might've liked it if it hadn't been forced on her - if she had a choice in whether she had children at all, you know?).

I think she had a lot of rage at her limited choices.

And she did hire convicts to work in her sawmills and treated them worse than her father had treated the slaves at Tara.

That too! It might've been in the same section? But it's been about 8 years since I read it, and some of weirdest bits have stuck. Like how she'd been too young to marry at 16, but Ellen wasn't - and had been *younger* when she'd married. (So close, Gerald. SO CLOSE, and yet the point went whoosh over his head!) Etc.

When I was reading that book, I was young and single. I went to a dance party and without even thinking I started channeling Scarlet. I just acted like her and the the guys were all over me.

That shit works. But I don’t want to be her.

She's a compelling protagonist BECAUSE she's "messy and flawed." I prefer to think of her as a survivor - at the beginning of the book, she's sixteen and the only life she's ever known changes dramatically and for the worse, but she survives it because she figures out how to adapt while most people around her just cling to the old ways or go under.

I have heard many people say that when they hear a person cite GWTW as their favorite book, they assume that person must be racist, but GWTW is one of my favorites, if not my top favorite, precisely because of Scarlett. She is such a complex and infuriating and admirable and dreadful and spiteful and blisteringly intelligent character. I ended the book wanting to slap the shit out of her. I love hate her.

I've always imagined that Scarlett would have realized that she didn't need a man and being a bad ass woman who not only saved herself but everyone around her was her path, and thus went on to build an empire, eventually meeting up with Rhett again and finally FINALLY making it work.

One of the sequels drifts in that direction while shitting on the Irish nearly as badly as the original shit on black people.

This book is in my top ten and I reread it often.

She does! I absolutely love this book!

We get to judge her and then see her grow through adversity. Great character development. And a morality play that needs to be revisited for southern women…?

She is one of my favorite characters. And I can always tell when people have only seen the movie and not read the book. You really get a sense of some of her inner turmoil over her actions in the book.

I hate her in the book. I'm quite frustrated that movie portrayed her as a much more positive version (still quite flawed) leaving the ending on an optimistic note.

By the time I reached the end of the book, the depths of her delusion and narcissism were breathtaking and it was clear she would never deal with these.

Part of this is just the power and charm of Vivian Leigh. She was captivating, despite her character's flaws.

Her complications are exactly what make her a compelling character, imo.

i love how scarlett is so stubborn that it turns to radical optimism lol, tomorrow is another day

it's a good book because of the messy protagonist, not despite it

The most favourite character !! She is flawed but it's her will & resilience and that makes her unforgettable for me.

I also read gwtw young and felt I understood the character of scarlet pretty well. What I didn't get until I was older was how the concept of slavery as portrayed in the book and movie is offensive and just plain wrong. The 'they were basically family' narrative is so historically inaccurate. I also got a similar lesson at school America history (and I grew up in Pennsylvania!!! Rural Pa but still..) No hate to Margarett Mitchell, she was a person of her time too, but I do hope modern children get a more accurate picture of how atrocious slavery really was.

Great character, shame about the book.

What shame? It's a great book.

I've always thought Billy Joel's She's Always A Woman could have been about Scarlett (not literally, I doubt he's read or seen it 😂)

Scarlett is complex and messy in a way that female characters are rarely allowed to be. She's bratty, selfish, pathetic, ruthless, brave, pragmatic and hopeful. She's allowed to fuck up and she's allowed to succeed. There are times we root for her while other times we are begging her to stop.

Because she's so layered she feels like a real person because of these things. Love her or hate her, but she ain't flat.

I'm confused. Why is it a revelation that a messy and flawed protagonist could be compelling? Isn't this what literature is? Are characters supposed to be perfect?

Once I read Gone with the Wind, I've always thought of Billy Joel's Always a Woman as Scarlett's song.

She can kill with a smile, she can wound with her eyes
And she can ruin your faith with her casual lies
And she only reveals what she wants you to see
She hides like a child
But she's always a woman to me
She can lead you to love
She can take you or leave you
She can ask for the truth
But she'll never believe
And she'll take what you give her as long as it's free
Yeah, she steals like a thief
But she's always a woman to me
Oh, she takes care of herself
She can wait if she wants
She's ahead of her time
Oh, and she never gives out
And she never gives in
She just changes her mind
And she'll promise you more
Than the Garden of Eden
Then she'll carelessly cut you
And laugh while you're bleedin'
But she'll bring out the best
And the worst you can be
Blame it all on yourself
'Cause she's always a woman to me
Oh, she takes care of herself
She can wait if she wants
She's ahead of her time
Oh, and she never gives out
And she never gives in

She just changes her mind

She is frequently kind

And she's suddenly cruel

She can do as she pleases

She's nobody's fool

And she can't be convicted

She's earned her degree

And the most she will do

Is throw shadows at you

But she's always a woman to me

Same. I read it at 18 yo and completely identified with Scarlett. I read it 5 times over the next 20+ years and each time had a completely new perspective. But, the last time I read it, I was a few years older than Rhett and my main feeling was "You are all babies with romantic problems that seem so inconsequential". I have been nervous to read it since then, hopefully I still love it!

T04 Ashley was Useless

Ashley was Useless Just did a rewatch for the first time in years. Never realized how actually useless Ashley is. Scarlett's sister is screaming & crying that She's gone & married my Mr. Kennedy! And Ashley goes I should've committed highway Robbery to get you that money. Well Duh!! But he never actually did anything to help. Never had any real vision for the Mill…like what was he even good for? Insufferable!

He is a great reminder of old times - if the war did not happen, he would be a perfect, bookish gentleman, 12 Oaks would be running smoothly as the last years, he would engage in intelectual conversations at dinner parties etc.

War has thrown all of that through the window and Ashley does not know what to make of it.

He did say he was going to free all his slaves though, which raises questions about running a plantation. But maybe he was happy to just sell off the land and not be wealthy.

This plus Ashley's quote about life before the war being beautiful having a 2-sentence line (that no one ever seems to talk about) "Maybe it wasn't so to everyone. I know that now." tells me that there's a bunch of character development with Ashley that we the reader just don't get to explore because the narrative doesn't take us there.

I doubt he would actually do that. I believe he would think it was a right thing to do, but then he would be swayed by an impending change in lifestyle, or some older slaves that would beg him not to turn them away from their only home, etc.

I'm sure he would find some friends to theoretize with about how slavery is bad and how they need to make a plan for ending it. Slowly.

He could have set them free and then hired anyone who wanted to continue working for him at a fair wage. I got the impression the Wilkeses were wealthy enough for that to be feasible. (All of this assuming the war never happened.)

I think that would work for a while, maybe a few decades. He would have to be okay with giving up the family ‘legacy’ of extreme wealth (which Ashley genuinely might be, I wouldn’t put it beyond him).

I doubt he'd forcibly make all the slaves leave the property. But he was pretty against the convict labour so I can definitely imagine him freeing them all and then realising he had no way of running the property. But maybe Melanie, India and Honey would have intervened.

Ashley wouldn’t force the slaves to leave; realistically, he’d free them & at the same time offer them a job, at which point some would choose to leave & some would choose to stay. I don’t remember if we ever get a number of how many people work the plantation at Twelve Oaks, but it was a lot, and they would’ve spanned multiple generations.

Except you couldn't just "free" slaves in antebellum Georgia. There was a law against recently freed former slaves living nearby their former owners. They were supposed to leave the area, I believe they had to go to another state, even, lest their freedom stir up any anti-slavery movement.

And, of course, if freedom comes with an automatic exile from your family and everything you know, people will be less likely to want it.

It was vile.

Even slaveowners who wanted to do better struggled to find any way to stop the system.

Very true, though I doubt when the book was written & the movie made that the average person could have been expected to know that; it's hardly a widely known fact even today. So I think it was Mitchell's way of symbolising yet again how much of a dream Ashley was, as opposed to being able to deal with the reality of the situation. That holds true for whether or not the war had come IMHO.

He would put it in his Will to free everyone so he could believe himself to be a good man and Christian, then his heirs would override it as happened constantly in real life. Only a handful of people stuck to their ethics and freed enslaved people when it would directly impact themselves

Might as well free them before you die then, if you mean then to be free

Yeah, saying he's do it and actually doing it are very different things. I could see him pulling a George Washington and freeing them all in his will, and thus punting responsibility for figuring out what to do next to Beau.

He wouldn't have to turn them out! If they wanted to stay he could just pay them

I always thought that was just a fanciful idea he had and he wouldn’t have done it.

Maybe. But he's fairly idealistic, so he might have. And it's an idea he had before the war and he didn't support the war. I think if anyone in Scarlett's circle was going to do it it would be Ashley.

He would not have freed his slaves when he realized he would no longer have his life of leisure without their free manual labor.

He probably had enough wealth outright at that point not to need Twelve Oaks to turn a profit.

True. He would have sat on the backs of the slaves and the women who ran Twelve Oaks, rode his horses and read his Shakespeare. Although, he says he would have freed the slaves if the war hadn't done it, but, what then? Teach school?

And of course there would still be slaves. Ashley's remark about freeing them if the war hadn't done so (in the film) as so much bullshit

Scarlett's first instincts being to correct the situation with the convicts but quickly letting her fears take over is 100% a trauma response. That doesn't make it good; it makes it real and understandable.

I never saw what Scarlett saw in him. Rhett was much more attractive. I even wanted to call my kid Rhett but it got vetoed. Fiddle dee dee, I say!

I always saw it as Ashley being like a plaything that she couldn't have, and the more unattainable he was, the more she wanted him. She could have any man, but he didn't want her, so that made him basically a challenge in her eyes. She was never really in love with him, because he was just a prize to be won. Had she won him, she'd have tired of him quickly as she did Charles and Frank, because he would bore her.

This, especially pre-war. Post-war, he's one of the few connections she has to the past before the war hardened her. She even says she's glad her mother didn't see what a 'bad girl' Scarlett has become in order to survive.

Originally I think he was very well bred and respected in the local area. Scarlett's father is basically new money and her mother's family is old Catholic, which isn't common in their local area. Later I think Scarlett holds onto it as a part of her pre-war life (before the war, before her parents die). Rhett's old money but a black sheep who mirrors Scarlett. Scarlett feels like she should honor her mother and be a "lady" but she's a 1930s modern lady as written.

I think Scarlett loved the Idea of Ashley rather than the flesh and blood Ashley. She held onto the dream of what he was before the war...before the blood and sweat and ugliness of war. I don't think she would have ever been happy with his quiet, intellectual ways.

To be fair he was supposed to have been a very good soldier. He just wasnt good at business.

Edit: I think we could also see Ashley as struggling with a great deal of PTSD. He fights in a war he doesn't believe in, all his friends die, he sees countless atrocities, his parents die while he's away, he is a POW in truly atrocious conditions that he almost doesn't survive, and has to walk home on foot to find every trace of his childhood home and life gone forever. I think he's partly just utterly exhausted, traumatised and depressed for the rest of the novel.

He was elected captain of his company at just twenty, which implies that he was charismatic enough to sway the vote and had natural leadership qualities. The problem was that he simply wasn't practical and never learned how to be.

I feel like he may have had potential as a politician in the post-Reconstruction era, but he may have been too much of an idealist for that. Instead, he'll probably struggle to run the lumber business that Rhett effectively donated to him, though he may have the good sense to partner up with someone who will run it for him while he handles the sales side of the business. If he does that, I could actually see him making a pretty good living.

It's implied that he and Rhett together effectively change the Klan/Democrats political strategy, so he definitely had influence.

He was practical in some aspects- politically, and several times he’s considered to have a good head in a crisis. He was just not practical in a long term planning way. It’s a shame he didn’t get to go North and work at a college or a bank, he probably would have done fine.

Though I can’t really blame him for not wanting to profit from convict labor and starvation, that bit was reasonable.

I think I was using “not practical” in the sense that he not the best with money or running a business, but he definitely has good sense when it comes to people. This is why I feel like the lumber business would have probably been best served by him running the sales and customer relations side while someone else ran the mills and did the books.

Yeah though I think at some point it says he kept giving lumber on credit to old friends and didn’t drive a hard bargain because he was too gentlemanly… so maybe he was just always going to haemorrhage money.

IRL, choosing commanding officers by election was one of the reasons the CSA army failed so enormously. Being elected meant he was popular, it didn't mean he had leadership qualities or was good at war.

And he was one of the few who never wanted to fight in the first place 😳

Rhett pointed out that Ashley is stuck in his old days and he wasn't prepared to deal the aftermath of war. He is more interested in arts and other sophistacted hobbies than managing a business. I get that Scarlett is attracted to him for his handsome apperance, intelligence and not being stubborn but that man felt being hopeless to deal the damage he saw.

We are told that Ashley is handsome, good, and noble. He is the "best" man in Scarlett's orbit, and that is why she wants him. He is everything she wants to be, but can't because her survival instincts are too strong. It's not so much about who Ashley as a person is, but more about what he represents that Scarlett wants - a return to the gentility of the old days, when she could imagine she was a good person.

This is such a savvy read on it!

In fairness to Scarlett, that's more or less what Ellen did when forbidden from marrying her cousin Phillippe. She immediately latched on to someone old enough to be her father in Gerald, who, as new money and Irish to boot, probably seemed exactly as unsuitable to her family as Rhett was to Scarlett's.

But that’s the point of the character. Literally all Ashley had was honor. If Scarlett had taken off her rose colored, childish glasses for Ashley she would have realized how weak and ineffective he was and she would have begun to despise him.

Her realization came far too late.

In the book it’s worse, Ashley knew what she was planning to do but did nothing to stop her. He hoped she would change her mind, that’s all.

Ugh…so frustrating! Like I get soldier ptsd & all, he came back damaged, etc., it’s just still hard to wrap my mind around how he had a head for battle & excelled in the ranks of the army but then zero drive or survival instinct once he returned to real life.

Ashley was popular before the war because he was wealthy and educated, as a Southern gentleman of that era was supposed to be. He was also 'tactical' in the entirely theoretical way that was expected of his class & station, not because of his own virtues or attributes.

He simple had no idea how or ability to adapt to an entirely new paradigm after the war. He'd been bred, raised, and educated for one thing only: to run a plantation as the master, while outsourcing the actual day-to-day realities to an overseer and to his wife, who would be in charge of the house and their family. When that reality disappeared, he was utterly lost and never truly recovered.

He was not as moral or honorable as he tries to present himself. An emotional affair is still an affair.

True! I'm also still just hung up on the 'moral' status he seems to be assigned. Yes, the emotional affair. But what's worse was how he allowed Scarlett to care for his wife, deliver his child, (literally risking her own life to save theirs!) provide for them in hellish conditions, only for him to come home & be like thanks, I think I'll try splitting rail road ties part time while you keep doing the heavy lifting! lol Don't get me wrong, I have no delusions of Scarlett being a stellar person. The only thing she was good at was survival.

But back then such a concept as an 'emotional' affair simply did not exist...so I find it hard to apply 2025 morals to a story set almost 200 years prior.

Scarlett with Ashley was mirroring the infatuation her mother had with her cousin Philip. Like mother like daughter. With Philip dead, he would always be young, beautiful, and not a real person.

Just like Ashley

I agree with all the above about Ashley being stuck in time.

I posted a reply above before reading this that said basically the exact same thing lol

In Ashley's defence he is well aware that he is completely useless, and he readily admits that he has no practical skill and is able to provide little help running a farm/ plantation/ mill after the war.

His did have a plan to go up north and work in banking (I think?) which may well have suited his quiet intelligence and bookish nature perfectly. However, the manipulation by a certain someone who had a crush on him persuaded his wife to veto him leaving Georgia.

I never understood why Scarlett was so obsessed with Ashley.

He was a mild mannered Southern gentleman, based on the way the book described him. I think he represented the unrealistic bubble their plantation lifestyle lived in. He was the total opposite of the passionate, assertive Rhett. But I agree with you. I guess that's why Ashley's family, the Wilkes' always married their cousins - they were all alike.

Even so, Melanie has strength of character that Ashley lacks.

Because Melanie was a WOMAN! Yes she absolutely did

Ashley is a broken idealist. I think that's kind o the point. He's moral (to an extent, he won't do the dirty with Scarlett, even if he commits an affair with her in his mind every time he sees her) but ultimately weak, passive, and easily manipulated, which is one reason Scarlett holds onto him. Unlike Rhett, she can get him to do whatever she wants.

Most of the characters in the book are divided between those who accept the old life is gone and get on with other ways to prosper (and Scarlett is the most prominent example of this), or they pretend the old ways never ended and just sink into squalor.

Ashley is an exception (and Rhett is the other exception but for different reasons). Ashley accepts the old life is gone and even acknowledges it was immoral anyway (I think he's the only character that does so), but it

was the only world he was suited to. Coupled with his likely PTSD from the war, he's basically buried in depression - he feels he's fit for nothing and no good to anyone. I wonder how he coped without Melanie - she really was his rock.

He might have soon followed Melanie to the grave. And Beau would end up being raised by Scarlett.

I think people forget that these characters were heavily traumatized by war and most of their decisions were based on living through PTSD without proper help. That's the beauty of the book - there are no villains or no absolutely positive characters. Even Melanie who everyone admires is useless in a way, living off Scarlett's back and being in denial about Scarlett's true motives. Ashley was the last reminder for Scarlett of the old ways, home and her childhood where she felt safe. As a matter of fact she deeply respects him for choosing Melanie over her because if he did escape with Scarlett, he'd be betraying his honor and tarnishing the portrait of the proper gentleman Scarlett idolized for so long. His character is pivotal in the story line to show the reader on how the Southerners were struggling to adjust to the new ways after the war. Lots of people seem to blame him for giving Scarlett hope and leading her on when in reality I think he just felt that he forever owes her and couldn't repay her with anything for the things she had done for him, Melanie and Beau. I don't even think he felt true sexual desire towards her. It was more of a trauma bond and his responsiveness to her "passion for living" that he deeply admired and lacked himself. That man came back from war dead inside, feeling useless, severely depressed and nothing but Scarlett's push could have dragged him out of the slumber.

Ashley would never have freed his slaves. That was just another one of Ashley’s wordy, empty speeches. Like his “I should’ve stolen that money” line. Woulda, shoulda, coulda. As he himself admitted, he would’ve freed them after his father’s death.

If it hadn’t been for the war and the stress that came with it, John Wilkes would’ve easily lived into his late 70s or 80s (or even 90s), like most men of his class typically did. By that time, Ashley would’ve been in his 50s or 60s, and I think those youthful ideals would’ve long since vanished from his head—because he would’ve had to pay dowries for his sisters and eventual daughters, and also fund his son(s)’ education and travels across Europe.

Ashley was probably the kind of man who had never dressed himself before the war.

On top of that, freeing the slaves would’ve been a precedent on a scale unheard of in the South, and neighbors along with their social pressure would’ve quickly talked him out of the idea. Or he would’ve had to flee to the North—which he clearly didn’t want to do. After all, if that life didn’t suit him, he could’ve gone North after returning from Europe. But he liked the Southern gentleman lifestyle.

Ashley didn’t resist Scarlett or Melanie very hard when they asked him not to go North to work at the bank, did he? ONE conversation was enough. And that was about his independence and his ability to stand on his own two feet.

It’s one thing to talk about ideals and correspond with enlightened minds; it’s another to take real action. I guarantee you: in his mind, Ashley would’ve been a staunch opponent of slavery, and at the same time owned a hundred people. Just like he was 100% married to one woman (Melanie did get pregnant, after all), while telling another woman he couldn’t imagine her husband even touching her.

Just like he claimed to abhor violence and slavery—and yet was a member of the white sheets.

Was his decision to go to war a matter of honor and belief in ideals, or rather the result of social pressure exerted on him?

He could go on and on about ideals, but he never once took responsibility for his own life. He didn't like getting his hands dirty, but he still accepted a paycheck from Scarlett. His lumber mill was losing her money, so at the second one, the prisoners had to be exploited even more. And yes, he knew that perfectly well.

Ashley was the kind of person who didn't want to deal with real life and its real problems. The only thing he would've done with his plantation is hand over all responsibility to Melanie—because Melanie wouldn't hurt a soul, right?

And he? He'd have locked himself away in the library.

They say Abe Lincoln got his start splitting rails. Just think what heights Ashley may climb to once he gets the knack.

Ashley was too weak—being overly sensitive and romantic during times of war is not ideal. Scarlett only wanted him because he didn't choose her; for her, it was just a whim. Rhett was pragmatic, more similar to Scarlett in nature, and she respected him.

I roll my eyes when people say "I should've…" and then do nothing about it.

Yes to all of this!! 💯

FR he's so frigging annoying

Ashley was not a ruthless man, and ruthlessness was required to flourish in the post-war South.

I never understood why Scarlet was so enamored with him. He was boring. And he had two women that wanted him. Of course, Scarlet only wanted him because he did not trip over himself for her affections.

I've never understood what Scarlett saw in him. He's goofy looking, cowardly, and about as useful as tits on a boar. Rhett was much better.

I always thought that

T05 Ashley Wilkes and Scarlett's accusation

Ashley Wilkes and Scarlett's accusation There is a lot of commentaries about Ashley leading Scarlett on and lying to her, not directly telling her "No". Let me add my two cents in defence of Ashley.

Scarlett accuses him of lying to her, "but you told me you love me! If you do, why don't you choose me?!" I don't think he is lying at all. Scarlett is more direct and oblivious to emotional nuances; Ashley, on the other hand, is emotionally intelligent. Love can be a very broad spectrum. You love your parents – and it is love, you love your friends – and it is also love; your neighbours, your country... Now I'm older and more bitter towards people, but in my younger years I would think bad of someone only if that someone would do something really, really bad. I could go for miles looking for silver lining, and could generally say I love most of the people who I interacted with. So Ashley is not lying when he is saying "Yes, I do love you" towards Scarlett. He loves her personality, admires her, even if he chooses not to challenge himself to be with a person who is so different from him. You can fully appreciate someone without willing to get closer or spending a lifetime with them. That's what he is saying to Scarlett, but she fails to understand.

And a minor add: Ashley calls Melanie his dream come true. What can be bigger than that? Dreams, in some way, are meant to be unattainable. That is in their definition. To have embodied dream near you all day every day, what can be better? Ashley almost directly ranking Melanie above Scarlett (almost, because he is a gentleman and must not upset any lady), but Scarlett, again, doesn't want to listen.

In the book, Scarlett is 16 at that point, of course she's blind to emotional nuances! Ashley is 20-odd and has had a decent education, as well as being thoughtful by nature, of course he has a better idea of how things would go if they married.

So I can believe that he has a crush on her as well as the hots, but he knows he wouldn't have the kind of life he wants to have if he married his crush and not his cousin.

I"m struggling with the idea that they saw each other from the time she was 14. LOL I have got to reread this book--I can't believe there's a sub for it.

And then there's the kiss when he's home for Christmas break in Atlanta and the kiss in the barn at Tara. Ashley was definitely giving her mixed messages. Do I believe that he loved her as a friend? absolutely. Do I believe he admired her strength and her courage and her drive absolutely?. Do I also think that he was sexually attracted to her? absolutely.

To be fair to Scarlett, Ashley did take her out once a week for 2 years. <-- this was definitely him leading her on based on 1860 standards. A marriage proposal would be expected when she comes of age - which is about the time the book starts. He never spoke to her about Melanie in those 2 years so Scarlett had no way of knowing Melanie's true importance to him. I can see why she thought his family pressured him into marrying Melanie. But definitely by the end of the war she should have figured it out. I think Scarlett loved the idea of being loved. The second she finds out that Ashley doesn't love her, she is instantly over her infatuation. There was no heartache. No lingering urge to try to win his love. Her feelings are just Poof! gone.

Exactly. He was certainly one of her beaux. He wasn't calling on the Tarleton girls and Cathleen Calvert like that. Just Scarlett and Melanie.

Damn. Forgot they dated for two years.

Didn't she get more attention from the other young men?

That is true!

He's still an ass. He knows she's infatuated with him and tells her he loves her. Maybe he meant it in abstract way, but there's no way he didn't know what his words conveyed to her.

I think they were infatuated with each other, but he realized that they were incompatible.

When Melly is dying, she asks Scarlett to help Ashley because she knows that he's basically helpless without her. She was 'The Woman behind the Man".

I think he loved her but knew he could never marry her. He was expected to marry Melanie. It was his duty and Ashley was a gentleman. Ashley was not always true to himself. He put honor before his own happiness.

He married Melanie because he loved her. Why do so many people miss that?

After Melanie died, he said that she (Melanie) was the only one of his dreams to come true.

I disagree--I think Ashley was attracted to Scarlett, but deeply loved Melanie.

Reminds me a lot of the Edward Ferrars saga in Sense and Sensibility he would have married Lucy Steele had his brother not, because of being a Gentleman, even though he may not have passionately loved her.

I think Ashley loved Melanie, but it wasn't the lust and admirability he felt for Scarlett. He enjoyed the flirtation with Scarlett, as did most of the males from the book, but unlike some of the others..like Charles, Ashley had no intention to marry her.

To be fair, Scarlett wasn't a huge fan of marriage. She was raised with marriage as a goal, and when she married she felt her life was over. She found it more tolerable with Frank and Rhett. Largely because Frank usually didn't resist her demands (certainly not for long), and Rhett was comfortable with her generally doing as she pleased.

Ashley enjoyed flirtation with Scarlett, but flirtation was really what she enjoyed also. Ashley had the sense to know it would be a disaster if they were a couple. I think for Scarlett the idea of marrying him was partially an end goal due to expectations and partially seeing it as winning him.

Yes, the Wilkes were one of the richest families in the County, bore an old and prestigious Virginia name, and had the prettiest mansion. Scarlett wanted to be mistress of Twelve Oaks and thus Queen of the County just as badly as she wanted Ashley.

To an extent, except Scarlett didn't fully grasp the difference between wealth and prestige. She proves this after the war and her associations with the carpetbaggers. Although, she does seem to genuinely admire Twelve Oaks.

Hmmm I think she did grasp it or was aware of it in social settings - because she knew her Aunt Eulalie apologized for her behind her back and that the Charlestonians looked down on her because of Gerald. I think it was just sort of the cherry on top with Ashley/made him that much more perfect to her. After the war a lot went out the window with her.

To me, the burden of responsibility falls on Ashley. Not only was he the man (in the 1860s and 1870s), he was older, he called on Scarlett in their youth of his own free will, and he understood her while she never could understand him until the very end.

He also just likes the attention from her which is annoying as he's married, has a large extended family deeply embedded in the region, and has the admiration of all. Scarlett is accepted because of Ellen's old family name and because she's beautiful and says and does mostly the right things, putting a toe over the line here and there and operating covertly in girl world - but there's always an asterisk there because her father is an Irish immigrant. She's accepted because of Ellen despite Gerald. Being accepted grudgingly or always being just on the fringe of high society - that sticks with people and messes with them.

You nailed it with this.

People say Ashley never really loved Scarlett, when it's obvious he did; there are different types of love, as well as different levels.

Right, he did. She never loved him - it was limerance (intense infatuation). He represented the perfect southern gentleman to her - and she was raised by her mother with a reverence for the old South and the prestige of the oldest Southern Families - especially those from Tidewater Virginia (where the Wilkes' were from), Charleston, and Savannah.

Scarlett was in love with the idea of Ashley, who she thought he was. Not until the last chapters does she realize that the man she was in love with never actually existed.

Yes, what she loved was the idea of Ashley that she had built, that and the fact that she couldn't have him. All her temptations, all his flirting back, but he would still not succumb to her and cheat on Melanie.

And remember, she thought she loved Ashley for who he was, but when her dad was trying to tell her how different Ashley was from all the rest of her family and all their friends, how he had a whole different way of being, Scarlett impatiently said, as if it should be obvious "Oh, Pa, if we got married I'd change all that!"

Yes! I love the line where she said she forced him into pretty clothes that she loved even though they never really fit him - something like that

I just want you to know your sentence “You can fully love someone without being willing to get closer or spend a lifetime with them.” Is one of the most profound things I’ve ever read, and not because of Charlotte and Ashley. I’m saving it as a quote.

Scarlett — autocorrect

I always believe that Ashley does have a crush on Scarlett (or the very least finds her attractive physically) but it's not in his nature to pursue Scarlett because of his nature.

He's more introverted and thoughtful. He's got enough awareness to know that Melanie was the right woman and partner for him. He knows that Melanie understand him. But I also believe he truly does love Melanie.

But I also agree with the part that Ashley admires Scarlett's 'fiery' nature and her passion. His attraction to Scarlett definitely leans on the physical though, he was tempted because the two of them had those kisses. I think he did give her a mixed message because of that. He knows he's weak to resist the temptation of Scarlett but he also knows he can't be with Scarlett and have a life that is suited to him (peaceful, etc).

The thing about Ashley is that his characterization is very consistent if very annoying. He will, at all turns, take the path of least resistance, even if that means fighting in a war he knows is wrong!!!!! because that is what's expected of him. Like, imagine how unwilling you have to be to take a stand that you're like ¯_(ツ)_/¯ guess I'll go fight in a war rather than go against what everyone else in my social class is doing. While he does love her, I think he would have married Melanie regardless because that's what was done. He says he would have freed the enslaved people at Twelve Oaks after his father died, but that would have required so much initiative and action, I doubt it.

I can see him being boggled that Scarlett thinks that he's in love with her because like, he is married to Melanie and he had, actually, turned her down in the library, but I also think he's like... this will require so much inner strength to go against this and I don't want to. So he kisses her and is like oh man :(that wasn't a good move :(like DUDE MAKE A CHOICE IN YOUR DAMN LIFE

Even when he's like okay! I am going to be Strong and Move My Family Up North (because SOMEONE! IS! HANDING! HIM! A! JOB! I cannot stress enough how inert this guy is in his own life!) it takes two seconds of plotting and some tears to undo it because Ashley is like ¯_(ツ)_/¯ I can't go against both of you.

Honestly, saying that he leads Scarlett on might give him more agency than he actually possessed. He's not leading her on. He's not doing anything to not lead her on. The man is floating along in the current of life with no paddles.

He is an amazing example of someone being pathetic, and by that I mean "being so weak and inadequate that it inspires contempt." The fact that Scarlett doesn't despise him is how you can tell she never updated her opinion him, because she cannot staaaaand weakness and would not tolerate this behavior from anyone else.

I... actually think Ashley WAS in love with Scarlett. The one time his POV is seen in the novel, he's thinking (mentally gushing) how gallant she is, how brave.

(He and Melly are living at Tara after the war.)

I think Ashley loved both women, but understood that Scarlett put him on a pedestal and saw him as tougher than he was. Melanie saw him as he was and willingly played "Little Wife" while actually being in charge of their family.

So, yes. I think he gave mixed signals.

Yes, he loved her. But he was wise enough to recognize that beyond the bedroom, they would be miserable together.

Unrequited love was once thought as the strongest form of love and that certainly sums up Scarlett and Ashley. For the majority of the story it could also describe Rhett's and Scarlett's relationship.

I'm not sure why Ashley's relationship with Scarlett was written like it was, it seemed to even perplex Rhett. I seem to recall Rhett saying that Ashley was incapable of being emotionally faithful to his wife, but wouldn't be physically unfaithful to her, or words to that effect.

I do think Ashley had real feelings for Scarlett, but lived such a structured, ordered life that his course was set and to not follow it through would be dishonorable. An argument could be made that his refusal to really set boundaries and tell Scarlett in no uncertain terms that his heart belonged to Melanie, was less than honorable. The character of Ashley was certainly getting something out of being pursued and I think that was justification for his own sincere, though tortured feelings

Oh, he loved her, but he knew they'd make a terrible couple. She'd quickly grow tired of him, then she'd chew him up and spit him out.

Ashley is a coward, that's all you need to know

The kisses at Christmas and at Tara definitely sent her mixed signals. He could have avoided , or given a chaste peck when asked. He was married and loved the attention from Scarlett and gave in easily to his desire for her.. What got me the most though, was when Ashley was shocked and judgey at the mill upon Scarlett's return after having Bonnie. He was in a dream world that Scarlett was a sweet innocent girl like she was once in their youth. He could not see her business choices were largely her own, including hiring convicts. Him blaming Rhett and then saying he hates to think of Scarlett in Rhett's arms makes him crazy sealed it for Scarlett. She had no problem kicking her husband Rhett to the curb. Ashley wasn't having marital relations with Melonie because she couldn't get pregnant. Scarlett was a constant temptation to him, a veritable tease. He knew that she would take these comments to heart and essentially end her marriage to Rhett by refusing sex. I hate that scene and Ashley as a result. I firmly believe that Ashley led Scarlett on.

I partially agree with you—Ashley was refusing to see that Scarlett had made her own choices—the business, convict labor, etc., and that the war and life's changes had sharpened and hardened parts of her personality that had always been there.

Maybe he should have known she'd reject Rhett sexually after his comments, but I honestly don't think he did. I think that just as Scarlett refused to face Ashley's intrinsic nature, that he also refused to face hers. To some extent he understood they were basically incompatible, but he also dressed her up in pretty clothes and cherished her as an ideal in his mind. These comments about Rhett coarsening her just prove that he's not able to fully see her true self.

You think Ashley knew that Scarlett would kick Rhett out of her bed?

I do think Ashley genuinely loved Scarlett and her passion for life and her strength. And I think he wished he could be with her. But I think he also knew that she would just steam roll right over him and make him feel emasculated their entire marriage. Which she also did to her two other husbands.

Melanie, on the other hand, also had strength of steel, but she did it in a more quiet and supportive way and made Ashley feel like he was the man of the house and taking care of her. Not the other way around.

So...to recap my rambling...I think he did love her...and probably did lead her on....but also realized that they were not a good match for marriage.

Oh I love this topic! Ashley never lead her on. Ever. He made it so clear but also was sexually attracted to her. She was a temptress and she also felt like a sister. It was a weird dynamic for him. Also he was the most idiotic stump emotionally. I use him as a reference for dumb as a stump. Charles too. Cute but stupid?

Ashley was educated but he was in his own world. His own head. He never wanted anything but the life he had at twelves oaks. His dream with melanie was everything but scarlett was the sexy temptress like a devil on his shoulder. He was naive in so many ways. I think he wanted to believe scarlett like melanie but he knew the truth under it all but refused to recognize it.

I always loved how melanie responded at ashleys party in reaponse to the accusation india made. She basically laughed it off and made it clear scarlett was her SISTER and Ashleys SISTER. India would die if she were accused of the same with her own brother. Melanie was making a point to everyone that they were family. She has always been my favorite character in the novel.

Uh... There's a lot to unpack here.

T06 Ashleys or Rhetts of the world

Who do you respect more, the Ashleys or Rhetts of the world? One of the most powerful story elements of Margaret Mitchell's Gone With the Wind is the striking differences (yet similarities) between 2 of the main characters, Rhett Butler and Ashley Wilkes.

For those who never read the book, these characters are polar opposites that however share some things in common.

To start off with their similarities. Both men are well-educated, highly intelligent, and very courageous. Both had their lives affected by the Civil War.Both ABSOLUTELY thought the war was sheer stupidity. Both were outstanding soldiers in the war.

However here is where the similarities end.

Ashley Wilkes was a patriot at the core. Even though he opposed slavery enough that he would have freed all his slaves upon his fathers death had the war had not come and even though he knew that the Confederacy

would have ultimately lost the war, he still volunteered to fight from the moment Georgia decided to enter the war.

After the war ended, Ashley continued to try to live under the Southern code of honor. He did so much to live as the ideal Southern "Gentleman" before the war that he ended up living in poverty and his family suffered as a result. He was that patriotic, refusing to adapt to the new world if it would require him to breach "Honor" and he was nostalgic for the days of antebellum South later on by the time the story was in its final stage.

During the War, he was captured as PoW at one of the worst Civil War POW camps (can't remember the name). The conditions was such in the camp troops were starved and living under conditions comparable to a concentration camp. Mortality rates were high. Ashley Wilkes was given the choice to give up his loyalties to the Confederacy and instead fight for the Union in the West against Indians (which he had a much better chance of surviving). Ashley was so patriotically loyal he refused the offer and stayed in the camp until the war's end.

After the War, Ashley's spirit was destroyed when the Confederacy collapsed.

Rhett Butler was the exact opposite. He absolutely despised the South and its customs and mocked the Confederacy in front of patriotic citizens whenever he could. He committed acts of fraud on both the Union and Confederate sides to make a profit. While its true within the context of the story, some of his actions actually helped the Confederacy such as his acts of illegally bringing in weapons and necessities to the Confederacy during the Blockade, he openly admits the only reason he did such acts was to make a profit and if he could make more money by aiding the Union he would have sided with them instead.

Rhett before the war was an utter thug who murdered several people for fun and already committed acts of fraud for profit.

He could care less about the Confederacy's fate and never thought of fighting for the Confederacy until the very end when he departed from Scarlett after the burning of Atlanta. Even there I suspected his reason for joining the remnants of the Confederacy army to serve as an artilleryman in the last months of the war was motivated not out of patriotism but out of self-interest.

Even more striking differences come after the war. Where as Ashley's spirit was killed post-civil war, Rhett's spirit was more enthusiastic than ever. He thought the fall of the Confederacy and the Reconstruction was a blessing, and opportunity to make profits and become rich. Which is exactly what he did through a combination of deceit, fraud, and shrewd business skills. In addition its later revealed in the story that Rhett took a large portion of the Confederate's last gold reserves before it collapsed and hid it somewhere. Other Confederate veterans did the same but they honestly returned it to the now-sovereign Union government after the war. Rhett did not-after being released from prison for several more murders, he got his hidden gold and used the almost all of it to invest and make even more profits and put into his savings accounts.

His life took a different direction from Ashley- he would become one of the RICHEST men in the South because of his disregard for honor and patriotism.

As you can see the characters are polar opposites-patriots and traitor, thug and law-abiding citizen, traditional and revolutionary.

Just in the final chapter of the story, when Scarlett told Rhett how weak she discovered Ashley was, Rhett told Scarlett:

“If you must see him (Ashley) as he really is, see him straight. He’s only a gentleman caught in a world he doesn’t belong in,trying to make a poor best of it by the rules of the world that’s gone.”

I've been reading more on various aspects of History, and what I noticed in any civilization, upon its collapse you can easily notice upon the Rhetts and Ashley of that civilization be it the Anglo-Saxons, the Romans, the Byzantines, the Native Americans, and so on.

Who do you have more respect for-The Ashley or Rhetts throughout history?

Saw that this thread is old and thought I would pipe my two cents in.

I don't think I could respect Ashley in real life.

He's willing to die for a country that would put him in danger and not help him out when starving or in poverty. He's willing to put his family into poverty and rely on Scarlett for an income. Duty to the country/Scarlett is his folly.

He leads Scarlett on for many years. Why not just tell her the truth and let her move on.

I could understand Rhett's motivation and actions during the who book. He is so loathsome in some scenes but also has his reasons. His downfall was loving Scarlett. I like his respectful relationship with Melanie even though he knows Ashley is a fool.

You're really sheltered. Its precisely why men like Ashley why countries survive and remain stable. Without guys willing to die to protect your group, you'd be overwhelmed by outside clans who only see you as food for the table.

And frankly birthright is so universal to cultures Ashley isn't unique for it. I mean have yous seen our current President's upbringing? As well as our previous one? Its universal that people born to parents with good reputation automatically gets privilege. Its the whole reason why some families stand out while others remain forever at the bottom of the system.

I haven't had the chance to reply and am late to reply.

First, I'd like to add. You know nothing about me to say I'm sheltered. You are some random person that is projecting.

Second, I'd like to add. You missed my point entirely. And, my point is that Ashley was a fool with his ideals in this storyline.

I know plenty of people who fight for and respect their country tremendously. You made a blanket statement and projected. It happens, I was specifically referring to Ashley's character arc and what bugged me about it. It's a story.

Anyways, my views are the same. I respect anyone else who might have good reasons to fight for the country.

I appreciate your comment either way. Discourse is the best way to learn.

You really are sheltered though. Because you haven't lived in a 3rd world country (or any nonwhite country for that matter) and it shows in your inability to understand social hierarchy and how rigid lots of cultures view it.

Ashley behavior after the war? Its the norm in South Asia and it was a very big problem in China after the communist wons the Civil War.

But you can't understand why so many cultures like

Shows who's the real one who's projecting! 😂

"Shows who's the real one who's projecting!"

Both of us are actually lol.

Ill also keep things on the topic to the original thread. My mind hasn't changed.

In terms of my view on Ashley. I prefer Rhetts of the world. He fought in the war and made a profit off of it. He is practical, won't starve or procreate unless he can provide, and has a heart beneath everything. Those are some of the main reasons why I prefer Rhett. And I agree with you. I'm viewing things with my own lense which has been influenced by environment. Literature is meant to be interpreted subjectively.

You made some really good points until things got patronizing.

"Confucianist have so many citizens act in the way Ashley did because you are so blinded by your American-centric view of the world." This point specifically got patronizing.

Keep it respectful and we can continue conversing.

Otherwise take care~

Ashley is the worst. Weak and overly dramatic. If a forthright thought crossed his brow he'd blow it away like dandelion fuzz. I loathe every scene with him.

Will Benteen on the other hand is better than any of them.

T07 Why did Mitchell choose the name "Ashley"

Why did Margaret Mitchell Chose "Ashley"?Is it to show he is weak and effeminate? Or was it actually a common name in the Antebellum South? In a Gone With the Wind blog I went to a years ago, this comment in a post got me.

So, everybody knows Rhett Butler. If you know Rhett, you probably also know Ashley. George Ashley Wilkes. (I don't know why he didn't go by George, its a much more manly name.)

Reading the comment reminded me of something I wondered years ago.

If you look on Wikipedia's article of Gone With the Wind, there is a comment that Ashley Wilkes being the epitome of unmanliness:

"A "young girl's dream of the Perfect Knight",[62] Ashley is like a young girl himself.[63] With his "poet's eye",[64] Ashley has a "feminine sensitivity".[65] Scarlett is angered by the "slur of effeminacy flung at Ashley" when her father tells her the Wilkes family was "born queer".[66] (Mitchell's use of the word queer is for its sexual connotation because queer, in the 1930s, was associated with homosexuality.)[67] Ashley's effeminacy is associated with his appearance, his lack of force and sexual impotency.[68] He rides, plays poker and drinks like "proper men", but his heart is not in it, Gerald claims.[66][69] The embodiment of castration, Ashley wears the head of Medusa on his cravat pin.[66][67]

Not only is Scarlett's love interest, Ashley Wilkes, lacking manliness, her husbands, the "calf-like"[13] Charles Hamilton, and the "old-maid in britches",[13] Frank Kennedy, are unmanly as well. Mitchell is critiquing masculinity in southern society since Reconstruction.[70] Charles, Frank and Ashley represent the impotence of the post-war white South.[60] Its power and influence has been diminished."

When I was a Windie years ago, long before Wikipedia was as mainstream and commonly found on the search engine as it is today, I always wondered why Margaret Mitchell gave the name Ashley instead of a more masculine name. As opposed to most in the Windie fandom I felt while Ashley had huge flaws, he was anything but a coward and was one of the bravest characters in the story.

As I finally read the whole book cover-to-cover this year, while I agree Ashley Wilkes in the end is a weakling he isn't as big of a sissy wimp as as the fandom criticize him as. Yes years later I still hold the opinion Ashley has admirable qualities and while he lacks the strength to adapt into a new world, I felt he was anything but a sissy wimp. Weakling in some ways?Definitely. Sissy Wimp?Anyone who says so should try marching for miles with Civil War equipment. To see what hardships Ashley faced. A true wimp couldn't have endured the marching let a lone fight valiantly in the battlefield as Ashley did! So I was truly puzzled why he was given a girl's name.

Some years earlier, I was playing Evil Dead:Regeneration. In the scene where Ash William's tombstone was revealed just as he was coming back to life, it stated: "Ashley J. Williams". Ash Williams is one of the most BADASS characters in Horror cinema who takes on horrific creatures from demons to ghosts to even skeleton armies. At this point I began to wonder if I was using Ashley in a wrong cultural context. I know Ash Williams according the expanded universe came from some Southern town.

So I did research and I learned a long time ago Ashley was actually a name for both guys and girl. There was actually a time when Ashley was frequently used as a guy's name especially in the Old South. In fact it was considered among the MOST MANLY names you could have given a son during the 1800s especially in the Old South.

So despite how many Windies think that Ashley was chosen to show the character as an effeminate weakling, my resarch on the name made me come to the conclusion that Mitchell chose the name because it was considered an ideal masculine one and Ashley Wilkes is supposed to represent the ideal Gentleman so hence she chose what was (within the time and cultural context) as manly name.

However I made this conclusion out of speculation. I would like your input. Can you give me more reason why Margaret Mitchell chose the name "Ashley" in addition to what I concluded?Or is what I stated pretty much the probable reason?

In history, the name Ashley can be traced back to medieval England, where it was often used to identify individuals residing or owning land in areas known for their ash trees. the name evolved into a first name during the 18th century, growing in popularity among families of English descent.

In the 1940s, Americans started using the Ashley for girls and was more common for girls starting in 1964. Ashley was considered a surname style name at the time.

Gone With The Wind (the book) was published in 1936. The film came out in 1939. Ashley is a unisex name, but it didn't become more feminine-leaning until after Gone With The Wind was already published and filmed.

I actually don't think Ashley is a wimp. His problem is he's more intelligent than his peers and this is coupled with being dutiful to a fault.

So take his stance on the civil war. Unlike the Tarletons etc, he knows the Confederates probably can't win. He also doesn't really think the justifications for slavery hold much water. But he fights in the Civil War because it's his duty. And by all accounts he's a brave and capable commander despite having little faith in the cause or its prospects.

Also see his involvement in the KKK. Unlike the others, he doesn't agree with it morally and he also realises it's foolish to stir up trouble. But he takes part out of duty to his people at least until he has Rhett as an ally to convince them to end this tactic.

Finally with Scarlett, like every man in the story he's attracted to her, but he has the intelligence to realise they're ill suited whereas he and Melanie have similar interests and temperaments. Of course, he realises the strain this puts on Scarlett and Melanie so tries to move to New York. But Scarlett manipulates Melly into getting him to stay by preying on that rigid sense of duty. He'll be miserable working in Scarlett's mill, but does what is expected of him.

In a way, he's an interesting contrast with Rhett. Their assessment of the world and the other characters nearly always agrees, but while Rhett is mostly a cynic, Ashley is almost paralysed by his sense of honour and duty in a world where, as he recognises, such things bring very little joy.

Fair assessment of Ashley. I do want to add though, that Ashley isn't exactly trying to be successful at anything. Yes, he's depressed and he hates the world but he has a wife and a child to support and if it weren't for Scarlett, they wouldn't have anything. Even Melanie knows that Ashley is kind of dead weight. He's honorable but his honor is misplaced in the service of providing for his family, something that the other aristocratic slave holding families are doing. Removing his wife and child to a region where they don't know anybody or have any connections is also pretty selfish. He's not a wimp but his depression leads him to be complacent and impractical at a time when you need action the most.

I agree with you that he was depressed and that hurt his drive to do something positive. He also probably had PTSD. That said, part of Ashley's problem is he's badly suited to manual work and the more intellectual work that would suit him better is all going to the scallywags and carpetbaggers.

Some of the old slaveholders just sink into squalor while reminiscing about the good old days, while others pull themselves up doing manual work (farming, baking, woodwork, wagon driving etc) and earn a modest living. Ashley seems to recognise the former are deluded, but he lacks the skills and mindset to be one of the latter. Becoming a banker in New York probably wasn't the worst idea in those circumstances even if far from ideal. And had the bonus of removing himself from Scarlett.

I wouldn't go as far as to say he hates the world. And I'm not sure if I'd characterize his behavior before the war as being depressed either. He reminds me of a couple of people I know where they've always felt like they didn't fully belong to their environment/community/social group..but would also be hard pressed to feel like they belonged anywhere, in any group, in this reality at least. They'd go through the motions expected of them but their heart wouldn't really be in it. Ashley buries himself in books and lives in la la land and was able to do so at the beginning b/c of the luxurious life afforded to him. When the war took away those luxuries, he found himself unable to cope but continues to slave away miserably out of a sense of responsibility/duty to his family.

Personally I thought he would've been equally miserable in New York working as a banker since we know he's terrible with numbers and was making a mess of the books at the mill. And it would've been even more stressful for shy, introverted Melanie to adapt to NYC's bustling city life (talk about culture shock!). I doubt distance would've dampened Scarlett's determination to win him over (if she was still convinced he actually loved her). She wouldn't just "forget about him." She would've found some excuse to move up there or at least visit frequently enough.

Keep in mind that MM initially named Scarlett “Pansy” (🤢). Changing it to Scarlett was not her idea.

Everything you said about the fandom liking to unfairly dunk on Ashley as being a wimp is accurate.

Pansy?! (In Scarlett's voice)...GOOD GOD!!! What was she thinking! 😈

Thank God she changed it! ...pansy...ew

I learned something new today thank you.

Lol I didn’t know that 😂 I couldn’t imagine a Pansy being the belle of the county

Omg, I didn't know that! Where was it revealed that she had planned that? Then again, she did prefer to go by her self-given nickname of Peggy, which I personally think is such a dumpy name (but that's probably b/c nowdays Peggy is very uncool/unsexy).

I read it somewhere on the internet, so feel free to take it with a grain of salt. Iirc, changing the heroine’s name to Scarlett was one of the last changes made to the book before publishing, and it was the editor who told MM that Pansy was not the right name.

Another thing is that Ashley is his middle name (his first name, George, is only mentioned briefly in the book and never in the movie if memory serves me), and is likely an old family name. It wasn’t uncommon for men to be given an old family name, such as the maiden name of one’s mother or grandmother, as a middle name in the 1800s and it was also quite common for men to go by that middle name to distinguish them from other men in their family with the same first name. In fact, Rhett is also a family name and had it not been made explicit that this was Captain Butler’s first name, I’d suspect he was going by his middle name as well.

Scarlett is the same - goes by her middle name, which is an old family name and also a surname.

She was named after her father Gerald's mother Katie Scarlett O'Hara. With Scarlett being Gerald's mother's maiden name.

Yes, family name (Gerald's mother's name), surname (maiden name)

Funnily enough, Rhett's middle name was King. And Clark Gable was known as "the King of Hollywood." MM's 1st husband "Red"'s middle initial was also K. (Berrien "Red" Kinnard Upshaw).

Ashley has only become a female name in recent decades. It was formerly considered a male name

Very common name for men

Maybe she just liked it? I have a friend who is a writer & she says that most of her character names, are just ones that either pop into her head, or ones that as she's writing them, just show up. She said she wrote one section of her story, and when she went back to read over it, realized she named a character in it, without

knowing she had. She just said "Well, I guess that's their name!" I always imagined writers naming characters, the way people name children.

All the names have a good rhythm - Scarlett O'Hara, Ashley Wilkes, Rhett Butler, Melanie Hamilton etc.

You could go deep and think ash is pale, while scarlet and "red" are much brighter and more vibrant.

And Scarlett and Rhett's names rhyme like their personalities As well as Ashley and Melanie.

Wow! I never picked up on that one, it's true.

Same my mind is blown!

Oh, this can absolutely happen, speaking as a fic writer that researches names like crazy. Someone submitted a character that had power over fire, so I went looking through names meaning fire until I landed on Brandr, which is old norse for Flame, and his partner is over earth and we just went with the name Tir because of Tir na nog and all that.

Some characters absolutely name themselves. We have a character named Freya and it was just supposed to be a one off, then the character became bigger. Most of the OC's are based around a name meaning and working backwards.

It's a reference to something in Birth of a Nation I think but I can't remember, it's a removed character name or was going to be the name of a character and was changed or something. I remember seeing it mentioned in a documentary about silent films

You could also say the same for its actor, Leslie Howard. Leslie is seen as a female name nowdays, but I think it had been a common name for boys in the previous century.

Humphrey Bogart and Leslie Howard were very close friends that he even named his daughter (but surprisingly not his son) after him and called her "Leslie Howard Bogart". However, I think no one batted an eye because Leslie have become a unisex name already at that time.

My high school sweetheart is named Ashley(born in 1971)

I thought the name Ashley, in a way, represented Atlanta and the South burning to ‘ashes’-with Ashley being lost in the aftermath of the war.

I also thought Rhett sounds like ‘Red’ which is scarlet. Those 2 characters having much in common.

Melanie sounds like ‘mellow.’ I’m sure MM didn’t do any of this intentionally, but I like the associations.

T08 Why does Scarlett "love" Ashley

Ok, but why does Scarlett "love" Ashley so much? I know this is probably an overplayed topic, but I just got into Gone with the Wind (I'm not from the US, so I just now at my ripe old age of 24 discovered it). First movie, now I'm reading th a book and I don't really understand what Scarlett sees in Ashley.

I get the appeal of him, but not from her POV. Almost every passage that's actually about him (not just about how much she wants him), her thoughts are pretty much: Omfg, everything this man does and says and thinks it so freaking boring, I don't understand a single word and I'm not gonna try because it's so wildly uninteresting.

Like... If they ever actually got together, she'd go CRAZY.

Like I said, I know it's overplayed topic, but I unfortunately don't have anyone to talk to about this 😆

It's hard to explain why someone is obsessed or infatuated with another.

One of my assumptions was that Ashley was the 'unattainable' neighbor 'hottie' for Scarlett. All the 'boys' were falling all over themselves for her. They'd make a fool out of themselves to please her and to be able to dance with her, sit next to her, visit with her...but Ashley? He didn't appear to be 'captured' by Scarlett's charm. He sems the quiet, introspective type, and he knew he's to marry Melanie so he didn't flirt with Scarlett the way the other boys had.

Then post-war, I think her obsession with Ashley shifted to nostalgia. He's the symbol of (again) the unattainable. Such as Scarlett' memory of her childhood and past life at Tara.

Agreed he was the ideal of Southern Culture before the war and Scarlet's hopes of it returning before her realizing it wasn't going to happen

Yeah I think it was the combo of childhood fantasy / crush, like "you're gonna marry the boy next door" and the fact that she couldn't get him. Made him more interesting to her

That's an excellent analysis! Also, Scarlett seemed to want what she couldn't have. As soon as Rhett walked out on her, HE was suddenly her 'true love'. I always thought they'd get back together, have a couple more kids, and have a continuing on & off toxic relationship.

He was always her true love; she didn't just magically begin loving him the minute he walked away. She just doesn't see/realize it due to her infatuation with Ashley. In fact, earlier in the book she tells herself she's not in love with him twice:

There was something breathtaking in the grace of his big body which made his very entrance into a room like an abrupt physical impact, something in the impertinence and bland mockery of his dark eyes that challenged her spirit to subdue him. "It's almost like I was in love with him!" she thought, bewildered. "But I'm not and I just can't understand it."

Something vital, electric, leapt from him to her at the touch of his warm mouth, something that caressed her whole body thrillingly...she had not bargained on this--this treacherous warm tide of feeling that made her want to run her hands through his hair, to feel his lips upon her mouth. She wasn't in love with him, she told herself confusedly. She was in love with Ashley. But how to explain this feeling that made her hands shake and the pit of her stomach grow cold?

Plus, Scarlett was about 15-16 at the time, so it was mostly about his looks, and his aloofness. Scarlett got anything she wanted, until Ashley didn't want her.

I don't think you can really explain infatuation (if we could, we'd all be able to choose who and who not to fall for!). But insofar as Scarlett's ongoing obsession can be explained, Ashley increasingly comes to represent her golden childhood and adolescence: Tara and Twelve Oaks and the County and the world of security and comfort she knew before the war (built on other people's misery, obviously - but Scarlett sees only a genteel world in which all the horrors are kept well out of view).

And he's the only unattainable man she knows. Other men are dumping their serious girlfriends for her, but Scarlett threw herself at Ashley and he declined.

This is a lot of it. It's at least partly her ego. She's the belle of the county and she's bagged, emotionally, every guy she wants, except him.

She feels the way about Ashley that most of us felt about our first crush. It’s not really rational or even about them as a person, it’s about what they represent to you at that time in your life. Most of the time you barely even talk to them, they’re just the dreamy boy at school. And that sort of idolisation can really have a grasp on you.

It also helps that Ashley is socially very acceptable for Scarlett, he’s handsome, rich, brave, a war hero, and can ride and drink better than all the other men she knows. So there’s a whole external reinforcement thing going on as well.

She became infatuated with him when she was about 14. Her family was new money, regarded as slightly lower-class, while Ashley's family was old money and regarded as higher class. Her father had a clear-eyed view of this dynamic, but young Scarlett did not. She just saw their elegant home, their low-key relationships, how his educated, sophisticated father was so different from her bombastic, embarrassing recent-immigrant father.

Also, of all the young men in her neighborhood, he was the only one who wasn't obviously infatuated with her. He was the one guy who wasn't impressed with her, which presented a challenge. And Scarlett loved a challenge. Because she couldn't get his devotion, she kept trying for it. And as she grew up, and life became chaotic, Ashley was a symbol for her of all that had been lost.

This is so brilliant — I hadn’t thought about the class aspect of this but you’re spot on.

She’s 15/16 when she develops a crush on him, and it’s clearly based on physical attraction. And while most of us get over our teenage crushes without much lasting damage, she has the trauma of seeing him get married, then marrying someone she didn’t love out of spite, becoming a widow—the restricted social status being far more meaningful to her than Charles’ death—and then the real trauma of war, nursing, reconstruction and bone-crushing poverty. At that point, he had become something between, as ScrutinEye put it, a talisman for the world she had lost, and an idée fixe, rather than a human being critically evaluated for his qualities. And don’t forget that at the end of the book when she finally gets over it, she’s only 28. That’s still quite young.

And in the modern world if you saw your childhood flame get married, a lot of people would just move away and start their own life. Scarlett could only get as far away as Atlanta and lived with … members of Ashley’s family, particularly his wife. Personally, I would have lost my mind if all that was right in front of my face every day

You would have thought, though, that after delivering Melanie’s baby, escaping Atlanta, getting home to her dead mother and absolute wasteland of a county, and the crushing poverty and famine, she might have seen sooner that Ashley was completely useless, but that flame was strong. Also that would change most of the second half of the book

I think she is disappointed in how useless Ashley is, but he does have the ‘excuse’ of being a returned war hero. In reality the guy had been starving in a brutal concentration camp for a year plus would have had some gnarly PTSD so it’s not surprising he didn’t immediately manage to run the farm.

He wasn't capable of that, he'd been raised to be a thinker, not a doer. And his PTSD prevented him from adapting. Will was a much better choice to run the farm that Tara had become

I disagree that he wasn’t raised to be a doer, it’s made very clear that he was an exceptional soldier, great rider, and clear and cool in a crisis. He’s not helpless, he’s just not okay after the war and farm work is completely foreign to him. But yes, Will was much better at it.

He came home after everything to a home that he had fought for that didn’t exist anymore

They lucked out with Will. Especially when he married Sue Ellen

Another example of how Will is a pragmatist to the point of being fatalistic. He loves Careen, but he knows it’s never going to happen. So he marries Suellen so he can stay on at Tara. Talk about a deal with the devil. But maybe she calmed down after she finally had a husband.

I think Suellen was probably fine when Scarlett wasn’t around, they just rubbed each other the wrong way. The only people who don’t react to Scarlett are the saintly ones.

She was pretty awful even without Scarlett. Remember she was the one who mercilessly egged Gerald on to sign the oath and receive money, leading to his death.

I agree with this take wholeheartedly. This is the take of a thinker, not someone who just accepts Scarlett excuses for Ashley at face value.

He was just an intellectual while Scarlett was pragmatic and "earthy". He was dreamy, she was fire. So like the majority of gentleman Ashley and business don't vibe. And in a way she did feel Rhett was beneath her, with his awful reputation.

Ashley didn't even seem to make a token ATTEMPT at saving 12 Oaks. He just settled in at Tara. "O well, guess this is my life now."

I don’t think there was what to save, really. The house had been completely burned and everyone was gone. He didn’t have the resources or the know-how to build a rough cabin, much less restore the original home.

And then when offered a chance to make a life for himself and his family up north, he allowed himself to be manipulated, while knowing that was happening!

Melanie insisted he take Scarlett's offer.

Hadn't thought about this, but yeah, Ashley's been through it. He describes the horrors of war on his visit at Christmas 1862, and after that it gets worse for him: more war, then capture and starvation, and then a looooooooong walk home.

OTOH, Will Benteen has probably also been through similar experiences (not prison camp, though), and he's perfectly useful; in fact, he's Scarlett's rock from the time he shows up onward.

So ... ?

Well yes, people have different responses to trauma. And Will is an experienced farmer.

Will is a pragmatist. Ashley is a dreamer.

Scarlett is a pragmatist as well. Those survive. Scarlett didn't get the life that Ashley was meant for was literally gone. No "new money" can repair that. He belonged to the different era.

2026 better informed Scarlett would be a lot more understanding. Good point

Now I’m imagining Scarlett instagramming her lumber business as a girl boss.

And just calling an Uber if she needs to get out to the mills

I think hanging on to the idealized Ashley allowed her a connection to the old days. I think that dream was her only escape from the hell her life had become.

She would have been better off in Savannah. 😌

Instead, she went to Atlanta where she was settin' there waitin' fer him jes' like a spider. 😉🤣

Funniest line in the whole damn movie.

Mammy had the best lines and knew how to take the wind out of Scarlett's sails.

Must disagree. The funniest line in the movie is 'The war stopped being a joke when a girl like you doesn't know how to wear the latest fashion '.

I think she's actually only 14 when she decides she loves Ashley

Even worse. Remembering my obsessive crush at 14 is so cringe-inducing. 🤦🏼‍♀️

All of my teenage crushes are cringe inducing at this point. I so desperately wanted to be loved by one of them…and only maybe 3 of the grew up to be decent people.

Oh God, me too 😬😬😬 it was actually what I thought about when I wrote my first reply and how some (lots of) years later I am sooooo glad that 'ship didn't happen 🤦🏻‍♀️

I don't think any of mine turned out to be terrible people, but my freshman year, my obsessive crush was a senior whom I was desperately in love with, despite never having had a single conversation with him. Shortly before he graduated, I cornered him in the hallway with a rose and a terrible poem I wrote for him. As I walked away, I could hear his friends teasing the shit out of him. I'm sure the poor guy was mortified. And it wasn't much different, I guess, from Scarlett cornering Ashley in the library to tell him how she feels, while he's thinking "oh my god, can we not?" CRINGE.

Yes, but you did feel the cringe. Scarlett was offended by being called not a lady. Everyone knew she was throwing himself at Ashley but she was just so obsessed that no matter how many times she was rejected her "pride" didn't appear.

I think she was young and infatuated. I think in her mind, she thought that they made "sense" and be the most beloved couple of the county.

At one point she said that she imagined a pretty suit and put Ashley in it. Then she was hooked. Thanks for letting me read a lively thread. I do love the movie and the book.

The word used here has been infatuation. Definitely.

In addition, Scarlett didn't have the depth or insight to analyze or understand her own feelings. At least Ashley understood himself and the world around him. Scarlett didn't.

She also stuffed her feelings inside and refused to face things (I'll think about that tomorrow). She COULD face tangible things like starvation, hard work, and survival. She was a scrapper!! But personalities or depth were beyond her, so she pushed it away.

That's how she ended up holding on to an infatuation.

And then she realized how weak Ashley is opposite to Rhett. But it was a little too late. Also she couldn't read between the lines at all. Yes, her growth was stunted but she always valued vanity and money. This she understood. Why Ashley would go for Melanie - I don't know when exactly she got it.

You know as a former young girl/teenager myself, just by looking at his superficial features in the book, he sounds like the ultimate dreamboat/prince charming/knight in shining armor before the war. She is in love with the idea of him and his potential rather than who he really is and is aggravated by the fact that he is dependent and strings her along for the whole book. Meanwhile, you have Rhett, yeah he's handsome and kind. But would I date a playboy who has illegal businesses and shady dealings and lives in a brothel, could have an STD and is like as old as my dad and does couldnt tell his feelings directly and makes fun/humiliates of me? No thanks. Both men have flaws and did absolutely nothing or straightforward to a simple minded straightforward Scarlett who doesnt beat around the bush and doesnt have the ability to read the room.

And this is what the movie/book is iconic because its fucking relatable/realistic and speaks more humanly

This might be the first time I've ever seen anyone describe Rhett Butler as "kind".

Scratch that, im sorry but he was generous at times

He was always kind to Melanie.

Melanie was to him a true lady in all the best ways and genuinely kind, good person, non judgmental. She welcomed Rhett, Belle while no one wanted to. She was a bit anti-Scarlett.

Oh he was unbearably kind. IF you earned it.

Because she couldn't get him. He was the one man she couldn't capture.

You nailed it.

Yes. This got her obsessed. The one who got away (in her mind).

Because he was young and blonde and hot. 🤷‍♀️

The Calvert boys are young and brown and hot. The Tarleton twins are young and redheaded and hot. Ashley is young and blonde and hot. Yet she only goes for Ashley - the others were ego-boosters.

Teenage crush and then the trauma of war and all the other stuff happening put her in arrested development until the end of the novel, locking it in.

Because he didn't want her. EVERYONE wanted her, except Ashley. That's my viewpoint anyway.

Yes, even Rhett showed he cared too much. Maybe if he pretended to court her sister she'd want him more.

She doesn't have the emotional intelligence to recognize that finding him boring etc means that she doesn't love him; she loves the idea of him, who she thinks he is.

THIS. She loves the idea. She never understood him. She'd be bored by him.But she closed herself off.

Ashley is a symbol of a life that has passed.

She didn't actually love him, romantically. When the story begins, most every other guy, in the county, wanted Scarlett. But Ashley didn't chase her. Many want what they can't have.

And once she is determined to have something, her personality isn't gonna let up and accept "defeat." And I don't care what anyone says, Ashley used her desire for him to play head games with her.

He loved it. He was just as unworthy of Melanie's love as Scarlett was.

I don’t think that’s so. He felt trapped and miserable a lot of the time, wanting to be faithful to Melanie, but wildly physically attracted to Scarlett. He definitely hates being financially dependent on her and being bullied into doing things he doesn’t want to do (e.g. using the convicts).

Well, he clearly felt tempted by her but it was purely physical. He always told her to stop though. He was still a man but remained faithful.

Apparently, the actor originally planned to play Ashley Wilkes was the tall, dark and incredibly handsome Tyrone Power.

Leslie Howard is a great actor and captured the role impeccably. But put Tyrone Power in the role and Scarlet O’Hara’s obsession with him takes on a whole new perspective.

Wow Ty Power 😍 I like that in the book Ashley’s light, almost silver hair give him such a contrast to the dark and swashbuckling Rhett so that would be lost. But Ty Power has the more patrician / genteel looks that I totally associate with Ashley and would be a super interesting foil for Clark Gable

He would have been a great Rhett too!

I would argue that he largely serves as a symbol. Ashley represents “the Old South” and who she is supposed to be / what she is supposed to want. But that idea and way of life is dying, and clinging to him/it isn’t being true to reality or who she actually is. The tragedy of the story is that she comes to understand all of this way too late.

I agree with others about the reasons for Scarlett's enduring love for Ashley. But the movie never gives us the beginnings of Scarlett's and Ashley's relationship. I say relationship because Scarlett never really leaves Ashley's mind either. But I think this beginning is in the book.

Obviously they had known each other for years, but one day Ashley had come to visit the family at Tara. Scarlett was standing on the porch when Ashley came riding up and when he looked up at her smiling, Cupid struck. Its been years since I read the book but I seem to remember that.

Ashley was that young, first real feeling of attraction and love. The first feeling of having her own life, her own family. He sat the bar whether he knew it or not.

What is interesting to me to speculate about is if Melanie had either turned Ashley down or married someone else, if Ashley would have succumb to Scarlett's advances. And what kind of life they would have each had then.

Yes! Tiny correction, it was when he looked DOWN at her. It made him this sunlit god staring down upon her.

Thanks. I wondered if I'd remembered it right! The scene of him looking at her and that being it for her, always stuck with me because I could picture it happening in my head.

Mitchell was very adept at creating scenes on paper that were both visual and familiar.

The DOWN part is crucial why she was so obsessed.

OP, you don't say how far you've gotton in the book. As you read it, especially late in the book, read very carefully what happens with her feelings about Ashley. Mitchell gives us very subtle clues about how it

changes. I just finished it for the eighth (yes, 8th) time, and I only noticed those clues this time. I'm not going to say any more.

As a college literature professor of mine said, “The excellent is always new.” The book is a masterpiece. I have no idea how many times I’ve read it by now.

When you do sit down and try to figure out how many times, it's ridiculous. You made me try. And then I realized, duh, I've read it a minimum of once a year (quite a lot more in the early years, sometimes 3-6 times a year) since I was 11. I'm now 38. I am ridiculous lol

In 8th grade I got in trouble with the librarian because at that point, I'd read it enough times that I was able to pick out misprints, typos, and subtle variations in different editions so I proudly corrected the library's copy in gelpen 🤷‍♀️ 🤦‍♀️ 🤦‍♀️ 🤦‍♀️

She wanted what she could not have. All the other boys were trophies and she wanted the forever elusive one 🏆

I think that another component of that "love" in addition to what other comments say is that Ashley was a mystery to her, and he was very different from both Scarlet herself and other men she knew. She couldn't understand him and his thoughts, dreams and feelings, and that pulled her to him like a magnet. He was a riddle she couldn't decipher or hack into using her beauty and charm that worked so fine with other men in her circle. In fact, the inner world of these other men was probably hidden from her too (she never understood Frank Kennedy, her second husband, either, and his active involvement in the KKK was a shocking surprise for her, she never thought him capable of something like that), but she did not care as long as she was sure any of them would propose to her at the wave of her hand. Ashley, on the contrary, remained mysterious and unattainable, and she filled this mystery with all kinds of imaginary virtues that she found attractive. It wasn't Ashley who she loved, but her idea of him, and since it was all in her head, she had to really part with these girlish fantasies first, before she could see the real Ashley, which is why it took so long.

I think he was unattainable, he was a gentleman, he put up with her crap without being a pushover, he was willing to lead her along and flatter her ego.

As for the film, Ashley was miscast. Leslie Howard felt himself far too old for the role, though I think he did a pretty good job in a fairly bland role for him. It is worth looking into him, he was a very charming actor and very funny in his other films. He was murdered by Nazis during the war, his civilian plane was deliberately shot down for reasons that remain unclear. One theory is that Leslie was mistaken for Churchill's right hand man or bodyguard, and that his bald and portly companion was mistaken for Churchill himself. Other theories are that they knew who they were targeting, and wanted to kill him as he was doing war work, and for the shot to morale.

Because in her mind, Ashley is the only man she can be soft and feminine with. With her husbands; she has to be the strong one. With Rhett; he was her equal and challenged her to be her truest self. With Ashley she gets to be vulnerable, fawning. That is until the end when she sees that Ashley IS weak and she’d have to be the strong one once again

In the book I seem to remember she was attracted to the fact that he was thoughtful and an intellectual, not like the other boys, who are more like male versions of her. She seemed to like his intelligence, even her own dad tells her the Wilkes are in love with books and he would never make her happy.

Honestly to me it felt like Scarlet had a case of limerence. It lasted so long because he never said outright he didn't want to be with her.

He was the only one she couldn't have, ergo the only one she wanted. 😉

Because he doesn't love her and she can manipulate every other man in the county except him.

Because she can't have him. If he had courted her like the other boys in the neighborhood did, she wouldn't have been interested.

Because he's different and like repels like.

Because she can't have him

She's sixteen. She has a crush on him that never goes away.

She was spoiled and always got what she wanted. She couldn't get him. Simple.

She's a lot like her mother. Her mother also fell head over heals in love with her cousin and never got over him. She had six children with Scarlett's father and was fond of him but it was her cousin's name she was calling for at her death while delirious of illness. It's pretty sad and a parallel between mother and daughter that didn't make it into the films. Scarlett misses her girlhood and the past and Ashley Wilkes is the embodiment of it. I like that duality in her character: ruthlessly pragmatic but surprisingly dreamy and nostalgic too

I have always wondered that. He is not attractive compared to Rhett.

Ashley in the book was quite a bit younger, probably in his mid-20s. Leslie Howard was about 41 and didn't want to play Ashley; thought he was too old. But apparently he had a studio contract and was practically forced to take the role. He'd been quite popular as a romantic hero in The Scarlet Pimpernel, Pygmalion, Of Human Bondage, and Intermezzo.

It's limerence. She fell head over heels for the young man when he came back from an European tour. I am sure, he was witty and charming.

I think primarily because he kept turning her down.

Because she's a young girl when she meets him, or even a toddler when she meets him, he treated her with respect and she got stars in her eyes from that day.

She's no deep thinker, she operates on instinct. She never questioned her adoration of Ashley and was egotistical enough to believe no man on the planet would say no to her.

She perceived his weakness. Scarlett wanted a man she could dominate.

This is the answer.

Exactly, it's a case of wanting what you know you can't have.

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T09 Rhett, Scarlett and Ashley

Rhett, Scarlett and Ashley I recently re-read the book and watched the movie and just can not get over this story. In my early teen when I read the story, I formed the impression that Scarlett ruined her own marriage

and relationship. But now I started to form the idea that Ashley and Rhett made a bigger share of mistakes than her. Scarlett was a child in an adult body. She did not introspect or inspect other people. She is too busy to have fun or make a living to support the huge famiy. But Ashley and Rhett knew the circumstance and understand the real dynamics of the intricate relationships. Ashley would never leave Melly for Scarlett. He should stick this idea to Scarlett's head rather than talking about honor, dream. And Rhett, how could he acted so mean towards Scarlett so often? He did not respect her. How can Scarlett realize his love from his actions. Honestly I would not be able to if my husband treated like this. I would conclude he is a pendululming mania.

Their relationship is doomed right from beginning. A marriage can not survive when it lacks of trust, respect and the willingness to compromise.

Rhett/Scarlett is sort of a Frankenstein story. Rhett created a monster, mostly for funsies, then rejected his creation.

Exactly! He played with her like a toy and then coldly rejected her.

The truth is that Rhett and Scarlett were truly at cross purposes the entire relationship. I don't believe he was ever right for Scarlett and I honestly wanted her to be able to have Ashley and vice versa. Ashley was kind to her never put her down or criticized her like Rhett.

Ashley was never right for Scarlett. She only wanted him because she could not get him. And she learnt that the moment she could.

Not true…he was her first love. How was Rhett better?

I first read GWTW when I was 11. I've read it many times since most recently this spring. The older I get the more sympathetic I get to Scarlett she is just a child in the beginning and then she has such huge problems I think she becomes stunted emotionally.

Also the older I get the more I hate Ashley. All he had to do is tell her he wasn't interested in her but then he strung her along for years. If he had just been truthful with her she would have been upset but then she would have moved on. She could have had a better chance with Rhett. Ashley is older than Scarlett and has no excuses. When she makes the curtain dress and goes off to Atlanta Ashley understands she will do anything to get the money and he lets her go. Even Will is disgusted with him. Ashley is both weak and selfish.

GWTW is a fantastic read. I honestly cannot stand Ashley either. He acts like his choice to stay with Melly comes from a deep moral duty and sense of honor...and maybe it does. But it honestly seems more and more like cowardness and a weak sense of character as the book / movie progresses. I feel for Scarlett honestly. She has her faults too, don't get me wrong. Often, she's selfish, self-absorbed, and hypocritical. However, I feel like for most of the novel's second half, she is forced into a position of caretaking and maturity that is so unnatural and traumatic for her that it makes her lean even more into the "security" and "unconditional passionate kindness" that a love with Ashley seems to provide in her head.

Her security and safety was taken from her overnight, and she was left trying to survive & maintain the livelihood of the rest those with her. She was essentially a child and had no real support besides Rhett, who had his own personal issues too. Gone with the Wind has such deeply flawed and fascinating characters.

Yes, only when I got older did I appreciate the second half of the novel! She went through a lot and Rhett even when proposing did it coldly and kind of jokingly. He mocked Scarlett.

I always want to smack Ashley from the very beginning when instead of outright saying he's marrying Melanie and loves her and doesn't love Scarlett. He pulls the "Yes I care. Oh can't we go away and forget we ever said such things" crap. I mean seriously wth is that? He toyed with her from the very beginning.

Also Ashley acted like he was better then everyone. But Rhett made me angry several times because he was just so cruel and didn't validate Scarlett.

People LOVE him and I think Ashley is a little bitch that doesn't love Scarlett or Melanie. What he DOES love is attention. He kept feeding Scarlett little nuggets of hope bc he didn't want to give her up and didn't seem to really care what happened to her because of it. He sat in a pool of self pity and entitledness to do it with the belief that things were EXTRA hard for him so he didn't have to roll his sleeves up and keep moving. It would be different if it was coming purely from war trauma (I'm sure he was traumatized). But that's not why he took this stance. He was saying from the get go how it would be the most unbearable for him if the south fell and then after just kept whining to do things that "weren't him" Get up and move Ashley everyone is uncomfortable post war. I'm glad I didn't live back then all the men seemed so entitled, so spoiled, and just a nightmare to deal with!

You might be interested in this Shmoop article about Rhett: [link]

"So again, Rhett says that Scarlett would have thought him weak and manipulated him if he told her he loved her. But part of love is being willing to admit that you are weak and needy. The person you love has power over you; that's part of what love's about. Rhett says Scarlett would see him as weak, but it really seems like it's Rhett himself who's afraid of weakness, Rhett himself who is so afraid of the woman he loves that he's willing to cheat on her and lie to her and treat her as a punching bag for his own insecurities.

At the end of the novel, Scarlett realizes she loves Rhett, and instantly goes to tell him—because she has a spine, and isn't going to spend four hundred pages wavering and whining like Rhett did. But when she tells Rhett, what does he say? He says that after being hurt by her before, and after losing Bonnie, he's simply too afraid to have a relationship with her. "I'll not risk my heart a third time" (63.79), he says, as if he ever were willing to risk it in the first place."

IMO Rhett is a fascinating character, but he is absolutely ruled by his fear of rejection. Scarlett is not entirely to blame for their relationship falling through.

Interesting. It raises many good points but I think Scarlett has some responsibility here too. There's the scene on their honeymoon where she's laying next to Rhett dreaming of Ashley. She wasn't emotionally available either.

Yes, and she wanted to have an upper hand. Unfortunately, she started to like Rhett and she appreciated his looks and prowess in bed but then decided not to have a kid so he didn't entirely convinced her.

I kept thinking she was going to say to Rhett after he got married " and can I have Ashley too?"

It's so tough. I believe he was too cruel to her so many times but there was one line in the novel when Scarlett thought he loved her and was thinking how to use it against him. But yeah, Rhett should have told Scarlett he loved her and if she rejected him then divorce her and try to move on.

For the Ashley-Scarlett story, I think that they are both to blame, though Ashley the most. He wanted Scarlett physically (I guess he like the fire that Melly didn't have) but would never have left Melly. He should have put a stop to Scarlett from the beginning. That was their biggest problem. Scarlett, even if she is a child in an adult body, still has a part of responsibility. She is an adult after all and cannot be free of blame.

For the Rhett-Scarlett story, I think it was all Scarlett's problem. Rhet loved her, but he was afraid to show it (there is a quote when he tells her that she will hold amy man's love over his head like a whip). She hung on to an idea of Ashley instead of paying attention to her marriage.

Ashley told her "no" quite a few times but then was too weak. For the Rhett-Scarlett I get where you come from but Rhett was often uber mean to Scarlett. Like extreme levels. For me he was a coward when he didn't visit sick Scarlett. He could have shown his soft side. She needed him. Also he knew Scarlett wasn't emotionally intelligent. Do you think they get back together?

I agre that Rhett was unbelievably mean to Scarlett. I like to think that they get back together for many reasons:

Scarlett always gets what she wants. She works hard until she gets it (money, confort, Tara,...). And since she finally realised that she loves Rhett, she will go after him until she gets him. (At one point, she was jealous of all the attention Rhett waa giving to her Bonnie).

Rhett loves Scarlett very much and he cannot stay away from her. When he got drunk to the point of breaking his hard protective shell, he admited loudly that he loved her. When she had the miscarriage, he wanted desperately to be with her. Whenever Scarlett swooned over Ashley, he always forgave her and stayed with the hopes that she would finally realise how Rhett loved her. During the war, he would come back just to see her. After the war, he risked being arrested to see her. I don't think it will be any different by the end of the book. He might be very hurt and tired of being hurt, but time will heal him and he will still come back to Scarlett.

I truly like your answer. He just seemed so numb, tired and burned out at the end. I'm scared his love is really gone as is his energy. Do you think he has still in him to be charming, funny again?

Ashley never comes right out and says no. He'll say he cares for her and then "oh let's forget this." and many other things like that. He never outright just says I love Melanie and we will never be together.

No he loves Melanie in a far different way because they're alike and share books and and art but at the same time I believe he loves Scarlet and tries very hard not to love her, even though he says he does love Scarlett twice in the book. when he's trying to go to New York and Scarlett's having a big fit because she doesn't want him to go and he tells her that there are other reasons and that only she knows what they are that he needs to go to NY and Scarlet says well I told you I wouldn't speak of the whole thing that happened at the paddock at Tara, and and Ashley says in the book "Then you are surer of yourself than I am." So Ashley in that very statement is struggling with his feelings for her and wants to get away from Scarlett. Ashley also says in the book that he can't stand to think of Rhett touching her. Ashley absolutely does love Scarlet and as I've said 100 times once Melanie dies, Scarlett is saying well at least I still have Ashley need Ashley for strength and then the minute she sees him crying and holding the glove of Melanie's she thinks that he loves Melanie and at that very moment realizes she does not have Ashley's love and now she has to run back to Rhett. I will continue to believe thatAshley felt a lot of guilt about Melanie dying of a miscarriage.

Ashley and Scarlett love the ideas they have of each other. Ashley loves Scarlett's bravery and strength, but in reality his pride could never handle being with a woman like her. Melanie was strong in her own right, but always deferred to Ashley in most things so his male pride wouldn't take a hit and she moved behind the scenes so he succeeded. Scarlett would never do that and she'd just call him weak or a fool and do what she wanted because she never wanted to be without money again after the war. Ashley, her father and Rhett all tell her that she would never actually be happy with Ashley and probably even grow to resent him.l, but she

never listens because she still has a childish fantasy about him and he's also the only man to turn her down. The book starts when she's 16 and ends when she's 28 and throughout that time she went through a lot of trauma and Ashley is the only thing left of her carefree life before the war. In a way she is still that 16 year old girl you meet at the beginning (just hardened by so much fear and loss) She believes Ashley would make her that happy carefree girl again and she always thought if Melanie wasn't in the picture he would turn to her because he constantly leads her on, but when Melanie dies she sees that isn't true and that Ashley isn't actually someone she could be happy with…

"I loved something I made up, something that's just as dead as Melly is. I made a pretty suit of clothes and fell in love with it. And when Ashley came riding along, so handsome, so different, I put that suit on him and made him wear it whether it fitted him or not. And I wouldn't see what he really was. I kept on loving the pretty clothes—and not him at all.".

When Mellie dies Scarlett loses the only person who truly saw her and still loved her anyway … faults and all. Scarlett and Melanie were not only sisters-in-law, but everything they went through truly bonded them as sisters. She realizes she pushed Rhett (who she really loved) away for a dream that was never real and runs home to tell him, but he's done and it's too late.

Even Rhett though had an idea in his head of who Scarlett was though and could never really acknowledge just how strong the war had made her. He still saw the vapid sixteen year old from twelve oaks and didn't give her credit for everything she had survived in only 12 years. I would say Mellie was really the only true love she had because Mellie knew why Scarlett acted the way she did and all that she had been through to make sure they all survived.

You must not have read the book when Ashley tells Scarlett he loves her twice at paddock after their very intense kiss. Scarlett realizes that Ashley does love her, but that he will always work hard to stay away from her and not act on the love. Yes he definitely wants her physically but there's more to it than that and for Scarlet he was her first love and I know for sure. My first love started when I was 14 and I didn't get over it till I was 27 years old. You never forget your first love.

No they never get back together! Rhett goes west or goes to Charleston and hooks up with some woman like Belle! I am one of the dissenters for decades that believes that Scarlet and Ashley do end up together and I have written a whole four paragraphs on that that I just published here.

No Rhett never comes back. As long as Ashley lives he won't ever come back. Scarlett will end up with Ashley…it's in the cards.

Ashley should've stopped pussying out of telling Scarlett "no" straight and plain, instead of using all these wishy-washy expressions that confused Scarlett and frankly confused me as a reader. Like srsly everytime he rejected her I had to re-read three times because I was just like "Wait what tf is this dude saying!?!?!?"

Scarlett hung onto the idea of Ashley. True. But I often think she and Rhett had many times where they could've figured it all out and made it work, but they were always like ships in the night. They were never emotionally available at the same time once Scarlett told Rhett she wouldn't sleep with him anymore. That part is her fault. But there are many other times after where you see her happy to see Rhett or being with him, but he is cold to her so then she shuts down and says something hurtful in response.

Are you my sister? I read it when I was 13-14 and re-read it now and boy, Scarlett was clueless yes. However, Ashley and Rhett were wiser, more emotionally intelligent, older and they both knew that Scarlett

was not and she didn't really realise emotions. Rhett toyed with Scarlett so many times, played mind game, being almost twice the age. He was a coward, he never truly told her how he felt. And then he discarded her coldly. I must ask though, do you feel she gets Rhett's back again?

I definitely used to think Scarlett was fully at fault for things, but I now put a lot of the blame on Ashley (not 100% sure I agree about Rhett though).

I think one of the key differences between Rhett and Ashley is Rhett was always up front about his intentions and his sordid past, while Ashley remained the "perfect" southern gentleman in appearance, but was too cowardly to cut Scarlett loose.

Also, I think Rhett did respect Scarlett. Did he treat her in a gentlemanly manner? Of course not lol. But I think he respected her far more than most women (Belle, Mammy, and Melanie being three others he genuinely respected). But that respect wasn't enough to overcome Scarlett's lack of reciprocation and their overall lack of communication as a couple. Their relationship was based on Rhett spoiling Scarlett, yet she was determined to be unhappy with anything Rhett could provide.

I completely agree! Except I think it was love. Rhett loved Scarlett. He respected her at first and that transformed into love.

I think there was a quote in the book when he straight up says that he doesn't respect her and equates her to a pet. He says he finds her amusing.

Everyone hates Scarlett but she's like 15 when the book starts and has to support her entire family all of a sudden. The shit she does is undoubtedly morally wrong but there isn't anyone to look for guidance anymore when her mother dies (except Mammy). Plus she took care of Melly, albeit begrudgingly. I can't imagine having to be responsible for the wife of the man you love.

In my mind, I like to end GWTW with Scarlett coming to her senses and running out to meet Rhett before he leaves in a buggy lol. Then they decide to give it another try and work out their differences. It's too depressing any other way.

I hate that this is my perfect ending because Rhett sucks and is emotionally abusive to Scarlett. His anger stems from her emotional infidelity but notice he's the one that does the cheating. He is cold to her in times where she clearly needs affection but blames it on her for not appreciating him.

Yes, he always reminds her she is not well-read and is often cruel. Scarlett didn't want to sleep with him so I don't hate him that much for cheating. The ending is depressing and I'm like.. how do you think she gets him back? He really seemed to change.

My perfect ending is that Ashley and Scarlett end up together. Ashley did love Scarlett and he said so He loved her but would not leave Melanie. Rhett was never right for Scarlet. He was sarcastic. He was insecure, and as he said, they were always at cross purposes. Ashley on the other hand was kind was not harsh.He would not allow himself to love Scarlet even though he did.

Yeah, Scarlett chose to be unhappy but when he got Scarlett he became even more mean and threw her to the wolves - her reputation as a mother - for Bonnie.

I'm not sure I understand what you're saying. Rhett cared a great deal about Scarlett's reputation as a mother and wanted her to behave better for the sake of her children.

I recall he made himself look like a great father while making Scarlett a bad mother by comparison. He also stop caring for Scarlett when he had Bonnie.

I don't think he ever stopped caring for her, not even at the end. I just always felt that the loss of Bonnie broke him and then Melanie who was Scarlett's biggest defender dies and Rhett no longer has someone telling him that Scarlett "loves him a great deal, much more than she knows". He was emotionally spent and even when Scarlett poors her heart out he just has nothing left to give. I would love to say that before they actually get divorced he comes around and they are able to make it work, but they spent so much time battling each other and missing out on so many opportunities to be open and honest about their feelings because the other had hurt them that I think the damage was done.

Though I totally agree on this take I do feel like I can relate to Rhett in some way shape or form. I don't see him as a villain per se, just flawed just like Scarlett.

I think one of his biggest mistakes was marrying her when he knew she loved another man and that she only wanted him for his money. In fact he was willing to bribe her to keep her. This short of desperation creates this compelling character though- I believe.

Additionally, I will take his word on it, that he was afraid letting her know how he felt would lead to losing her altogether. That wasn't some irrational fear, he knew what she was like and how she would react. In fact I believe that had she known he loved her before she loved him back this would by defect make her view him like Frank Kennedy and Charles- pathetic. I feel like whatever chance he had with her would in fact end right there and then. In a toxic way, I believe he played his cards well knowing what he was dealing with. Him becoming increasingly more petty and aggressive was a result of build up resentment. Though I think he could have been more respectful to a woman he loved I also get why he would be less than perfect in the situation.

I also think that one could easily tell from his actions how much he loved her even more so than in the movie. He practically risked his life for her, gave her anything she wanted in terms of money even before marrying her, he practically founded her business, he loved her kids and treated them as his own, he even protected Ashley and Melanie for her. When he asked her to marry him it should be a dead give away he actually loves her because he was never a marrying man but he changed for her.

I think the text itself makes it very clear that Scarlett and Rhett are mirroring and paralleling their way throughout the text. They both wish for the unattainable and they both try to bring the object of their affection closer. The story points at dissolution and how love like many things (civilisation, standards and morals) can actually be taken by the wind at any given moment.

P.S. I never thought of Scarlett as the villain either. I think that if you read the text carefully you can clearly tell she is having severe PTSD and she is not in fact a narcissist or whatever else they come up with to frame her nowadays. I agree on the take she is judged too severely (I'm of the opinion that if she was a male character she would have been widely loved by the readers and saluted as a hero).

OK, I am 79 years old. I've been reading the book since I was 12. My mother loved it so did I I've watched the movie hundreds of times I mean every night I watch snippets of it on YouTube so I am a huge GWTW fan. However, I am a reader who loves the book and does not care for the interpretation of the movie and the reason for that is that I really like Ashley I think he's a gentleman. I think he's kind. He's not sarcastic. He's a lot of things that I like and he's definitely not weak. I'm sick of hearing how weak he is. He is not weak. So I have pointed this out many times if anyone has read the book, can they explain how Scarlet comes out of

the room after Melanie talks to her on her deathbed and while she's walking down the hallway, Scarlett says to herself at least I still have Ashley. That's in the book then she goes out to find Ashley's in the bedroom. She finds him and at some point he's tells her that Melanie was his dream and at that very moment she thinks that Ashley loves Melly. I think that actually he is feeling a lot of guilt. Do I think it's love it's some kind of love for me, but it's not the same love that Ashley had for Scarlett. Then she has this epiphany that Ashley doesn't love her and now she doesn't love him. I say this is all baloney because then she races out heading home wants to see Rhett and he says to her I fear you are transferring your love from Ashley to me and that is exactly what Scarlett was doing said in the book. She said so many times in the book that she had no strength without Ashley. This continued to be true until this all unraveled at the moment that Melly was at deaths door. There was no epiphany with Scarlet until that very moment that she saw how Ashley was behaving. So having said all this, and it doesn't matter if anyone agrees with me, I'm simply saying if you would read the book like I'm saying and you can connect the dots. You will understand that my scenario is more accurate. Therefore Rhett leaves and by the way, he was terrible for Scarlet. He was sarcastic. He was coarse and Ashley was much better for her. Anyway, Rhett is not coming back ever he's going out west or he's gonna find some woman in Charleston. I believe Ashley goes to New York for a year. He and Scarlet write back-and-forth a connection is made once again and they do end up together. It's in the cards. Scarlet builds houses in Atlanta. Ashley provides all the lumber Scarlet rebuilds 12 Oaks and while they are very different opposites attract. DONE!

The two men are just too arrogant to confront each other, they value honor over everything else. if they can talk about the matter more openly it could be much better but they can't afford to damage the dignity of another man nor their own. But scarlett seems to them always like a child and they don't really respcet women enough, playing with her like a toy, tearing her between two relationships.

scarlett has a really strange character, people think she is childish and clever at the same time (which she is)but this lead her to more burden and agony than she can bear. a digression: I saw nothing wrong with her personality yet it seems to out her in a really unfortunate state, I guess it teach me that it not always the victim's fault

Im going to weigh in on this old ass post haha, but I believe Rhett was exactly right for Scarlett. Love is not always telling you what you want to hear. That's flattery. There are many ways someone can love you. Rhett didnt let Scarlett manipulate him like she did everyone else. He had patience with her—to a degree, because Scarlett was not the kind of soul you let have the upper hand on you. She will take full unfiltered advantage. Scarlett was stunned in her development from losing Tara to witnessing war, and it turned what would have been just typical manipulative traits into a conniving, scheming ice queen. Lets remember she married Charles to spite Ashley rejecting her. And she stole Frank from her sister. She also did numerous things that was not in line with societal expectations—like dancing while in mourning. (I dont hold these against her just pointing them out) She was no angel and did not need nor would she have respected to be handled with kid gloves. Its why at the very end of the movie, she realizes how much she truly loved Rhett. He was exactly what she needed, not some girlhood dream of chasing Ashley. Mostly because Ashley would not choose her, though he appreciated her beauty and sex appeal like any other man, he remained gentlemanly about it. Scarlett would have ruled over him and that wouldnt have made him happy. Melly is exactly what Ashley needed. He wouldnt have known how to even control Scarlett.

I think Scarlett relived her mothers life. Her mother fell in love with someone who didn't even acknowledge her and then married not for love but for the sake of not being an old maid. Both of them married someone they didn't love.

T10 The saddest part about Scarlett's fixation

Reading the book again: The saddest part about Scarlett’s fixation with Ashley.

Is that because of it Scarlett missed out on spending her last Christmas with her mother in Tara, as she wanted to stay in Atlanta in order to see Ashley when he returned home briefly from the war for Christmas. Ellen O’Hara died in the fall of the following year.

Yes! Her teenage crush ruined her life. Most people would have grown out of it but she was too stubborn. I blame Ashley too if he had said straight out to drop it she would have eventually gotten past it but he kept stringing her along and giving her hope.

I think she wished she was like her mom, but was far more like her dad. Ashley was the man that, if she Were like her mom, would be a good match. However because she is Scarlett, it could never be. Ashley is more humble and would be considered timid to Scarlett. I think that would have drove her nuts in the long haul. I think it also had to do with the fact that Ashley didn't pursue Scarlett. He was a challenge.

Scarlett was chasing something she could never find… happiness… even though it was right there in front of her! She thought Ashley was her answer to love and happiness, she built him up in her head to be a man he never truly was…while Rhett was the man who could of given her the happiness she chased in her dreams had she opened her eyes

It has nothing to do with the Mother. Scarlett wanted something she couldn’t have. Ashley loved Melanie because she was submissive, gentle, subservient Southern. Scarlett was too much fire for Ashley, in fact I think he actually admits it in the book.

I have come to see Scarlett as a Narcissist in that she didn’t really love Ashley but she didn’t want her cousin Melanie to have him. If she had ever married Ashley, she would have soon become bored with him because he really is a milktoast, and ditched him. But if she kept him away from Melanie, then she won. It was a game to her.

Scarlett loved her father more than her mother. Keep that in mind while reading the book.

Scarlett was definitely a narcissist, but Melanie was Ashley’s cousin, not Scarlett’s. Near the beginning of the book, Scarlett’s dad talks about how the Wilkeses always marry their cousins.

OMG, how could I have forgotten that. Thanks for setting me straight. Got some rethinking to do now.

Ashley is a sociopath. He was only ever nice to her so Scarlett could take care of his bitch and brat.

I really don't see that. I think he always has some attraction to her, and fondness leftover from youth, but I also think he expected Scarlet to be a bit more mature than she really was, that she would have an inner sense of honor to protect and care for the wife and child of a childhood friend in the time of war.

I am one of the few people that has always liked Ashley. He wasn’t weak as has been stated 1000 times he served in the military. He was a gentleman. He was kind to Scarlet and I thought he was much better for Scarlet than the crass egomaniac that Rhett was. They were at cross purposes at all times. She was better with Ashley.

T11 Good or bad person

Do you see Scarlett O'Hara as a good or bad person in "Gone with the Wind"?

I see her as a bad person who occasionally does good stuff and by the end, she acknowledges her wrongdoing but she made too many mistakes to atone so by then, it's too late. That's why Rhett dumps her and she isn't given a happy ending.

Scarlett has some positive qualities, her unwavering desire to keep Tara and her survivors instincts, but then you have her many flaws: narcisistic, she ruins her sister's life by marrying her fiance and by doing so, keeps Tara but emotionally abuses her husband until his death, a negligent mother towards Bonnie and then blames Rhett for Bonnie's death, tries to seduce a married man and is awful to Melanie who's always been kind to her.

Even when Scarlett does something right, it's based on her selfish needs. She saves Melanie, not for love, but because she promised Ashley. If it was up to her, she'd have left her in the house to die.

People found Rhett leaving Scarlett cruel and cold but when he says to Scarlett hge doesn't give a damn, she made him feel this way. He put up with her lack of love, her showing no affection towards their daughter, her flirting with Ashley for everybody to see. No man loved Scarlett more than he did and he was a broken man. When Bonnie died, it took his love for Scarlett away. Scarlett's promises rang hollow.

Frankly, I don’t give a damn

This is the only real answer.

However, I'd say she's a bad person....terrible racist, selfish person, a true product of her times.

The scene where she beats Prissy is a horrible reminder she's a woman of her time.

I would have done more than just beat Prissy. That was a serious situation, and she treated it like, "Oh well. It's not me who's suffering." Had Prissy survived me, I would have done far worse than sell her or otherwise kill her. I would have made it known how lazy and useless she is, and that she is a drain on any master she serves, regardless of how much you punish her. Then I would set her free and let her fend for herself.

You sound Hella racist tf wrong with u

I fucking hate Prissy. So did Butterfly McQueen. The actress who played her. If I were racist, Mammy would not be my favorite character.

I read an interesting take on this situation. Miss prissy actually was capable of delivering a baby, or at least she had a lot of experience helping as her mother had a lot of experience as well. But, she assumed a white doctor would be present and that it wouldn't be a complicated birth. So as a slave she was put in an awkward situation where she would be the person responsible for delivering a rich white lady's baby by herself and she understood that if anything bad happened, like the baby or the mother died, she would probably be dealt with very harshly so she thought it was in her best interest to lie and let Scarlett take the bulk of the responsibility.

That's why I loved Mammy so much. Aside from her pre-civil war ebonics and the fact that she cared enough to be stern, she would have helped any way she could. Gone with the Wind is a very unique story. I'd wager there are only two likable characters in the whole story, and it still manages to be a beloved classic that captivates audiences. Scarlett, though selfish and spoiled, becomes a very strong character, and grows a lot even before the end when she realizes she loves Rhett. I will always love Mammy though.

What Prissy did was terrible; and it was a very serious situation! The birth of Melanie’s baby. She would’ve hit ANYONE who lied to her in that situation. She slapped her own sister for saying she hated Tara. In the book she didn’t treat black people any worse than she treated anyone else.

I think no matter what time she was raised in she'd still be just the same.

I couldn't have said this better myself.

Not to be that asshole but the movie doesn't do any justice to the character as written in the book. The character of Scarlett is definitely a product of her time and privilege but is also capable of learning and growing and does a lot of both over the course of the two books featuring her. So to answer your question she's neither good nor bad, she's human, with all the shades of grey that brings with it.

Um, . . . sorry, there were two books? What is the title of the second one? Was it also written by M. Mitchell?

I read GWTW when I was 12, and I thought Scarlett was awesome! Then I grew up, saw the movie, woke up, and saw her for who and what she truly was. When I was 12 I wanted to be her. After I could see her for who and what she truly was I still felt a little badly for her. So much so that when she says "After all, tomorrow - is another day!" I hoped that she would eventually "grow up", see herself accurately and change enough so that she might even be able to get Rhett back. Who knows?

There is a sequel! It wasn't written by Mitchell but it is a very good sequel called Scarlett by Alexandra Ripley! It's been a long time since I read it, but I do remember I liked it!

Cool! I'll check our library.

It was also approved by Mitchell's estate so it's recognized as a legitimate sequel! And it pays absolute respect to the first book. I just wanted to add that because it was important to me anyway that it was Canon. It's also a little short series that came on in the 90s! It's on Peacock for sure that I know because I just saw it! 😊

Who knew? Are you referring to the movie sequel that was made, IDK, decades ago, that was terrible?

Yeap 🤣 I think it was a show first and then turned into a movie. It wasn't THAT bad 🤣

I don't see her as either. People get so hung up on whether she's good or bad but to me, it doesn't matter because she's fascinating. That's the beauty of her character. She does all these terrible things but you still want to see what she does next.

Even for a human, she’s an asshole

She's self absorbed, petty, naive, and eventually pays the price. She's also intelligent, capable, reliable, and determined. Don't know about good or evil.

The fact that she always pays the price makes everything worth it. And I'm not saying that because I like to see her suffer or anything. I'm saying that the book always punishes her for what she does wrong. I think that's probably what you're saying, too. So, whether she's good or bad(personally I think she's mostly bad in the beginning and mostly good by the end), she's intriguing to watch. She annoys me in a long of moments, most notably when she steals Kennedy from Suellen and ruins her socially, but she always pays and it makes it worth it to see how she'll change herself next.

Truth be told, most of the characters in Gone With the Wind are generally unlikeable, including Rhett Butler who at one point rapes Scarlett. Everyone has their flaws, and enough so to make them horrible people. To that end, the only character in the entire movie who the audience can get behind, is Mammy.

only main character who isn't unlikeable is melanie.

She wakes up in a very good mood after that scene. So I'm not so sure we can use that word for their drunken married post-fight sex. Maybe a little 50 shades of grey kind of thing. Who knows. But I agree Mammy is the only completely likeable character.

It doesn't matter if Scarlet woke up in a good mood. If she was forced to have sex against her will, as occurred in the scene, then it was rape.

They're drunk and angry. He carries her up to the bedroom. We don't see what happens. The director let us believe that something traumatic and horrible was about to happen, then it fades out and we're greeted with a super cheerful, content and well-rested Scarlett. It's ambiguous and confusing and I refuse to label it, Mr. Virtue Signaler.

On screen, we see her walking away from Rhett and rejecting his advances, yet he still forces Scarlet to have sex with him. That is rape. It doesn't matter that she was satisfied afterwards. That doesn't mean it ceases to be rape. If she did not consent before the sex occurred, then by definition it is rape. That they were drinking doesn't make it any less a case of rape either. In fact, the alcohol consumption makes it a more clear cut case of rape. You can't consent if you're drunk.

Nice way of proving you're an incel or far right loser by the way, what with calling me a virtue signaller. Since you seem to be willing to defend rape, you can go f*%£ yourself. 🖕

That poster is legit the creepiest.

Rhett was drunk, scary, and menacing. Obviously, during the night he said or did something to make Scarlett be in a good mood the next morning. I would not have forgiven him for saying he could crack my head like a walnut. I would have served him divorce papers so fast his head would spin. I don't care if the sex was good or not, domestic violence is pretty disgusting when it gets to the level I saw in the movie.

You are a virtue signaler, and you're judging an 80 year old movie based on events during and after the Civil War on today's morals. If you read the book you'd also know he did not rape her.

I see. You hate it when people point out when rape has occurred. You try and belittle and degrade them by using epithets that aren't as negative as you believe, because you want to make those people appear weak and fragile.

So congratulations. You're defending rape.

You do realize you are arguing with someone who doesn't even know you or care about your opinion, I hope. It's not me. It's some other clown on here.

You can't consent if you're drunk.

What a bozo.

Digging up a comment more than a year old to fling an insult at someone because they point out the truth?

I don't remember the scene from the movie well, but in the book, once he sobers up, Rhett himself believes he raped her as evidenced by him being so ashamed of himself he leaves town afterwards. I think it's pretty clear HE believed he forced himself on her, so it's pretty hard to justify the scene as co sensual.

Congrats. You win the Creepiest Post award.

I bet if someone orgasmed during rape, you'd say "it isn't rape because they came". Ew.

She's a huge b and gets everything she deserves by the end.

But she's a masterfully written character and nonetheless you still feel for her.

Like most real people, she's complex, both good and bad.

If you read the book, Scarlett started out a little brat, but as the war ravaged her state & her family she took over and did what she needed to do to feed & house her family, & Ashley's. If she'd been a man they would have praised her for being a go getter, smart, forward thinking but alas she's a woman so she was labeled a bitch. Ashley, who was MUCH older than Scarlett, led her on for over a decade. He knew she was in love with him and didn't tell her to stop, and even encouraged her behavior, because he liked the attention.

I think Scarlett walled herself off emotionally because everyone she loved, did not love her back or had died. She was afraid to love Rhett because she though he was using her and to a degree he was, but they did love each other in their own messed up ways.

TL;DR I see her as a good person who did bad things to take care of herself & everyone around her.

I think she was a shitty woman and would've been a shitty man

I think we have different memories of the book. It may have been after a while, but Ashley does tell her to stop, and he's clearly ashamed of "leading her on". He's gentlemanly but a coward, but that doesn't necessarily make him worse than her, does it?

Oh look, another crazed feminist who seems to think men lionize the worst aspects of other men, rather than the most sacrificial. Other men might admire her, kind of. No man would ever follow her, even if it was a him. And any man would know that.

You might want to have your fragile white male syndrome checked, it seems to be fairing up something fierce.

As for the rest wut?

"White male syndrome" ——sweetie, you proved his points with the lack of your own. Jfc you just assumed he was white because he didn't agree with you. Lol I bet YOURE a privileged white girl just dying to fight about anything to make their own boring life seem important.

As a non white and non male (since that matters so much to you) I'll say it: you're a racist, sexist, closed minded, feminist idiot who clearly loves the sound of their own voice. And I really hope you grow as a person.

Ps: Scarlett is an asshole. Even if she had a dick, she'd be an asshole.

Do you apply this judgment to Movie Scarlett as well, or just Book Scarlett?

Both, I find it hard to separate the 2.

She's a conceited, greedy, manipulative, and self-centered brat in both the novel and the movie. She's got her sympathetic qualities and moments, just like Rhett. A good example is her growing soft spot for Melanie Hamilton as a friend, even though she hated her for a while at first. . However, in spite of Scarlett's flaws, you do have to admire her determination to survive when life stops being easy for her. Unlike her sisters and many other women of her time, she doesn't just fall beside herself and cry when Tara starts losing money, she starts working to make money for food and shelter to survive.

I agree, and I also think she was so young when everything happened, and I think people forget about that.

I never read the book, but in the movie she comes across as entitled, calculating, and unlikeable.

She was an entitled and privileged girl who survived a war. She did what she had to do to not only survive the war and poverty, but she took care of her family and friends so that they would survive too. You never know what you would do in her shoes.

read the fucking book

Why? Is it worth it?

In the book is she entitled, calculating, and unlikeable? Or is she more of a hot mess?

In the book you see a lot more depth behind her actions and motivations than you do in the movie. The movie doesn't do a good job of showing her thought processes. It also cut out about half of the book. The movie doesn't even address that she had 3 children, let alone any depth of character she has.

Is she more likeable once you know what she is thinking?

Scarlet was the definitive ambitious woman.

Scarlet is neither good or bad. She is a character with the will to do what it takes to survive. She is the epitome of what Margaret Mitchell referred to as having 'gumption'.

Also, I love this movie, it's insanely beautiful and well acted, but even at its length, the movie leaves out some key details about Scarlett which I think does a disservice. However, it was ballsy enough having that strong of a female character in a novel let alone having her be that way entirely on film.

Side note: Ashley can kiss a fish. The movie hints at it, but the book really shows how much he led her the fuck on.

She is a character with the will to do what it takes to survive.

No one is questioning Scarlett's drive to save Tara etc. That part is admirable, regardless of what gender she is.

We're calling her out for continuing an emotional affair with Ashley, dressing up & simping for him, while cutting her actual husband off & only showing Rhett enthusiasm when he offers her huge amounts of money. Ffs, the movie even has a scene blatantly comparing her with a prostitute, & Scarlett comes off as worse. Literally, "has no heart". Well actually, she does, just with a man other than her husband & father of her daughter.

She either has agency or she doesn't.

You do realize that in the book Ashley actually leads her on and is a tremendous part of the problem.

Scarlett is neither good or bad, and I think reducing her to such is missing the entire point. Almost no one in the book/film is wholly good or wholly evil. It's not about that.

Whether Scarlett is a good or bad person is literally the point of OP's post, as well as a perennial question in lit classes. So yes this kinda is about that.

We all agree Ashley is awful. And Rhett has lots of flaws, many of which arguably map into the social mores (racism, prostitution) of the day, as do many of Scarlett's (beating slaves, unabashed gold-digger, etc).

The question is if Scarlett is even worse than Rhett ('cruel abandoner') or Ashley ('cruelly leads-her-on'). That's a useful question, bc the relationship mores she broke (emotional affair, verbal abuse, etc) haven't changed to this day

Right and I'm saying she's neither good nor bad and that it's not really relevant to the movie or the book. Scarlett isn't a good digger either. She's a business woman who is money-hungry but in the sense that she wants control and power and her own money and not having to be a weeping soft woman at the beck and call of a man. It's one of the reasons she despises Melanie. It's also what so finally realizes about Ashley, that he's soft, weak.

A horrible narcissist person. That's why she ended up alone. Rhett was so much better of a parent and deserved a better woman.

Even though she is a strong character with admirable qualities, I would prefer to not be acquainted with her in anyway.

Evil fucking cunt the worst kind of hoe bag on the planet... the type that lies manipulates and uses people knowing she will kill them in the worst way in the end. She has a momentary omg moment and then back to ruthless fuck all you lab rats go die mentality. She panders to anyone above her throwing anyone below her into the pits of hell just to save her own worthless soulless ass.

Okay, Rhett, settle down.

I felt she was a horrible person. She only thought of herself at every turn. Even at the very end right after Melanie passed away, she was self-absorbed. She may have had a few moments of realization, however, it was not enough.

She did have much strength, passion and intelligence.

Complete piece of shit.

Absolutely a bad girl. Scarlet occasionally latches her selfish wagon hitch to the promise of riches capitalism brings. So a couple of others are neutrally affected. But overall everyone is unhappy. I think today we would accuse her of boarder line personality disorder. A very gregarious and willful character who could have done so much for those who crossed her path.

She had the opportunity to become a physician's assistant or a successful business woman. She couldn't help but subvert her own fortunes because she lacked insight. It's a Southern Gothic Tragedy. In real life terms very similar to the Alex Murdough saga in South Carolina. In the end we see the character for who and what Scarlet is about. Don't be a Scarlet. She's mean.

Frankly my dear, I don't give a damn. But if pressed, she was complex, with both good and bad tendencies/ motivatoons.

obviously a terrible person.

I'm so late to this, but this is one of my favorite movies. That being said, I find Scarlett to be a very manipulative and selfish person who also possessed good qualities like resiliency, fortitude, and cleverness. She screwed over those whom she claimed she cared for (but they also wouldn't be alive had it not been for her). The movie's portrayal is interesting because most of the men in her life saw through her flaws. And the two other main women showed a dichotomy. There was Melanie, who was truly too good hearted to see through the negative qualities of Scarlett. And there was Mammy, who called S out on her every antic, but

also understood the dire situation at the time. As trite as it sounds, I find that it captures the very essence of mankind and the choices we have to make in everyday life

I've always admired her for her survival instincts and pluck

I also want to slap that snobbish look off her face.

Honestly I think she's both, because she was so young at the time everything was still happening. But she definitely isn't the good guy, but she's not the villian.

She is a survivor and she implemented the strengths she had in clever ways.

scarlett's character was a big reason i don't like gone with the wind. she's so annoying, bratty, and unlikable. she goes through no development throughout the movie

She's a complicated character, that's all I can say. She's human. We've all made mistakes and hurt people, and we've all done good in this world too. I think Gone With the Wind shows both the good and evil sides of the human mind; Scarlett's faults don't just only hinder her from advancing in her hero's journey as in many other books, they actually make her do horrible things.

A cunt and a hoe.

All these verbose responses.. and this says 100% the most 😍

The most capricious character, embarrassing how she was so obsessed with Ashley. So mature about money but so infantile about love

I've only seen the film so that's what I'm going off of, but In my opinion she's horribly selfish in ways that shocked me.

In the beginning of the movie it seemed to me like Scarlett was content with her love life. She liked the parties, where all of the eligible men catered to her every need in hopes of becoming her beau, in full control of her decision…. UNTIL she heard that Ashley was getting married!!! why did she wait so long to tell Ashley she loved him (the barbecue) if she was so obsessed? Because she didn't want him until somebody else already had him!! Scarlett is the worst kind of woman, spoiled. She only married her first husband because he was Ashley's brother in law, she only married Mr. Kennedy because she was broke, (and evil for doing that to her little sis) and she only married Rhett because she didn't wanna work anymore. She didn't rest in tearing apart Melanie's and Ashley's marriage until she realized she wasn't the center of Ashley's world…… even though he made it clear he wasn't a dishonorable man and he loved Melanie. Shes insufferable until she gets what she wants and will destroy who ever is in the way of that her sister, her daughter, all 3 of her husbands:/ news flash this women is horrid nobody should look up to the movie version of Scarlett 😭 😂

When I first read GWTW as a teenager I admired her; I even wanted to be like her. As I grew up I realized who and what she was. Now she strikes me as being a narcissist; I'm not sure which type.

I absolutly cannot stand her. If for any other reason was because of her treatment toward her children. I hate dismissive and unfeeling mothers. Idgaf she was only 16 when she had wayde, it inexcusable for her to treat him that way. It always baffled me why Melanie wanted her to keep her baby. Why would anyone want scarlette to keep their kid. She has her moments, and I enjoy her banter and her abilities but I dislike her as a person. She's awful.

I absolutely couldn't stand her throughout the whole book. She's greedy, manipulative, selfish and cold. She didn't care who she hurt, whose life she trampled as long as she didn't end up poor. She didn't love her children and was a terrible mother. How people act like she's some amazing hero baffles me.

I just watched this movie for the first time ever. I am 31 and I had seen so many clips and my family talked about how good this movie it.

Firstly, Scarlett is NOT a good person. She is a devious flirt that would only hit on men to get what she wanted. Selfish, arrogant, a cheater AND she screwed over the ONLY good character Melanie. The only one that stuck up for her. And she screwed her over by swooning over her husband Ashley.

Scarlett is terrible. Scarlett needed to get the beating that she gave Prissy. Even her own dad was telling her to be kind to the house workers(Prissy, Mammy, Etc). She was verbally abusive to everyone in her life. Scarlett is one of the most unlikable character I've seen on screen.

As far as the movie itself, the pacing was really bad. The dad and the daughter falling off the horses and then they are just dead. So corny. I wasn't sure if that was normal corny for that time period. People fell off horses and they didn't just die every time.

Overall the movie was okay for being an older movie. Obvs a lot of racism and sexism in that movie but hey, I figured that would happen.

I first read the book when I was 26 years old. I grew up middle class without want or any real responsibility, so I identified with the gallantry of the planters. I thought Scarlet was human garbage. But, I'm the kind of person who loves to hate on shitty characters, so I finished the novel. The second time I read it I was 57 years old. Like most people, I'd experienced love and loss, crushing responsibilities, kids and grandkids. While I still think Scarlet is a terrible, selfish person, I have come to admire her pragmatism, strength of mind and body, and her resilience. She literally saved the lives of 13 people who would have simply starved to death. That's not nothing, even if her motivation to do so was less than saintly. I think it was brilliant of Margaret Mitchell to not sell out and make her some kind of heroine in the end. She maintained the truthfulness of the character until the end, and I admire that. Survivors do what they need to do to survive, regardless of morals. In some cases, such as this one, nicer people benefit from it.

The book and movie in question are both white supremacist propaganda. They are racist garbage not worthy of any other analysis.

You have the depth of a teaspoon.

Lol, wut? How is it supremacist? More like proto woke feminist garbage.

T12 What do you think of Scarlett

What do you think of Scarlett O' Hara? In some ways Scarlett is an admirable person and an inspiration. She doesn't let hardship or setbacks phase her along, she can be an excellent friend (when she has a mind to be) and is determined to lie, cheat, kill and steal as God is her witness.

The issue though is she is one of the most mean spirited and self centered hero's I've seen.

She doesn't really care about anyone but herself, and all her friendships (including Rhett) seem a mean to some sort of end.

She envies and desires Ashley Wilkes, sort of a young Georgian Robert E Lee, but it's only because he is " the best". She doesn't really have anything in common with him.

She throws plates at people, was happy to let Melanie die in childbirth, and slapped and threatened to beat her little slave girl, prissy. When she and Rhett are planning their honeymoon to New Orleans, Rhett asks her if maybe Mammy would like a souvenir from there. Scarlet shrugs and says " why would I care?" even though mammy had to be the O' Hara's family slave all her life and a nice souvenir would be the least she deserved.

What do you think of Scarlett?

She is a paradox. Her conscious thoughts were horrible, but she fought like hell for and took care of everyone in her circle. She thought she would like to see Melanie die, but she took as good care of her as she possibly could.

She is this amazing mix of good and bad qualities, and I unapologetically love her.

Also, Prissy deserved to be slapped. Even her mom slapped her.

Scarlett slaps 4 people in the movie and of those, Prissy's definitely feels the most justified

Who were the other 3? Wait, Ashley, Rhett, and who? Because honestly, they deserved a slap too- one was a coward and a cheat and a manipulator, the other was a rapist

SueEllen, her sister

Oh yeah, she deserved that (somewhat) too

Deserving a slap because of who you are as a person is not the same as a slap being a justified response to the immediately preceding actions

Well, Ashley was doing those things when he got the slapped

Didn't Ashley get slapped in Part I, when he was telling Scarlett that he was going to marry Melanie?

Oh yeah... But anyway, he was manipulative throughout the film, and cheated, so I have no sympathy anyway

It's not clear to me if Prissy was sort of slow and stupid or she honestly didn't care if Melanie died, or was sort of aiming for that?

I always felt she was a bit slow

It's pretty clear in the book; she's slow, to the annoyance(/detriment) of everyone including her mother Dilcey. It's more ambiguous in the film.

I sort of thought because of the hatred she might have from slavery she'd be callous and cold toward the idea of someone like Melanie dying

Again, you might be able to argue that in the film, but it doesn't work in the book.

Prissy took her time because she hoped that the baby would be born before she got back, and no one would know that she lied about knowing everything about birthing babies.

Honestly, she's a survivor and she took care of a lot of people, even if she was kind of a dick. We are all quick to judge her, but she was just a young teen with zero survival skills at the beginning of the book. She's

an imperfect person, but she got thru the civil war, kept her family home, and helped her family start over and rebuild a life. She could be unkind to other people and selfish, but if you lost everything you had and knew, wouldn't you panic and want to hold on to everything as closely as possible too?

But she was that way before the war too.

She was 16 when the Civil War began and fresh off of having her heart broken/'told No' for the first time in her life (both by Ashley) when she impulsively married Charles Hamilton. Within a year, she was a widow with an infant; imagine dealing with all of this at 17...I had my only - completely unexpected - child at 21 and I spiraled hardcore for the first few years.

Atlanta was burned when Scarlett was 19 and the war ended when she was 20. She (at least according to the book) married Frank Kennedy either that year or the year after; at best she was on her second marriage and second pregnancy, out of desperation, by 21 or 22.

When I look back at myself at those ages, I can only cringe as to how immature I was back then. And I graduated from high school and college by 22, then went on to graduate school. In the time period of GWTW, that level of education was unimaginable for girls & women... So I always keep this in mind, which the film clearly obfuscates, leading to this cultural interpretation of Scarlett as terrible, awful, self-centred, etc. which I have always found unfair in the extreme.

Just my 2 cents 🤷‍♀️

Nail on the head. it was about survival over anything else

I admire her spirit and her determination while also recognizing that she is definitely not the most moral person, and that's putting it gently. I see shades of her in my own personality as well, especially as I've had to fight and claw my way through early adulthood, but I also use her as a model of what not to do in many situations.

I posted this as a reply to a comment thread, but I think it bears repeating on its own:

"Scarlett

mo

Just my 2 cents 🤷‍♀️ "

To be fair she took Melanie to Tara because she promised Ashley she'd look after her and couldn't bring herself to go back on her word, she didn't leave her to die in childbirth. And at Tara Scarlett made sure that Melanie had rest, food, and the only pair of shoes. Scarlett hated every minute of caring for Melanie and resented it deeply, but she did it.

She did but only because dr Meade shamed her into it

No he didn't. Dr Meade wanted Melanie to stay put and asked Scarlett to stay with her, but when the Yankees invaded they had to run, and Scarlett took Melanie with them rather than leave her at a hospital where she probably wouldn't get the care she needed. Also, Scarlett stayed in Atlanta with Melanie long after everyone else evacuated, including Miss Pitty. She did not like Melanie, but she took care of her, because she had promised Ashley.

She's easily the most frustrating protagonist I've ever come across and I love it

What, moreso than Cathy and Heathcliff?

Good point! I find Scarlett much more likable than so many classic literature protagonists. And she actually had to struggled for survival unlike so many of the others who are spoiled and mean spirited.

I…don't know who those people are.

Oh okay. They're in Wuthering Heights

She's the worst person I love to read about. She's relentlessly pragmatic, but lacks empathy and is selfish. It makes for an interesting character, because as much as I don't like her, she is incredibly well written and she survives and flourishes where others could not.

I think she learned empathy in the end. She witnessed Ashley mourning Melanie and I think for the first time she saw who he was.

I agree, and after Bonnie died she longed for the old friends she had alienated. I think she did become a better person by the end, or at least a more empathetic one, but it was sort of too little too late.

I choose to think they reconciled :).

Have you read the sequel, I know it was a different author but I actually enjoyed it. The mini-series sucked though.

I read the sequel, years ago. There is another novel, that I don't think had permission from the Mitchell estate. It is called The Wind Done Gone. It is from a slave's point of view.

Oh i actually own that book! That and another book called Rhett Butler's People, but for some reason I've never read either of them. I'm actually listening to gone with the wind as we speak. I haven't read it in a long time. There is another really good book that I love called Margaret Mitchell & John Marsh: The Love Story Behind Gone with the Wind that is really good and I plan to read it again.

I think I actually liked the sequel more than the original.

Rhett Butler's People is an untouched staple on my bookshelf 😂 It's moved with me 5 times and I always put it back on the shelf but I've never read it.

She's not a nice person, but she has a grudging loyalty to people she considers herself responsible for.

How did she want Melanie to die in childbirth? I like Scarlett, she's strong and a survivor. Does she have flaws, of course, but if there's a war going on around me, I would want her to be with me She gets blamed for being a brat but she does a lot of growth during the book.

She's a fantastically entertaining character and she has a lot of admirable qualities. But the fact that she's so terrible in many aspects is what makes her so much fun to read about.

I always thought her character was about the growth she came into at the end

I love Scarlett faults and all.

I love her

I read somewhere that those who survive are often not the best kind of people. I think the character of Scarlett O'Hara illustrates that well.

We also have to remember that at the beginning of the book she is 16 years old, wealthy, and over-priveleged.

The appeal of Scarlett is that she is a morally grey character. People like nuance.

I agree with most of this, but that is the point, tbf. She's not meant to be a good person (although tbf, she's a downright angel compared to Cathy and Heathcliff).

Scarlett is a complex character, with good and bad qualities, and that's what makes her so compelling.

We had an assignment in college to use a fictional character and diagnose them with a mental illness. I diagnosed her with borderline personality disorder.

She's an anti-hero, sort of like Rhett 🙌🏽 female main character anti-heroes are not so popular in fiction, unfortunately

I think she's a HORRIBLE person, but I like to think she redeems herself in the sequel "Scarlett" lol (which is probably why I love that book so much)

Didn´t she slap Prissy because she lied about her knowledge about giving birth? I would slap her too

Scarlett has always been my hero, and her determination justifies the way she walked all over people. She had to, or starve to death. She was single-minded, and rose to every occasion to not be beaten down. How can anyone not like her?

She may not have been on a battlefield but make no mistake she was absolutely at war.

Spoiled brat and very racist.

T13 Scarlett O'Hara — punishment

Scarlet O'hara punishment I just finished Gone with the Wind. Scarlett is such a fascinating character and a compelling antiheroine. But I can't help feeling that Margaret Mitchell punishes her throughout the story. Was it really necessary for her to endure so much—losing her child, her only true friend, and ultimately Rhett—just to realize she loved him all along? Is she denied happiness because of her flaws? It seems as though the narrative refuses to let her find peace or redemption, no matter how much she evolves.

To realize that she loved Rhett, she had to realize that she never loved Ashley. To realize that she never loved Ashley, she had to see him as he was. To see him as he was, he had to lose Melanie.

That's what's so tragic about it.

Also, it's not a romance, it's a drama. She's not promised a happy ending.

It's a romance, a drama, a Bildungsroman, a historical fiction, and above all, an epic. A happy ending is never a given.

I don't think it was a punishment. It was a reality of the time she lived through. All the other women and most men had a lot of bad things happen to them too.

Exactly and until the Frank dies, it feels like that. But after Frank death it feels like a penury after penury just to demonstrate how strong is Scarlett that can survive to anything that happens to her.

Bonnie's death demonstrated how much she had alienated everyone. If she had cared about her relationship with Rhett and maintaining friendships with people, she would have had so much support and comfort after

Bonnie died, but that's when she realized the cost of her course of action. People didn't matter to her, only financial security. So that one time when people could help and money couldn't, she felt the shock of it. But ultimately she was never going to change, she would always put money before people.

The part where after bonnie dies and she's wishing she was friends with maybelle etc to talk about the past. But before this when melonie would talk about what happened during the war she wanted to forget it. If the stuff at Tara hadn't happened she maybe wouldn't have been how she was - but she also wouldn't have got what she had

Rhett told her she married a boy and an old man and that he would try to give her the best life possible. He built that grand mansion to rival Tara and took Tara's slaves to the new mansion .

Scarlett is the poster child of the "be careful of what you wish for" and "be careful not to take things for granted" tropes. At the cost of having Ashley to herself, Bonnie and Melanie died, and Rhett left her, for example.

Exactly. Scarlett had some pretty terrible attributes in addition to her great attributes, and in many ways she got the karma she deserved.

She was a very spoiled child and they basically catered to her before the war .She was the belle of the ball and all the girls age really didn't like her.She grew up with Ashley and was really hoping to marry him even though her father told her that was never going to happen.

Hmm, interesting take! I've never thought of Scarlett's misery as a punishment.

To me, it feels more like character development than punishment.

MM didn't necessarily punish her for her flaws. It's just that, because of those flaws, she was unable to recognize what real happiness was. It feels like a natural part of her personality rather than a consequence imposed on her.

Hope that makes sense!

This is my favorite take!

This reminds me of discussions I've seen about hamartia not so much as simply a 'fatal flaw' but that within the character of the protagonist of a tragedy that makes the tragedy inevitable. It's causal rather than punishment.

The problem with your theory is the last sentence. She can't FIND redemption because she doesn't SEEK redemption. She thinks she can play Rhett, which she can't because he knows her too well. She can't read him just like she can't read Ashley. Hell, she can hardly read herself!

It takes getting what she thinks she wants, Melanie gone and Ashley free, to appreciate all three of them for what they truly are: Melanie as the truest sister she ever had that loved her more than any woman on the planet except Ellen and Mammy and gave everything she had for her family; Ashley as the sniveling, weak willed, milquetoast man that didn't even have the courage to fully stand up for his marriage and instead let Scarlett keep hope alive for a decade or so; and Rhett, who always loved her from the moment she agreed to dance with him as a widow in mourning. Who not only accepted her for who she was, but loved her all the more for it. If they could have been honest (Rhett, Scarlett and Ashley), they all could have had happier more beautiful lives. So many times Ashley could have changed things but wimped out. So many times Scarlett hurt Rhett, thinking he didn't care, which made him want to hurt her back.

But my favorite thing about this love story is that it is realistic. Sometimes love is too little, too late. He put up with her shit for a long time. And sometimes love just ain't enough.

Side note: There are two really could compilation videos on youtube about Rhett and Scarlett all of you might like. One is to Maroon 5's One More Night. The other is to Celine Dion's It's All Coming Back to Me Now. The last one made me cry. Check them out.

She gets Rhett back in my mind. Maybe Margaret Mitchell felt that way too

The ending said it all. Tomorrow is another day. We can rest assured she will get him back.

Ugh, I hope not. He deserves better.

The part that was really punishment is the way that Mitchell mischaracterizes Scarlett from the very beginning. Almost as if she resents her qualities and charms.

In her very first sentence, she says that Scarlett O'Hara was not beautiful, then proceeds to describe her beauty.

She claims that Scarlett doesn't enjoy any conversation in which she is not the chief topic of conversation, then proves that wrong by having Scarlett explicitly express interest in the twins being expelled from college and their brother Boyd really having really wanted to go and get an education.

It continues throughout. Her behavior is exactly the opposite of how Mitchell describes her.

Scarlett's worst fault is that she doesn't know herself. She has absolutely no ability to self reflect in a true and forthright way. The only one who knows Scarlett less is Mitchell.

She doesn't think she's at all like her mother, but throughout the entire book, she saves everybody, even if it gives her no pleasure.

Melanie sees this and appreciates it. She sees how much Scarlett sacrifices and how much she gives.

The other terrible thing is that Mitchell keeps having her pine over Ashley. But Rhett is no better, so by the end of the novel, despite everything that she has achieved and everyone whom she has saved, she is still lacking.

If she were a bit more self-aware, she would realize that she has become the man that she has always desired. Because the truth of the matter is, she didn't really have a whole lot of desire for anyone.

And that is not because she's selfish, but just because she's self sufficient. In her world, she would not have realized that there was value in independence.

And perhaps that is Mitchell's greatest punishment on her. Because independent women were not valued in Scarlett's time or in Mitchell's.

Mitchell judges, Scarlet, harshly throughout the entire novel with little merit.

I don't think Scarlett is being punished.

Remember in the movie Casablanca when the protagonist says, "I'm no good at being noble, but it doesn't take much to see that the problems of three little people don't amount to a hill of beans in this crazy world"?

Of course, we, the audience, DO care about "the problems of three little people," otherwise, the movie wouldn't be nearly so popular as it is! But it's also an important aspect of Casablanca that their love triangle

is playing out against the backdrop of staggering, unimaginable misery and upheaval of far greater significance than their personal unhappiness.

I think there's a similar dynamic at play in Gone with the Wind. What's going on the background is just so huge—far too painful and overwhelming to be fully described. Many suffered much worse fates than the Scarlet O'Hara during the Civil War, but, as human beings we actually have an easier time comprehending and thus sympathizing with the suffering of one single individual, so works of art—such as novels—tend to tighten the focus to just a few characters at most.

Obviously, Scarlett's particular personality, her mistakes and self-sabotage, are important to the appeal of the novel, just as her courage and determination are. But she's not suffering so much merely because she's willful or foolish. So much of what she goes through was far from self-inflicted. Some people—like Scarlett—show incredible resilience in coping with trauma, but that doesn't mean they aren't damaged by it. And Scarlett is a great example of how being a strong person who overcomes major setbacks doesn't necessarily make you saintly, or even particularly wise.

Scarlett is probably a victim of PTSD. She suffered greatly after the war. She had nightmares for years. Money was the one thing that really made her feel safe. Money meant no more hunger, fear, cold. She wasn't working in the lumber mill still after becoming one of the wealthiest women in Atlanta before she just loved lumber so much. She was scared of becoming broke again. During the time right after the war was the only time in her life she felt helpless. That helpless feeling was worse than all the rest,

She didn't realize the money was part of what was making her so lonely too until it was too late,

Mitchell said herself, not every story has a happy ending, in a way, Scarlett life is a tragedy. However, she's still pretty young even at the end of the book. Will is around 10 so Scarlett may not even be 30 yet. She's got a lot of time to make a new ending. Go home to Tara and lick her wounds so to speak. I liked the idea of her going to Charleston for a while.(Bur no Ireland. What was that mess?). In a new city, she could make a respectable new start. Rhett can't ignore her forever. Make a new start. Sell the house in Atlanta. Travel like Rhett wanted her too. Come back maybe with another child and live right across the street from India and dare her to say a word.

Idk how old Will Benteen is but Wade should be 11 and Scarlett is 28 when the book ends.

I meant Wade. Two totally different people. Lol

Without the suffering Scarlet doesn't develop resiliency. The suffering is necessary for character development.

It mirrors the futility of the Civil War, IMO.

Her journey and growth through overwhelming adversity is pretty much the point of the novel.

Scarlett never has an abortion. She has a miscarriage.

Yes sorry English is not my first language

...in medical terms, a miscarriage is an abortion.

Only if you put the word "spontaneous" in front of it.

I think we have this idea that authors punish or reward characters based on what they "deserve" but ultimately the idea that anyone gets what they deserve is a victim-blaming mindset. People get stuff they

don't deserve all the time! And great authors like to write life as it is, not as they'd like it to be. (Not that I'm saying you're being victim-blaming, OP!! It's just a common mindset that we as a society don't recognize as victim-blaming for a sense of control.)

That said, if you want to feel better, read Scarlett. It's the sequel to Gone With the Wind which was not written by the original author but supposedly was outlined by her.

Edit: According to Google I was wrong and Margaret Mead did not outline Scarlett. Sorry I fact-checked myself after answering! Anyway, it still continues her story and is a kind of wish fulfillment.

Margaret Mitchell wrote Gone with the Wind. As far as I have ever known, there is no outline for a sequel.

I didn't care for Scarlett at all. It was written by Alexandra Ripley. I found that Rhett Butler's People was very well researched, as was Ruth. The story of Mammy. Not as good as GWTW, but much better than Scarlett. These were written by Donald McCaig.

I'm not sure Scarlett is the type woman who would let herself get punished. She always finds a way.

Scarlett isn't punished by her sins, but for her sins. Rhett sums it up best- "she throws happiness away with both hands" but she's never satisfied. She had a lot of terrible tragedies happen to her, but she had to carry them alone because she herself had used up everyone around her, and bulldozed her way through life. I have been reading this book almost every year for 35 years and I am always amazed with how my opinions on it have changed. When I was younger I admired her, as I grew a little older I could still appreciate her strengths while realizing her flaws, as I near 50 I see her as the most unlikable person in literature. If I knew a Scarlett in real life I would run far, far away from her.

It's a tragedy.

Now don't go feeling too bad for Scarlett! While it's true that some of her suffering was from circumstances outside of her control, she also made some willful decisions that make her less of a victim in my eyes. I should preface this by saying this is my favorite book and she is my favorite female character of all time.

That said, consider the fact that she didn't have to marry Charles or Rhett for that matter, she didn't need either of them. You could argue that she needed to marry Frank to save Tara but not so with the other two. She chose to use prison laborers knowing that it would cost her the protection of Archie on her rides. She chose to continue to use prisoners even after she found out that Johnny Gallagher was starving them.

There are many points throughout the book where she could have chosen to be graceful, merciful or quiet but she instead spoke her mind, often out of spite and this made her many enemies. There were times where she wasn't forced to do something out of necessity but chose to do it because she was bored and wanted to have fun. Her actions often negatively affected other characters and Scarlett didn't care about that very much at all, generally.

Scarlett is a selfish child in many ways. Yes, she suffered greatly in her life but if she was not as stubborn as a mule she probably could have avoided a good deal of it.

Scarlett is the personification of the American South.We feel empathy for their suffering, but we want to believe that their pain is somehow justified for their bad behavior and their flaws.

In the end, we fall in love with Scarlett, we want her to be forgiven, transformed and loved.

I mean she was a narcissist and a horrible person. I think she could have learned something from one or two of those incidents, but she didn't even realize she loved her husband until it was too late.

I agree with you. I don't understand tho why their dynamics changed so much after they married. Rhett was a able to read Scarlett so well, and they were able to be honest to each other. But after they married it seems like they lost the ability to communicate to each other till the point to be strangers to each other that love each other im secretly.

The reason it doesn't go well is because they were never fully honest with each other (until the last chapter). Rhett was never honest about his love for Scarlett before they were married.

They were both very strong willed, stubborn and emotionally stunted people who didn't want to let the other "win". Their marriage felt a lot like a struggle for dominance and was simply not a stable partnership. They got along just fine as long as they didn't have to actually share a house and a life together, but the second that happened, it all fell apart.

I agree with this. I felt so frustrated that Rhett never told her how much he loved her. Two people who desperately loved each other, but couldn't be honest with each other and themselves. So many missed moments because they couldn't be honest. One would reach out and the other couldn't see it.

Have you read Scarlett? It's not by the same author, but I absolutely loved it, maybe even more than the original.

I tried. I really did. I couldn't finish it. I devoured GWTW, but couldn't stomach Scarlett.

This is what keeps me coming back to the book. Because it's so true to life! They just couldn't say I love you!! I never thought about this before, but that's exactly why I loved Lonesome Dove as well. The tragedy and very real inability of humans to connect. These are both two of my favorite books.

I think he expected her to fall out of love with Ashley when she stopped having to struggle (I think he realized that she held onto him as a remnant of the feeling of safety from before the war) then when she didn't he resented her.

He was emotionally punishing her even before she asked for separate rooms.

The Caveat Emporium is one of the worst things he did imo. It's so tiny but so casually cruel. A perfect example of the way he constantly tried to make her feel inferior.

I think after they got married at a certain point Rhett gets tired of the game.

Really, Gerald O'Hara says it right in the beginning chapters- Scarlett is a child that only wants the toys she can't have (when he tells her Ashley is going to marry Melanie, and sees that Scarlett is disappointed about this but tries to act nonchalant). And she can't be happy until like is with like. Like so many of us, if only Scarlett had understood and taken her father's words to heart then, she would have avoided so much of the bullshit in her love life. But, like many of us, she had to find out for herself and learn through life.

Wow. I'd forgotten that. Great point! You make it sound like one of the main messages of the novel, because it explains so much about the entire story. Gerald nails it early.

I think that Rhett gave her everything she ever wanted (except Ashley) and she still wasn't satisfied. It demoralized him so much that his love for her died just as she realized this.

Yeah, I agree, it was strange.

I accidentally deleted my previous comment.

I think you make a good point, people see rhett are the all knowing eye and puppet master but he's a mess himself. He doesn't stuff that doesn't make sense all the time and eventually throws scarlett under the bus to make himself look better/for bonnie

People definitely do see Rhett as all-knowing, in a way, which is a mistake. He’s pretty good at reading people, and he can, indeed, read Scarlett like a book, but that doesn’t mean he’s always right.

Rhett really didn’t understand her either.

He did for the most part.

Sounds like you only watched the movie, tbh

How far into it are you?

Oh wow you’re just starting it. Yeah…book Rhett can definitely read Scarlett well. You’ll find out.

T14 What should she have done differently

What realistically should have Scarlett done differently for you to like her? Given that almost all opinions I’ve seen on Scarlett O’Hara were negative with “deeply flawed” and “complex” being the mist complementary: what should have she done differently that would be more morally correct for you? And I mean realistically, given her situation, role in a society and the resources she has been having.

I’m writing a bit of my opinion bc apparently I want to get downvoted.

It looks like the only reason people have with Scarlett O’Hara is that she is a woman who behaves like a man, she is realistic, non-conformist, doesn’t give a shit about useless stuff, she is smart, knows how to manipulate the system of “all ladies and flowers”, doesn’t diminish herself and is surviving and sometimes even thriving because of it.

I’m officially not being sarcastic in this post at all. I have an exceptionally good opinion about Scarlett, don’t think she had done things that were really that wrong and even think that Melanie hasn’t done enough for her (although Melanie is probably the only one from the main characters, except Scarlett, about whom I have a good opinion about). Maybe I’ll have a post about it later, because I can write a full essay on the topic disproving most things the audience says about Scarlett. Honestly the fact that even now, with all the modern feminism, she still gets hated even though she was the one who saved everyone’s ass sacrificing his reputation without a single word of support, makes me pessimistic about the world in general. If Ashley had done everything Scarlett did, he would have been a tragic hero who would make audience rethink what the word sacrifice means. If Rhett had done it, he would’ve been even more adored and fapped on and even him being rapist and child murderer in the book would be seen as noble traits. And if Scarlett had been like Ashley or Rhett (even with half less intensity), she would’ve been the most despised female character ever.

After reading a book at 17, I was really surprised to find out that people hated Scarlett who was nearly flawless for me at that time. After rewatching the movie now, at 23, as a war refugee with the background of poverty, I am even more inclined to think she didn’t do anything wrong and did everything she could for the things that did make sense (the meaning of the opinions of grandmas, who didn’t help her with a single word or penny and whose morals were conquered and dying out, has no worth if you ask me). In fact, I’ll even say

16-years-old Scarlett was a bit unrealistically written on how great, noble, fierce and wonderful she was in her circumstances. Again, I'm not being sarcastic.

I think people forget a lot of the time that Scarlett is 16 when the book begins and only 28 by the end and in that time she had 3 children, 1 (Bonnie) died, had a traumatic miscarriage when she fell down the stairs, was widowed twice, had to escape the burning of Atlanta with a newborn and try to keep Melanie alive throughout the journey, lost both her parents …. and during all this everyone is always looking at her for how they'll survive, but blame her when she doesn't go about getting things done the "polite" way. The entire book shows her traumas and the effect they have in her. She refuses to let go of the lumber mill because she's terrified of what she'll do if she ever needs the money and doesn't have it. I feel like the people that judge Scarlett harshly have no clue or understanding of what everything she went through did to her emotionally.

People also forget how bad her PTSD was. Her obsession with money has very little to do with natural greed. She was used to being spoiled but she wasn't out there demanding diamonds at 16. She just liked being pretty and comfortable.

Her 'greed' was entirely about the trauma at Tara and her never ending fear that she may end up in that place of starvation again.

Like the line about how every time she tried to be kind and caring, she'd think about being hungry and cold and just wanted to go around snatching money from people's hands. As Rhett observed, before the war, she probably didn't know how many pennies were in a dollar because she never had to worry about money.

Yes she had never even thought about money growing up, it only became important to her when she had none. She learned the value of money late but very, very hard.

Well put. It was a brutal lesson, but she learned.

She should have let Ashley go to that job in the North, let him have his chance at self-reliance. The fact that she guilt-tripped him into staying shows that her supposed great love didn't include any concern for his welfare or happiness.

Shooting the Union soldier in the face wasn't bad, BTW. That was self-defense.

Ashley would have failed at that job. Scarlett put up with his business shortcomings because of her personal relationship and feelings. No one else was going to do that. They would have had no support system up north when that happened. I also doubt the southerners would have enjoyed the northern society. Melanie certainly would not have. Scarlett did him a solid. While he was too dumb to recognize that, Melanie was definitely appreciative.

I agree. Ashley was symbol of the antebellum south. He was a "gentleman." He was educated and had knowledge, but he had no practical skills. He wasn't able to adapt to a world that required ambition and thinking out of the box.

Its spelled out clearly multiple times throughout the novel. It's one of the big ironies of Scarlett.

Ashley himself said he would have spent his life "happily buried at Twelve Oaks."

Scarlett admired the people who thought out of the box to pick themselves up after the war. Rene selling pies out of a wagon.

She derided the people who "lacked gumption."

Even think back to the very beginning of the novel. Ellen stayed home from the party to deal with firing the overseer. India took on the task of running the BBQ. Mrs. Tarleton was the one who ran their plantation. Who took the boys in hand.

Ashley was the opposite of every person she admired.

I don't think he would have failed. Working in bank, with finances, is a lot different than managing mills and basically ordering people around.

His education would be a lot more useful in the bank, than in Scarlett's mills.

He messed up the ledgers though. Dude was not good with numbers.

If he would have had an offer to teach philosophy or literature at a university, that would have been a solid option for him.

Teaching would have been the best job for him.

I agree. Ashley was not sharp enough for business world, but he would have been a devoted teacher.

Working in a bank would be about denying people loans, and Scarlett's issue with Ashley was that he kept giving people lumber on credit because they were 'good people'. He would have been terrible in a bank.

I agree. He was a bright enough man, it's possible he'd have stayed employed, and he and Melanie would have been able to have a little home and lead a self-sufficient life. And if Scarlett had wanted Ashley to be happy, she'd have wished him well, and told Melanie to write if they ever needed help coming home.

But Scarlett didn't want Ashley to be happy, she wanted him close.

If she was smart she would have let him leave and when he failed he would come back and she would always have him there. She should have thought things through.

I agreed with you in advance! If she had any regard for him, and compassion al all, she'd have let the Wilkses ho and told Melanie she'd bring them home if things didn't work out.

I like Scarlett. I know she was spoiled but that was her parents fault. She grew as a person and learned

Even when she does questionable things, I get why she does them. The only time I get frustrated by her is her thing with Ashley and being blind to Rhett, but I get it. And knowing the times she lived through, the fact that she's a woman, and where she came up, it's not hard to see why she does what she does.

....and part of it was she did yearn for the "old days." When she was young, and carefree, and had no responsibilities. Ashley was her tie to those days, to her youth.

Tara and Ashley were her only ties to the times when she felt safe, so she clung to them with all her might.

Scarlett doesn't need people to like her! She goes from being a petulant self-absorbed teenager straight into survival mode. Later she wonders if she could have done it all and kept friends, but it's a rhetorical question because she couldn't have achieved financial security (for herself and others) without sacrificing the niceties.

To be fair there's definitely a middle ground, a lot of their friends survive but in a sort of 'genteel poverty' while upholding the niceties. The Merryweathers and Picards etc. But Scarlett didn't want genteel poverty, she wanted enough money to insulate her. I think she might have been less desperate if she'd had more help-

if Melanie hadn’t been so sick, if Gerald didn’t lose his mind, if she had someone like Will at Tara sooner, if her sisters were more useful- then she wouldn’t have had to rebound so hard. But she really got hit with a lot of unfortunate circumstances to manage alone.

Eh. No matter what she does I will always love her. She is smart, opportunistic, forward thinking and she did what she could with what she had.

I think Scarlett is an extremely compelling character, which isn't the same thing as thinking she's someone I'd want to spend time with (or emulate) in real life, but on the page or screen, she's fascinating. She's strong, determined, and committed to the survival of herself and her family. She may not be kind to her sisters, but she's the reason they don't starve to death after the war.

At the same time, she's extremely lacking in emotional intelligence, even her own feelings and motivations seem to be opaque to her much of the time, she's vain and self interested. All of that is part of the author's intent for her character. And then beyond that, for modern readers there's the issue of her lack of introspection regarding slavery and racism. That was, I believe, mostly invisible to Margaret Mitchell, but it does shape how people respond to her today.

Part of what makes her a lightning rod is that it's very rare for a woman in literature to be an antihero the way she is, even now. Especially in the 1930s, having a lead character who's equal parts valiant and toxic and who's also a woman was pretty revolutionary. I think that's part of why she's remained so iconic.

I LOVE Scarlett. For all her faults, she has strength, courage and intelligence. One reason I enjoy Scarlett over Rhett Butler's People as a sequel is Scarlett really lets her play on and even expand her strengths. She's fiercely loyal,even to Melanie whom she always claims to hate.

I honestly always felt the book is truly about the love Scarlett and Melanie have for each other. They are the strong women that manipulate the men to succeed. Scarlett just did it right in your face while Melanie would calmly guide Ashley. While yes Scarlett was jealous of Melanie having Ashley (because he was always leading her on) she also took care of her. They protected each other and cared for each other throughout the whole book and when Melanie dies and Scarlett realizes how wrong she was and how well Melanie truly knew her it always makes me cry. Honestly all the guys annoy me (even though I’ve lost count of how many times I’ve read the book and watched the movie) so I never understand how Scarlett can get villainized for mistreating the men. Screw the men!! Yay sisterly bond!!

In Alexandra Ripley's Scarlett, Scarlett comes to that very realization at Melly's graveside. She realizes how much she loved Melanie and how they were friends. She even befriends Rhett's future wife because she reminds her of Melanie.

I don’t consider that book canon though. I didn’t really like it and the mini-series was even worse. Plus she had already had that realization before the end of the original novel when Melanie was dying

The miniseries was really awful. And I like a villainous Sean Bean and it was STILL awful. But I liked the book because I liked it when Scarlett went to Ireland and was praised for all the things she was disparaged in Atlanta. I consider both Scarlett and Rhett Butler's People to be canon because I think officially they both are.

I can't answer your question because I agree that the hate she gets is absurdly sexist. And Rhett is no different from all the Nice Guys these days who think you are REQUIRED to date them if they do things for

you. (Which, of course, means they see you as an object to be manipulated instead of a full human with your own hopes and dreams. And then they treat you accordingly.)

However, I definitely think she's flawed, in large part because she was raised to think of no one but herself. Only Mammy truly knew her, and Mammy was all about helping her appear to be a gentlewoman, not challenging her to grow as a person. One thing she does that I could never get over is lie and marry Frank. How could you ever do that to a sister? She chose the land over her sister. And she did it, why? Because she wanted to! That's pretty selfish. But she did help Melanie at great personal risk, which was a very good thing to do. And she is just plain impressive in general with everything she accomplishes with stepping into the role as head of her family, saving Tara, and going into business.

I could be wrong but I think a lot of what has happened to cause the hatred is that Margaret Mitchell wrote about her rather unflinchingly. Most people when they write a book try to always portray their hero/ine in the best possible light. Even if the hero did a crappy thing, they'll explain why to make the person sympathetic. It's like they're writing a persuasive essay. The author likes their hero, and it shows. But Margaret Mitchell seems to be neutral or even ambivalent towards her heroine, and thus influences the reader to feel the same.

Taking Frank was absurdly hateful to Suellen, but Scarlett was right that it was the only way to save Tara. Suellen would have let them rot.

This! I can’t feel bad for SueEllen because she would’ve left and never turned back while they lost their home and probably starved. It’s horrible to steal your sister’s fiance, but SueEllen wasn’t a good person either.

I agree totally. I think Suellen would have let them starve. But (and I fully recognize this as my opinion and not based in provable fact) I always sensed that Scarlett did it mostly because she wanted to continue to own Tara, even more than she wanted to avoid starvation for herself and her family. That's actually a reason I'm so fascinated with the story. Scarlett is so totally led by what she WANTS, beyond what is considered respectable, yes, but even beyond what is reasonable. I wonder if this is the real reason she gets so much hate--because people see that she allows herself to be led by her desires and they are desperately envious of her for this choice, a choice they want to make but don't allow themselves.

Scarlett wasalways being told by her father to love the land, it was part of her etc. Perhaps the other sisters were not given that indoctrination.

I don't understand how anybody could hate Scarlett. Whenever I'm feeling really weak and sad and I need to listen to something about a strong woman I always listen to gone with the wind and I start the Earth's children series. I really look up to Ayla and Scarlett for how strong they are

I like her the way she is.

I live for opportunities to repost this essay:

A Defensive Analysis of The Staircase Sequence™

Ah, The Staircase Sequence™. The most controversial part of this story. I was widely told that it was much less ambiguous and unnerving in the book than it was in the film, but there’s always someone who disagrees. For our purposes, I don’t think it matters whether or not it would be classified as rape in the 21st century, and we don’t need to examine the classification of 1871. The question is this: what did Margaret Mitchell write in 1936, and what did she want the reader to think?

Firstly, for what it's worth, Scarlett regretted kicking Rhett out of her bed basically as soon as she did it, in Chapter 51. True, she doesn't want any more babies, she wants to feel loyal to Ashley, and the sex does nothing for her, but she still regrets turning Rhett away, and she regrets it for selfish reasons, not for fear of retaliation. That regret is not shown in the film.

One of the biggest pieces that the film botched (I say 'botched' because I can find no justification for the changes) was Scarlett's shoving Rhett away when he kisses her. In the book, Rhett's kisses essentially do a hard reset on Scarlett's brain. This is seen on the road back to Tara when Rhett leaves to join the fight, and again when he proposes. The third time is in The Staircase Sequence™; Scarlett was afraid because she'd never seen Rhett behave that way and she was not a fan of the way he physically picked her up, but any fight they had, any physical, mental or emotional resistance from Scarlett, was over the moment he kissed her. And this happens before The Wild Thrill™. This can't be a case of the "orgasm always equals consent" misconception being employed, due to the order of the events.

It makes perfect sense for the actual scene to be cut from the film; putting aside the Hays Code and all of its restrictions, this scene itself contains no physical directions. The reader is just given the thoughts in Scarlett's mind, clues open to interpretation about what's happening. This vagueness is the reason I love it. It would be extremely difficult to film even today, simply because the source material does not give much to go on. Writing and filmmaking are different artistic mediums, and things that work perfectly in a book can't always be translated to the screen. Because (among other things) 21st century audiences need everything spelled out clearly, a modern filming would probably keep the lead-up exactly the same as in the book, add some blocking that would fit, show everything, and slap a PG-13 rating on it because that's the state of our current society.

Another change that the film made: the last line Rhett delivers before ascending the staircase is not "This is one night you're not turning me out." as in the film; it's "By God, this is one night when there are only going to be two in my bed." That line is less…rapey than in the film, and while I immediately took notice of this, the reason didn't occur to me until later; it indicates that Rhett knows exactly what he's doing, that The Wild Thrill™ was no accident, especially when preceded by his line near the end of Part 4 (chapter 47, pg. 833). The subtext of the line in the film is "I'm taking what I want whether you like it or not."; it's Rhett focused on Rhett. The subtext in the book is Rhett focused on Scarlett.

Scarlett's feelings the next day in no way indicate a lack of consent; indeed, the shame seems to come from her willing & happy participation in the events. She actually feels that she has now gained some degree of control over Rhett.

Finally, a point that is not part of the narrative but does speak to the author's intent: it would be wise to note that (according to some; I've been told that the evidence is in The Road to Tara but have been unable to find it) Margaret Mitchell's ex-husband at one point showed up drunk at her house, beat her up, and raped her. I cannot imagine someone having that experience and also writing The Staircase Sequence™ the way she did, unless those two things were supposed to be completely unrelated. Someone who has been through such an event would not write a piece of fiction in which the protagonist experiences the same event as a good thing. It's infinitely more plausible that Mitchell wasn't writing a rape scene. Remember also that while they had a few things in common, Mitchell in no way based Scarlett O'Hara on herself.

A+ analysis. I would add though, that the reason this sequence feels "botched" in the movie is because of the Hays Code and modern audiences not taking that into account. The audience is meant to assume by Scarlett's happiness and singing to herself the next morning, that what happened after the fade to black was consensual

and that she had a really, really good time. That's why you don't see any of the rape discourse appearing until the mid-late 90s; the contemporary audience would have gotten it, but the modern audience far removed from the restrictions of the Hays era would not have unless they were aware of the historical context.

Thanks for the feedback.

The whole sequence doesn't feel "botched" to me, though; only the detail about her shoving away his kiss, because it directly contradicts the book. That's not a detail that was changed for the Hays Code. I'm not sure why they changed it the way they did. They could've just cut the kiss entirely. They could've done a number of things.

I said "putting aside the Hays Code and all of its restrictions" because if someone is bothering to read this essay, I assume they know about the Hays Code; if they don't, the google search will now be easier. Additionally, while most will just use the Hays Code as an excuse for why the scene doesn't have softcore porn, it's not the only reason.

That's why I brought up the Hays code, because it is critical to the movie sequence ending up the way it does. It was more than not being able to show sex on screen, it was showing women *enjoying* sex or sex-adjacent acts (ie: kissing) on screen. This is why we see Scarlett struggle against Rhett almost every time he kisses her in the movie (the notable time she doesn't is when they're married and walking around Tara.) She never does this in the book. As you said, when Rhett kisses her in the book, it's a hard reset and she just melts because she enjoys it. In the film, they had to be more careful about how they showed these scenes in order to make sure it didn't come across as promoting/endorsing "lewd acts."

I spent most of the book wanting to slap Scarlett and simultaneously wanting to hug her.

It's kinda the entire point of her character to be unlikable. MM was writing about survival, and the survivor isn't always the most morally upright person.

We're not really supposed to like Scarlett, and that's okay.

I love how Scarlett is a survivor and becomes a success in a man's world.

But it bothers me how she treats her oldest two children. She's neglectful and sometimes abusive. Yes she was young when she had Wade but a teenage mother can still be a loving caring motber

I like Scarlett because she is flawed, like we all are in real life.

I like her, people when it was written during the Depression liked her, it was a story about survivors. Not saying she was perfect, no one in that book is perfect, but she got herself and her loved ones through by any means necessary, hooray for her. The book does suggest she might have done so without going to such lengths, holding up people like the Merriwethers as an example of those who came through morally intact, but we also aren't shown if they face quite as dire of circumstances as Scarlett did.

IMO those who hate her focus on her ignorance of Rhett's love and rarely read the book, which clearly shows he did as much to make her think he didn't love her as that he did, and base it on the movie, that made Rhett look better to appease Clark Gable. Rhett was 35 chasing a 16 year old who fixated on a 21 year old neighbor as a coping mechanism during a war and diffcult times. Claiming he knew her well, he failed to understand her emotional ignorance kept her on surface level and she took him at his word that he didn't love her and never looked deeper until the end of the book, the he faulted her for his own failure to make her

deduce he loved her while seeming to go out of his way to make her think he hated her. It didn't help that her mother's marital bed advice was to lie there and hope for a baby to make enduring sex worth it.

Scarlett is strong, complex, misunderstood, flawed, smart, stupid and maddening all at once.

She hired convict labor and knew they were being systematically worked to actual death and decided to do nothing about it. She even said that Rhett understood and approved when she "robbed people blind" at the mill.

Don't tell me she was a good person. If you think that you deliberately misread the book

People who don't like, or can't relate, to Scarlett have been lucky enough to never live in survival mode. She is resilient to a fault maybe, but everyone at her table eats. I also see her as a victim, in a way - having to marry men she doesn't love because there was no other way to feed her family as a society lady those days. I don't get the hate either, was she supposed to just let them starve?

What I think she could have done better - let go of her idealization of Ashley sooner. I think her mind used the romanticism/obsession of him as an escape outlet, something that reminded her of her old life before the war and she clung onto it desperately. They never would've been compatible in the logistics of life, but that false idealism blinded her from having the clarity to appreciate her life as she had built it to be with Rhett.

I love Scarlett as a character, one of my all-time favorite across all genres, but I would dislike her irl, mainly because of her man-hungry nature. Idk how to describe that, English is not my first language.

The way she needs to have male attention, only enjoys male company, throwing herself at Charles and Stuart Tarleton etc.

I really really dislike women who act like that, and my attitude would probably be more akin to India Wilkses lol

I think that if people dislike Scarlett, it's not for any of the reasons you list. Scarlett is selfish, she uses people without thinking twice, and she doesn't care for their feelings. She turns to other people when she needs them, but if she doesn't, she won't pay attention in most cases. This is something none of us want to see in our loved ones. It is quite possible to recognize and admire her courage and resilience, her commitment to Tara, her determination to survive, but these are qualities best admired from afar. Rhett Butler who loved her for many years from afar gives up on their marriage after his feelings have been trampled upon continuously (he is not blameless there, of course, but the fact remains that his love did not survive the close quarters). It's easy to like, appreciate or admire her as a book character (and I do admire many of her qualities), but I can't imagine being friends with her in real life. It takes someone as saint-like as Melanie to love Scarlett and overlook or accept the difficult parts of her, including her contempt for Melanie herself, but Melanies are rare miracles.

I love Scarlett just as she was written 💜 I only wish she and Rhett could have had a happy ending but even that would make the book less poignant.

OP, I think you are preaching to the choir here. Most of this sub is extremely protective of Scarlett, perhaps because she receives so much hate in other corners of the internet.

I do like Scarlett, but to your point, the first time I read the book, my jaw literally dropped when she lied to Frank about Suellen. I hated her in that moment. As for what else she could've done realistically, she could've let Tara go to taxes. 🤷‍♀️ Like Rhett pointed out, she and Melanie jointly owned "Aunt Pitty's"

house and could've taken their families there. Everyone would have survived, if uncomfortably. She also could have at least tried to ask Frank for the money. But Scarlett opts to do the unscrupulous thing. I think that's a major theme of the book. People who not only survive, but thrive, get there by being self-serving and amoral.

Again, I am not a Scarlett hater! But I agree she is deeply flawed. I think to say she is flawless is to misunderstand the story. I also think to say she is pure evil is to misunderstand the story.

I will also agree with others that the hate she gets is often misogynistic. People will talk about how plays with Rhett, Ashley, Frank, etc. without ever considering the man's role in what happens. I will never forget the day (not so long ago) when this one GWTW Facebook group posted the movie clip of Rhett threatening to beat Scarlett with a buggy whip. All of the comments were in the vein of "she deserves it, she was a spoiled brat" and "please whip me Rhett! 😍" Truly insane.

Scarlett should have accept the fact that Ashley will never love her back early. That problem made some of characters, particularly Melanie and Rhett in a bad situation. Like some people have said here, Scarlett should allow Ashley to let him work at the North.

Ashley also toys with Scarlett though. She clings to him because he's the last of her life before the war, but he is always saying he loves her and then claiming his obligations to Melanie and Beau. He knows she likes him and basically seems to enjoy being admired by her so he keeps her on a string with little things he says here and there and then he'll mention Melanie so Scarlett thinks Ashley does love her and that he's just too loyal to leave her meanwhile he would never leave Melanie and he knows he and Scarlett would never work.

She should have kept a formal distance from Ashley once she knew of his engagement to Melanie, instead of shamelessly pursuing and tempting him. She shouldn't have stolen other ladies' fiancés for her own use. She should have respected Ashley's wish to stand on his own feet instead of manipulating him into working for her. She was a dishonest, manipulative, selfish woman who ruined other people's lives. Her only redeeming quality was her strength in facing down danger and deprivation.

But then she would have been a different Scarlett in a different Gone With the Wind!

And yet she's the only reason Ashley has a wife and son to come home to. She keeps them all fed with a roof over their heads. She offers herself up to Rhett to keep that roof over their heads. If SueEllen actually cared about anyone but herself then Scarlett wouldn't have stolen Frank. She HAD to do it to get the money to pay the taxes because she couldn't trust her sister to help them.

Yes, that's all true too. Her wiliness served the people around her as well as herself in extreme adversity. Her sisters would have been hopeless at saving Tara. Melanie was too ill. Ashley was at war. But once they were back on their feet, Scarlett still wouldn't let go of her fantasy-Ashley and manipulated Melanie into guilting Ashley into sticking around.

Ashley also had a habit of leading Scarlett on and telling her he loved her (even after he was married) and then claiming he couldn't be disloyal to Melanie. It made Scarlett think he actually loved her and they would be together if he hadn't married Melanie meanwhile Ashley just liked the attention from Scarlett even though he knew they would never work and he truly loved Melanie. She kept him close because of the fantasy of them he helped build in her mind. Also don't forget he's older than her (not as much of an age gap as with Rhett, but still…) so when the book begins she's an innocent 16 year old and he's 21 and she's only 3 years older when she marries Frank and manipulates Ashley into staying (not that I think Ashley would've done

well as a banker up North and Melanie would've been unhappy). How much blame can you really put on her shoulders though as a traumatized 19 year old? Even though Scarlett wouldn't admit it she and Melanie had grown close and yes it was partly to keep Ashley around, but it was also partly to preserve any piece of her life before the war that she had and that was Ashley and Melanie.

Yes, he loved Scarlett and had weak moments when he kissed her and was tempted to run away with her. That's probably one reason why he wanted to take a job in the North, to get away from daily contact with Scarlett and be honourable to his wife. If Scarlett were an honourable woman she would have let him go. It was wrong of her to try to control him. Yes, she saved Melanie's life and all that, but this was a new chapter for all of them. You don't own a person for life because you've helped them in wartime.

She's a 19 year old with PTSD married to a much older man to save her home and the only people who actually like her are going to move away. Is it right that she manipulates Ashley into staying? Probably not. Did she have a right to want them to stay close after all she did for them instead of leaving her surrounded by people who can't stand her? Yeah … especially when it deeply benefited them also. I never honestly see it as her just wanting Ashley. Melanie is the only person who stands by her no matter what throughout the whole book. They have more scenes and a stronger bond with each other than with all the men. Melanie looked at Scarlett as her sister and loved her. And Scarlett loved Melanie too even though she didn't admit it until the end. Imagine 19 year old Scarlett in Atlanta surrounded by all those women that hated her without Melanie around?

Yes, that's another angle. The book and the movie portray some of the realities of life for women in that time.

I don't dislike Scarlett, but I do recognize that Scarlett has faults.

She is self-serving. She did save her family.

She only saved Melanie, and by extension, Beau to keep Ashley around. She knew if Ashley came home, he would go wherever Melanie was.

If Scarlett "ruined her reputation," she did it to advance her own interests. She danced with Rhett because she was bored, and tired of being in mourning for a man she barely knew, much less loved.

She didn't ruin her reputation as far as taking on a man's role, as it was decided in that era, until she realized that she could make a lot of money doing so. Marrying Frank Kennedy was real shitty in terms of what she did to Suellen, but it wasn't judged as wrong in society in that era. Frank was considered a proper gentleman and women of that era often married for stability or finances.

Sixteen year old Scarlett was written well. Sixteen year old Scarlett was no different inside than post-war Scarlett. She just cared about hiding it to maintain the image that southern belle were supposed to have.

Scarlett was always smart, and always clever. Mammy knew that the way she acted around Ellen and the boys in the county was all an act.

Explain to Rhett that, her figure obviously being something she's openly obsessed with, her reluctance to have another kid is about worrying having a fourth baby will make it impossible to return to that 18-inch figure.

He'd find it ridiculous but not take it personally.

And she doesn't have to admit to caring about him at all in this conversation. She slept with her first two husbands she didn't care about because that's how marriage worked. She never tried to hide her vanity from him before so why start now?

Even if they still ended up having a confrontation about their lack of sex life if it's not about her supposedly saving herself for Ashley it'll go better.

I think I wanted more growth, especially regarding her empathy and compassion.

Not realistic, as that would have been a different heroine; but while I like that this Scarlet exists in literature, I don't like Scarlet, because I met too much versions of her in real life.

Edit: To clarify, I don't mind that she wanted to survive all the shite history thrown at her. That part I liked. But she's selfish in the first chapter, and selfish in the last, and I'm not sure she actually sees any of the people who she cares for. Not as people, who matter just as much as her. I had the misfortune of close encounters with severely narcissistic people, and she reminds me of them too often.

I love Scarlett.

The only thing I can really fault her for is the way she treats her kids, she's definitely not a good mother. However it's also not surprising that a traumatised 15 year old who didn't even know about sex wouldn't immediately become a great mother just because she got pregnant, and it's not like she had a choice about having the kids. I do wish she was nicer to Wade and Ella when she was more comfortable, and fairer to them compared to Bonnie.

She's also racist, but it would be miraculous if she wasn't.

She did try at one point- but Wade was timid and Ella was “silly” (prob b/c Scarlett was secretly drinking during her pregnancy- not spelled out but I’d assume) And she did save Charles’ sword b/c it was her boys pride and joy. Not a warm fuzzy mom but she was in survival mode!

Yeah she had the occasional moment, but overall the kids had a tough childhood. I’m not really condemning her because she didn’t choose to have kids, and there’s a decent chance she had some PPD, along with all the war trauma. But I do think there’s an argument that she should have pretended to care about them even if she didn’t really. They’re the only people she doesn’t really come through for.

Conversely, genuinely liking and caring for the kids is one of Rhett’s more redeeming qualities.

Absolutely! And did you get that he and Belle had a child? Off at some boarding school? I thought the actress who played Belle did SUCH a good job!

Is Rhett the kid's father? I don't think that's specified in the book.

It’s not! But they both (separately) refer to having a son who is boarding school in New Orleans so….

To be fair to Scarlett, as well, while Ellen was very kind to everyone, I never felt like she was a particularly loving mother, either. The book makes it clear that she gave up on strong emotions after her cousin was killed in New Orleans, and Gerald was too thrilled that she was going to marry him to notice that anything was missing from her. Scarlett envies the Tarleton girls because they have a fun, loving relationship with their mother, and then she feels guilty for comparing Mrs Tarleton to Ellen and thinks she's being disloyal.

She didn't really know HOW to be loving with the children (though she never really bothered to learn) -- I was frustrated with her for being jealous that Melanie was so loved by the children, despite the fact that she

never wanted to spend the time and effort that Melanie did (and excused herself because she was working outside the house and Melly wasn't).

Ellen did seem a bit emotionally distant. However I think Gerald was a fun parent, and overall Scarlett wasn't nearly as emotionally neglected as her kids were. I do love Scarlett and I'll make all sorts of excuses for her, heck I think stealing Frank from Suellen was genius. But poor little Wade being actively scared of his mother is just a bit too much for me.

Gerald was a fun dad, but really he was always like another child for Ellen to manage. Scarlett was never afraid of her parents -- she actively didn't take Gerald seriously, and she was only ever worried that Ellen would realise what she was really like and be disappointed -- unlike poor Wade, who was his father made over.

Why do you think stealing Frank from Suellen was genius? IMO Frank and Suellen really loved each other, but were too "clumsy" to do anything about it. She could have pushed them to marry and help a little with advice, so that he would earn enough to pay taxes for Tara. Butler would have come sooner or later and they would have had enough money to return it to Frank.

Because they needed the money for Tara's taxes. Suellen was never going to help the rest of the family, so Scarlett did what she had to.

She was raised on a plantation with farm animals. She would have known about sex and reproduction.

Animals also lay eggs and eat faeces, you can definitely grow up knowing about animal behaviour not applying it all to humans.

I don't think her mother ever let her and her sisters witness anything like that.

When Mrs Tarleton is discussing horse breeding with Gerald in the carriage on the way to the barbecue, Scarlett notes that Ellen would never have wanted the girls to even be present for such a conversation. Plus Scarlett wasnt actually working with the farm animals herself before the war. So yeah, I dont really think she learned much about that from the animals.

No, but she would not have been ignorant either. The book describes Scarlett and the Tarleton twins as not soft and pampered.

It's easy to go along with oppression of other people when it directly benefits you, but that doesn't mean no one ever resists that temptation. Sarah and Angeline Grimke were born to a slaveholder father and learned better.

I don't dislike Scarlet at all

Not married several men for all the wrong reasons including Rhett. Seen far earlier that Ashley wasn't the man she initially thought he was.

She had so much drive and she wasn't unintelligent. She was stuck on all the wrong things and holding herself back. I know the time she grew up in limited women's choices but had she made better choice she could have been much happier.

Of course if she had we wouldn't have the book we have full of drama and conflicts..

There are parts of the various sequels that I don't like especially Scarlett but the one thing that felt right to me was Scarlett finally leaving the South and traveling to Ireland.

I could really see her doing that. She never struck me as a woman who wouldn't leave a life that constrained her for a better one. Of course those novels always have her ending up choosing badly in terms of her romantic life again but the premise of her seeking a better life there makes a lot of sense to me.

If she had not gotten Frank killed or leased convicts. But even so, I really like her no hate here.

She was not a good mother and did not seem to concern herself with them until Bonnie. That said, she was a strong woman who took care of others.

I do NOT hate Scarlett

But my own empathy and Allegiance is with : Mammy and every hardworking caring open-minded future-focused slave/PERSON and child in the entire Book and Movie

She doesn't need to do anything different because I like her as she is.

Care more of others and not just herself.

I liked her 😜

I grew up with GWTW and idolizing Scarlett, then got to be a mid- to older teen and disliked her, and then as an adult capable of conceptualizing all the trauma, I'm back to loving her.

As an even older adult, lol, able to really feel how young she was, and all the responsibility she had, damn. Is she flawed? 100%— she is a realistic human. Do I shake my head at some of her worse choices? Absolutely. Damn near everything about Ashley is like GIRL PLEASE. So many things about Rhett, up and including "wow it's like I'm in love with him lol!" Like!!!!! Scarlett!!!! Come on!!! (She is very much "my feelings are none of my business" 99% of the time, which I get as a Capricorn and eldest daughter, but also… just a little self awareness. A smidge.)

But I love her!

I think the best comment I heard about the book is that it's a story about choices, and how each choice has consequences whether good or bad.

Scarlett is more intelligent and resilient than people give her credit for, even those she socializes with in the book. Each choice she makes, it is made to benefit herself, and by extension at times her family. I do think a lot of her choices LATER were a trauma response, a large portion of that needing to be the resilient one, the one making sure everyone survived and didn't starve. And her selfishness during reconstruction takes on a new form because of her trauma and struggle. It also leads her to even more so doing what she wants and society be damned, because she does not want to have to depend on anyone, which results in her pushing people away even more than before the war.

Yes, Scarlett is not always a likable character, but you also have to love and respect her for doing what she needed to do to survive. Even if a lot of those choices I do believe later became detrimental.

Gosh, now I need to read this book again. Haha

I still love her

To answer your title : Nothing! I love Scarlett.

Yes, she's complex and flawed, but that what makes her interesting. She's the only anti-heroine I can think of, and definitely the most famous.

I don't think she's a bad person but she has certain psychopathic tendencies which I don't mean as an insult but rather as a medical truth. She understands social settings well and is able to adjust her behaviour very well, in a rather calculated way. This combined with the way she never, ever feels any remorse or real sympathy to anyone except her parents, to me, portrays a character I would never ever would like to be friends with. She only sees people as a source of the benefits they can give her which is just not something normal. Real people do not communicate with each other that way, or at least, not to that extreme.

I'm not talking about the stairs incident by the way, that was purely self-defense. I'm talking about little things and moments that make her almost inhumane - they way she doesn't feel even the slightest stab of guilt towards Melanie who's married to the man she so desperetaly wants. The way she listens to a horrific story by Granda Fontaine who'd have anyone feel respect, sympathy and interest in this strong, fascinating old lady but all Scarlett could think of was how bored she was. The way she thinks her younger sister Carreen is crazy for loving her beau the way she did.

All of these and more just portray a character who's extremely out of touch with the emotional side of life. She's like a baby who's good at business and protecting her family but not very good at anything else. I'm having an extremely hard time understanding why Rhett loved her the way he did (and by the end of the novel, it seems that Rhett himself has the same sentiment). Maybe it was like her loving Ashley, mainly motivated by how he could not have her for such a long time.

Please let me know if I'm missing something but I think that's the reason people don't think she's likeable, not because she shot a soldier who was likely to rob her.

A lot of her "heartless" decisions were made put of survival, trying to keep her entire family and a bunch of extended relatives afloat financially when Frank was useless at providing for their family. The thing that bothered me was her obsession with Ashley and inability to appreciate Rhett and Melanie. Particularly after Rhett married her, she didnt have to do ruthless things out of financial necessity anymore, and she barely had any positive interactions with Ashley to fuel her obsession with him. Frequently I will stop reading shortly after she marries Rhett and pretend that they lived happily ever after, instead of all the stuff that does happen in the later part of the book.

Scarlett's flaws - OMG (so many)

Why did she marry her sister's finance, she didn't even like him, she just did it for money (to save Tara).She didn't care about him or about his feelings or about her sister's feelings.

She didn't love Ashley at all.She was stalking him. He could have been a teacher or something similar and he and Melanie would live their life.And when he was available, she wasn't interested any more.

She used Melanie, pretending to visiting her in Atlanta, but only wanted to be around Ashley. 4.Used other people, sometimes not being kind to slaves, only caring about money.

What I don't blame her for: 1 Her first marriage. she was so young, only 16. And he was at least married with the woman of his dreams, before he died,and he had a child. 2.Rhett Butler - he is not a very moral man - although they are similarin some ways and attracted to each other, I understand that' she is ambivalent about him.

She should have stopped pining after Ashley after she learned he decided to marry Melanie.

Really, marrying Charles was a terrible decision, but it was her marriage to him that led her to interact more with Rhett. I think if everything else still happened, it would have ended with her actually realizing she loves Rhett early on and her marriage to him would have been a better one.

Nothing. Scarlett is the best

Okay I get you hate Scarlett and I could prob give you reasons for why she did all the things she did, but please explain how marrying Frank was wrong?? I get she stole her sister's fiance … so yeah that's wrong, but you said she did it "all to save the plantation"? That was their home and they had no money to go anywhere else while a lot of people were depending on her. SueEllen called Scarlett mean just for making her work the fields so they had food to eat. If Scarlett thought SueEllen wouldn't have just run off with Frank and left them all behind she would have let SueEllen marry him, but knew her sister wouldn't even make sure they had the money to keep a roof over their heads. Is it a shitty thing to do? Sure, but Scarlett was a better person than SueEllen. Desperate times make people do desperate things. Her original plan was to sell herself to Rhett to get the money. Meanwhile SueEllen just whined about calluses on her hands. I never felt bad for her.

T15 The only likable character

I found Scarlett O'Hara to be the only likable character in Gone with the Wind Is she a piece of shit? Absolutely. Is she a sociopath? It's very likely. Is she one of the worst fictional mothers of all time? At least top 10. Scarlett was Southern Belle Cersei Lannister before Cersei ever existed.

However, every single character of Scarlett's social class is also an absolute piece of shit including Melanie Hamilton. Melanie weeps over the idea of her son having to go to an integrated school, Rhett kills a Black man for being uppity, one character is written as dashing and gallant while going on a long tired about "the apes taking over" after he violently killed a former slave, one "wise maternal figure" explains away the presence of interracial children on plantations as a result of promiscuity on the part of female slaves, every man in her social circle are members of the KKK, etc. They are all presented as good and virtuous people, even Rhett to some degree. I get the time period it was written in and I understand the author's upbringing. I'm not saying the book should be cancelled. However, justifications for Scarlett's inhumanity aren't constantly shoved down my throat like the other characters making her the most tolerable character in the story.

She's also arguably the best human out of all of them or at least the least hypocritical. There's a moment where everyone gets pissy and self righteous about the fact she uses poor Whites for cheap labor in her factories and she points out that they were all slave owners.

She hates everyone equally and would shit on anyone to achieve her goals, very progressive.

there is a moment in the book that I feel like it totally explains Scarlett's character. I can't recall the exact words but Scarlett and Rhett were having a conversation. Scarlett said there would come a time were she could be a great mother, a sweet wife and generally a better person - after all the bad things are resolved and when she would have enough money. And Rhett then answered, that this time would come but then she wouldn't be able to be a better person anymore. He made this parallel that touched me deeply and said when you empty a ship in order to save it from sinking, the things you through away are lost forever - meaning kindness, sweetness etc.

I always felt for Scarlett. She was in fight or flight mode for so long, she couldn't go back to normal. The only thing she remembered from before was her childish feeling for Ashley and all else were veiled under her need to survive.

However, I don't agree with the term "bad mother". She was definetely not a very emotional mother- but she struggled for the wellbeing of her children. It seemed that there was always the need to do better- she felt discomfort that she couldn't be more loving. Yet, there is a moment when she insists on keeping Charle's sword when the Yankis arrived to Tara. She did that just for her son and I feel that was honestly very brave of her, especially considering how distant she was from him till then- it showed love, a love she didn't knew that she had for him until she had to defend him. Also, she was in complete shock when Bonnie died, it was honestly heartbreaking how bad she felt- that's why I didn't take her words about Ella too literate. Everyone has their own love language and Scarlett is surely the type of person that will show love only when protecting someone or supporting someone. You need to remember people then had a different mentality and we are reading her intimate thoughts. She has been through so much that her sensitivity turned to coldness in order to survive and protect those around her.

She was more a father than a mother, that I will admit.

I don’t think she as a sociopath, she did care about her mother, sisters, her children.

She literally stole her sister's fiance for money. I have 2 sisters, but I wouldn't do that for ANYTHING. I don't see how her plotting and conniving to marry what's his name (sorry it's been a few years since I've read it) is very caring towards her sister but I'm interested in why you think she cares for her sisters and how she shows it. (I hope this comment doesn't come across as rude as that is not my intention) I always felt like Scarlett cared about herself more than anyone and I believe she cared deeply for her mother and father. I think as she aged and matured, she definitely cared for her children and realized she loved Rhett, but that's about it.

Well, she didn’t send her sisters to her maternal aunts. She paid for their expenses in Tara. She sent money to her mother’s sisters too. Regarding sisters, I guess you love your while Scarlett didn’t have much love for hers. But some sense of family loyalty. Still, without her efforts her sisters and Melanie would have hardly survived that post war time.

She searched for food for her family, she learnt how to milk a cow, she made a plan how to gather resources for survival. I think that deserves respect.

Scarlett O'Hara is one of my favourite literary characters of all time. She's practical in every way except for Ashley. She just takes in what is going on around her and just does her best to make it work. She has grit and determination and just moves with the times while those around her just lament the loss of their old ways. She just charges through and it's brilliant.

I love Scarlett O’Hara. When people call her sociopathic they seem not to notice that she’s living in a war zone and in unsafe conditions that she was not taught to navigate for years. She also takes on the responsibility for the wellbeing of others that she was not obligated to. And if she hadn’t many of these people (Melanie especially) might not have survived. Her ability to think for herself and adapt is admirable. People who can’t separate her inner strength and resolve from the cultural context and mindset of the time are going to miss out one of the most compelling characters

The Civil Rights Act of 1964 is the law of the land. Segregation & racial discrimination are illegal. It's 2021. Hate to burst your bubble lol.

What are you even on about? You can admire Scarlett's hardheadedness and other personality traits without admiring her racism.

What are you talking about?

I think they said the same thing to me about "bursting your bubble". Apparently liking Scarlett somehow means you're a racist.

the least hypocritical

This was always my take on the principle conflict of the story - either you can be a hypocrite in order to fit in with society or you can insist on being yourself no matter what, and be willing to suffer the consequences of not being accepted.

I agree they all have their awful qualities (though I think it makes them more interesting characters), but I am confused as to how you can classify Melanie as an absolute piece of shit for not wanting her son to go to an integrated school while calling Scarlett likable. I mean, she spends so much time talking about how stupid and helpless "Negroes" are - much more so than Melanie. She's undoubtedly, unquestionably racist, as are the rest of the characters. That being said, I totally agree with you that she's the only character who isn't hypocritical about her actions, and I do love that about her character.

I do think what you're talking about though is exactly what makes GWTW such a fascinating book. All of these characters have these huge moral failings, but that was very much a reality of the south during that time period. There were plenty of perfectly nice, kind, friendly folks.... who also were horribly racist. That doesn't excuse their behavior at all, but it does stir up a lot of questions about good, evil, human nature, etc.

I dislike Melanie the most because she is the most annoyingly dishonest and unbelievable character. You can’t be a “perfectly nice“ member of the Ku Klux Klan in my opinion. Scarlett is a horrible person but at least the author seems to understand that and doesn’t excuse it. GWTW presents an idealized image of the antebellum south. Scarlett‘s the only real thing in the entire book.

You can’t be a “perfectly nice“ member of the Ku Klux Klan in my opinion.

But that's exactly what this book is showing: You can, at least in the sense that these kinds of people were friendly, caring, and sweet... towards everyone who wasn't "lesser" than them. What makes characters like those in GWTW so interesting is exactly how they can be that way, so blind to the idiocy of their hypocrisy and capable of turning that compassion on and off seemingly at will.

Of course those people aren't truly "perfectly nice," but they are to those who they believe are their equals.

These people weren't just racist. They were slave owners who inflicted unspeakable acts against other human beings.

I mean, yeah, but they were also racist, and that's what I'm specifically talking about here: the blatant racism in Melanie not wanting her son to go to an integrated school (your example) and the racism in Scarlett continually referring to Black people as children who aren't capable of caring for or managing themselves.

GWTW presents an idealized image of the antebellum south.

What would you say is idealized? I think every character in the book represents a very real type of person from the south in those days, but you're right in that most of them, like most of the characters in the book, were wildly hypocritical in their beliefs.

> What would you say is idealized?

The devoted slaves that are written as lazy, childlike and completely content with their lot in life is a starting point. They are horrific caricatures. You're giving Margaret Mitchell too much credit. It's one thing to create racist characters and another to shape the narrative in a way that justifies their outlandish beliefs.

I think one thing you're neglecting to consider is that this book was clearly not meant to be written from a completely objective point of view. Margaret Mitchell undoubtedly was racist and did share a lot of these beliefs, but they're also a reflection of what the main character actually does believe, which is that the slaves around her are devoted, childlike, and content (which is why I was confused as to how you could write off Melanie while defending Scarlett even though both are blatantly racist in that sense). I think it's fair to say the book is a mix of both - some of Mitchell's genuinely racist beliefs and some of her novelized depictions of many similar beliefs.

The false narratives that present newly freed Black men as mindless rapist and all northerners as mustache twirling villains in order to justify the creation of the kkk is another one.

I mean, those narratives actually did exist in the south; those are things that real people - like those in the novel - actually believed. And undoubtedly there were genuine attacks like the ones on Scarlett that may have given people further cause to believe the KKK was the answer. I can't say that for sure, but I would be shocked if no newly freed slave ever committed any attack on any white women at any point during the time frame depicted, so it doesn't seem unusual to me to have the author depict how those kinds of instances might have led people to the idea that newly freed slaves were all lurking behind every corner waiting to jump out and attack women. I mean, look at how people on the right talk about immigrants today. A handful of real attacks blows up into what they believe is a genuine national emergency, even though it's nonsense.

shape the narrative in a way that justifies their outlandish beliefs.

How would you say she does this?

She was just as racist and delusional about the antebellum south as the characters she created.

That's actually another part of what makes it such an interesting book to me. It feels meta in a way, like Mitchell can identify Scarlett's flaws enough to novelize them but still somehow reflects them herself.

I'm sure that Margaret Mitchell absorbed, almost by osmosis, the racist attitudes that were prevalent among (sadly) most whites of the South and face it, all too many in the North in that era. But one intriguing thing that she did shortly before she died was to fund scholarships for the education of 20 students at the historically black Morehouse College. Perhaps, hopefully she was evolving in her thinking and coming to see the light about race relations. If she had lived, I wonder if she would have met with Dr. Martin Luther King as he lived right there in Atlanta too.

Oh interesting, I didn't know that! It would be great to think she had evolved some in that way before her death.

The KKK before 1915 (the second rendition) was more complicated than history would have you know.

They were racists, but that was common all across the country. The majority of opposition to slavery from the north did not come from abolitionists, but those concerned with racial amalgamation.

"In the South, where slavery still exists, the Negroes are less carefully kept apart; they sometimes share the labors and the recreations of the whites; the whites consent to intermix with them to a certain extent, and although legislation treats them more harshly, the habits of the people are more tolerant and compassionate. In the South the master is not afraid to raise his slave to his own standing, because he knows that he can in a moment reduce him to the dust at pleasure. In the North the white no longer distinctly perceives the barrier that separates him from the degraded race, and he shuns the Negro with the more pertinacity since he fears lest they should some day be confounded together.

Among the Americans of the South, Nature sometimes reasserts her rights and restores a transient equality between the blacks and the whites; but in the North pride restrains the most imperious of human passions. The American of the Northern states would perhaps allow the Negress to share his licentious pleasures if the laws of his country did not declare that she may aspire to be the legitimate partner of his bed, but he recoils with horror from her who might become his wife.

Thus it is in the United States that the prejudice which repels the Negroes seems to increase in proportion as they are emancipated, and inequality is sanctioned by the manners while it is effaced from the laws of the country. But if the relative position of the two races that inhabit the United States is such as I have described, why have the Americans abolished slavery in the North of the Union, why do they maintain it in the South, and why do they aggravate its hardships? The answer is easily given. It is not for the good of the Negroes, but for that of the whites, that measures are taken to abolish slavery in the United States." - Alexis de Tocqueville, Democracy in America, 1835"

Had slavery remained like it did in Brazil then most of the south would not be pure white which goes against the WASP ethnic society behind the founding fathers. They were open to exploiting blacks, but not to welcoming them into the social order which is what happened in the south.

The same union soldiers who fought in the south went on to fight in the plain wars to remove the Indians. This was instigated in 1862 by the pacific railway act and was overseen by Stanton who was general secretary under Lincoln. They were emancipationists who wanted to return slaves to Africa, and eventually remove the Indian population.

"Major General H. W. HALLECK,

Chief of Staff of the Army, Washington, D. C.:

GENERAL; I received yesterday an order from the Adjutant-General's Office assigning the Sixth Minnesota Volunteers, now in this department on duty to the Second Corps, in the Army of the Potomac. I do not write to object to the order, but only to ask a suspension of its execution for a time. My reasons are, that if this regiment be removed from the Minnesota frontier before the new posts are fairly established and the expedition meet the Indians, there will be trouble and excitement on the frontier amongst the inhabitants which may entirely defeat our movements. There seems little doubt of a formidable concentration of the most powerful of the Sioux bands at some point on the upper Missouri. General Sully can only take into the field at most 1,200 men. i have directed Sibley to send him 1,600 men from Minnesota, which will give Sully about 2,800 men, by no means too many if the Indians make battle. Sibley is left with only 700 men on the Minnesota border, and they will be necessary for a time to keep the frontier settlers from abandoning

settlements, precipitating themselves in the river towns, and spreading dismay and excitement through the State.

The result will be that the Department in Washington will be overwhelmed with petitions and remonstrances, and our whole military operations, which now promise Final Solution of the entire Indian question on the northern plains, be brought to naught. As soon as I possibly can do so (and I am sure, general, the Department will acquit me of andy fault hitherto in forwarding troops to the South) I will send this regiment en route for this corps on the Potomac. Unless I considered it essential to our success I would not think of keeping the regiment a day, and I hope still to send it off very shortly. In this connection, I send you extract from letters received from General Sibly, from which you will perceive the difficulties under which I have labored, and in fact, do still. Unless otherwise directed, I will suspend the execution of the order to the Sixth Minnesota for the present.

I am, general, respectfully, your obedient servant,

John Pope was demoted to slaughtering Indians after he failed in the second battle Bull Run (In Manassas, Virginia).

Segregation ended around 1965 with the passing of the immigration bill which pretty much signified the end of the USA as a anglo-saxon/celtic nation.

Having black slaves institutionalized in a household meant intermixing and a general lack of segregation. Notice that the union policy in the occupied south was the first to enforce 'Jim Crow' segregation laws which were based on the black codes in Illinois. Mitchell came of age after reconstruction and the original KKK whom did not wear those iconic white hats or burning crosses.

Under reconstruction the goal of the union was to inflame racial tensions in the south to really jumpstart what was later called the Nadir of racial relations.

However the first KKK was simply a paramilitary force of ex-confederates to fight union occupiers and they recruited many freed blacks. This was mentioned in the congressional subcommittee report in 1871:

"In November, 1871 they interviewed a “colored” man named Washington Willis. In his testimony Mr. Willis states that he knew black men who rode with the local Klan. And he states that he himself was recruited to join that local Klan “before they rode for the first time.” He was approached by a Klan member who happened to be his former master, the reason being that Washington had recently been the victim of someone killing his cow and stealing his cotton. Naturally it was assumed it was men carrying out Brownlow’s strategy."

Again, I know this is a 2 year old comment, but YES! Mammy acts like the "damn yankees" might as well be the devil and the slaves all are supposed to be for the confederacy to the point where it's almost like it's satirical. Like you said, they are horrific caricatures. Of course they don't want to be slaving away at Tara...makes me want to bash my head into a wall.

I had a collector's book that went into detail about Ms Mitchell's influences for the book...and she often sat on the fat, slick laps of confederate grannies talking about the old days and the war, their experiences, etc.

You can imagine a kid...even a teenager mesmerized by such imagery that they felt compelled to write about it. Inspiration doesn't often come from hatred or bigotry towards others, but rather life experiences or even the life experiences of others out of pure fascination.

No doubt those confederate grannies made the South sound glorious and glamorous to Ms Mitchell, and it greatly influenced the overall feel of the book.

Did you know that slavery has existed since the beginning of time, in every culture and still does? I wonder why people have such an issue specifically with the American South? Northerners didn't view blacks as their equals either. No one did. You do realize that the past really can't be judged thru the lens of 2024 or whenever you wrote this? It's very silly to do so and very myopic.

I know this is 2 years old, but I agree about Melanie. I can't stand Scarlett, but at least she's real. Melanie is so overly sweet and sappy that it's obvious she's totally fake, and yes, she is massively racist. The only thing i can respect about Scarlett is that she does what she wants and refuses to give up or let anyone or anything stop her while Melanie lies in bed for what feels like half the book. Because she had a friggin baby. Scarlett is scolded for wanting to get out of bed "too soon" after the birth of her first baby because it's "unladylike." I've given birth 3 times, and give me a break. I swear Melanie is in bed for what feels like a damn year after her son is born.

I think that Rhett Butler also saw through a lot of the hypocrisy and self-delusion of the Southerners. Especially in the scene at the Wilkes' barbecue when he tells the other men the many reasons why the South doesn't stand a chance of winning against the North. But he does have his contradictions like when he leaves Scarlett alone on the road to Tara to join the Confederate Army in their last ditch attempt to fight the Union Troops. Or later when he sucks up to the old biddies of Atlanta like Mrs. Merriweather and Mrs. Meade so that his daughter Bonnie will be accepted by the remnants of the old "society" families.

I loved Scarlett O'Hara; she found herself in a new world for which she was not prepared and did whatever it took to survive. She changed w/the changing times--as did Rhett Butler, another of my favorites--while the rest of the characters--Melanie Wilkes, noble though she may have been, Ashley Wilkes, Scarlett's family members, the townspeople of Atlanta, even their servants--refused to do so, still clinging to their old, pre-Civil War ways. Scarlett & Rhett were outcasts of Atlanta society (although Rhett eventually worked his way back to respectability) because they refused to conform.

Of course everyone in the book was racist--we're talking 1861-1873 Atlanta, even the black slaves (and later free slaves) had their own caste systems among them. But that's they way people behaved/thought/acted back then; they saw nothing wrong with it, they knew nothing else. I know a lot of people don't like the novel for that reason, but it's an accurate representation of the lifestyle & attitudes (right or wrong) at that place and time. I love GWTW, I first read it at age 12 after seeing the movie and it has remained one of my favorite books of all time (and this is coming from a reader who almost always reads non-fiction).

Do you have any favorite books written by African American authors?

only memoirs, except for Their Eyes Were Watching God by Zora Neal Hurston, which I read in college and enjoyed. Not sure if you're interested in memoirs, but here's my list:

Having Our Say: The Delany Sisters' First 100 Years (1993) by Amy Hill Heart, Sarah Louise Delany and Anne Elizabeth Delany

Losing My Cool (2010) by Thomas Chatterton Williams

Black on Red: My 44 Years Inside the Soviet Union (1988) by Robert Robinson

Can't Hurt Me: Master Your Mind and Defy the Odds (2018) by Dave Goggins

Gifted Hands (1990) by Ben Carson

Black Boy (1945) by Richard Wright

Autobiography of Malcolm X (as told to Alex Haley) (1964)

Roots (1976) by Alex Haley

My Grandfather's Son (2008) by Clarence Thomas

A Piece of Cake: A Memoir (2007) by Cupcake Brown

Only memoirs? Ben Carson and Clarence Thomas. Yeah. Ok. No James Baldwin, Maya Angelou, Octavia Butler (if you are truly interested in humanities)? Sounds like poorly curated reading to undermine your entire "I'm really not a racist, but..." argument.

Agreed. I was shocked Maya Angelou wasn't on their list.

Very true. Sadly, Mitchell's depictions of the racial attitudes of that time are all too accurate. And yes I know that there were many Abolitionists in the North. There were even some in the South too, risking ostracism, or worse, even from their own families. While some may want a "Bridgerton-style" re-imagining of GWTW, the historical record of racial attitudes is pretty bleak. Think of "12 Years a Slave". If the white people of Atlanta and elsewhere had been as progressive and --much as I hate to use the word-- "woke" back then as we fancy ourselves being today, the present situation for people of color would be much better than it is nearly two decades into the 21st Century.

She used convicts from the state prison.

I love Scarlett. I think a lot of people have more parts of scarlett in them then they'd like to believe 😂 also she saved her family from starving. For me, her ends justified the means.

This is a question that I have not heard asked, and I have not found the answer in the book. With Ashley marrying his cousin Melanie, why was he spending all his time with Scarlet at Tara? Why wasn't he in Atlanta spending time with Melanie?

I absolutely love Scarlett O'Hara.

I personally loathe Scarlett O'Hara

Depends on the author & his/her works. They're some really likeable, even lovable classics in the world to say the least. And they're NOT racist either!!

Eh, depends! There's a lot of books in the historical Western canon that aren't racist because they simply don't deal with characters of color, at all. That doesn't mean their authors weren't racist or didn't hold (at least by modern standards) racist beliefs.

I can't speak a lot about outside the Western canon but most societies have struggled and continue to struggle with racism/xenophobia (even if very different than what we have now) so I'd be surprised to see a canon that doesn't reflect that to some degree, honestly.